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IIH Step I

Mental Level

Preliminary Comments: It is important in Bardons book to master each exercise before going on to the next one. Over time, you also increase your mastery over the beginning exercises. An exercise you do for five minutes in chapter 1 you extend to fifteen minutes or a half hour by chapter 8.

The exercises of each chapter--the mental, psychic, and physical levels--must also be mastered together before going on to the next chapter. This enables a student to avoid running into severe karmic difficulties due to a one-sided development.

Keep a careful record of your practices and make them a habit. Some things are best learned through repeated practice. The training will require your greatest commitment and highest spiritual will.

Do not become discouraged. Realize, however, that this line of practice is possibly the most difficult thing on earth to master. After all, in book one you are preparing to internalize in yourself the essence of all spiritual wisdom and power that exist on this planet.

If you get stuck somewhere, do not despair. The exercises are set up to reinforce each other. And there is always someone around who can assist you. Internet puts us into touch with practitioners from around the world.

And just about every single exercise in Bardons book has been made into a life long practice by someone. The practitioners of various religious or spiritual training systems often take a variation of one or more of these techniques and treat them like an onion. They carefully peel layer after layer until they arrive at the wisdom in its core. They then honor this achievement as the final realization of their system. The depths to which they go to accomplish their objectives can be appreciated

by a magician without having to adopt the limited goals and cultural values underlying their methods.

For example, various cognitive psychologists love studying mental processes and how thoughts influence behavior (a chapter 1 mental exercise). In Chinese Chi Kung, they love practicing breathing and circulating energy through the body (a chapter 1 physical exercise).

One of the most difficult exercises in Bardon is attaining magical equilibrium beginning with introspection. But the practitioners of a system developed from the writings of Carlos Castaneda try to recall in detail their entire life. Ira Progoff, who works with intensive journal, carefully guides his students to become conscious of the psychic threads which form the pattern and stream of energy shaping their outer lives.

As fascinating as many training systems are, they do not try to understand all aspects of human nature quite like a magician. The magician seeks to reflect and harmonize within his own soul the larger universe and all the powers within it. But the great training systems of the earth do offer insight and exploration of specific truths. A magician will understand the universal aspect of these many procedures and identify them as steppingstones he can utilize, at his own discretion, as he moves towards the mastery of the akashic plane of our planet.

I add here a few paragraphs from my essay on the four planes: My kids sometimes ask about magick. I tell them that in regard to Bardon's practices, the concept he has of basic mastery is a spiritual ideal in itself: Bardon expects you to have 1. The mental clarity of an advanced Zen master--that is, a mind empty like a mirror and sharp as a diamond. When you concentrate on something you easily focus without any distraction whatsoever so there is nothing else in your consciousness. 2. The concentration and artistic imagination of Stephen Spielberg. Spielberg can visualize each scene in a movie including camera angles. He can hear the intonations in the voices of the characters and see the emotions they portray. He can do all of this before he begins shooting.

3. The ability to understand personal problems from a universal perspective as one or two Ph.D.s in transpersonal psychology might impart. 4. The level of vitality and chi possessed by a sixth dan aikido sensei or a fourth generation tai chi master. 5. The qualities of a successful individual in any profession: His life must be organized. He must be free of needless distractions. He must have rugged endurance, patience, self-motivation, and determination. And, like those at the top of any profession or career, he must love his work with all his mind, heart, and soul. And these abilities and attitudes Bardon expects you to somehow acquire before you move on to working with higher spirits.

I mention these five points because they represent skills present in professions which are already part of our society. There is absolutely nothing secret or esoteric about them. They are the powers of creative imagination acquired and applied through hard work and commitment. The first step in magick is not withdrawal. It is to internalize some of the creativity which already surrounds us.

Introduction to Mental Plane Exercises

The goal of the mental plane exercises will be to master your own mind. This will involve observing your own thought processes and controlling your thoughts. Inherent in this process is the development of our imagination. For example, Bardon emphasizes being able to concentrate to the extent we can recreate mentally anything we can experience sensually through our five senses. This mental agility and resilience is the basis for developing psychic abilities as well as being able to understand the minds of animals, other human beings, and spirits as well.

Another goal of the mental training is to be able to move freely

between our physical world and various realms on the inner planes and to do so comfortably so that we avoid various dangers and temptations. In entering the sphere of elemental beings, the various degrees of the astral plane, and the akashic level of the earthzone, our minds will enter environments which offer no support for our five senses. There are no familiar sensory impressions similar to what we encounter in everyday life. To be fully conscious and to perceive on these planes, our minds will need great clarity and penetrating intuition. Before this can happen we have to strengthen our mental abilities and become conscious of everything which influences our perception and imagination.

In fact, the mind of a magician is meant to comprehend with ease the thoughts of a sinner or a saint, a fool or a wise man, an autistic individual or a genius, a salamander who commands a volcano to erupt or an undine who dwells in the depths of the seas, a spirit who guides the destinies of the nations or one who can resolve any conflict on this planet, heal any disease, or transform any karma. Bardón's training system is this demanding and this complete.

The task of a student, then, will be to take these exercises, however difficult and unfamiliar, and somehow to make them his own so they become second nature. Therefore, consider making the first book a life long friend. Return to it again and again. The teachings of the elemental beings and many spirits of the earthzone and other spheres often take these basic exercises and expand on them.

These spirits increase your power and heighten your concentration. They introduce into human nature a planetary and cosmic perspective building on your current understanding. As in any academic curriculum, however, you have to complete the basics. Otherwise, when you jump into an advanced class you can neither understand nor can you keep up with the lessons.

When, for example, you arrive at the sphere of Venus, these magnificent creatures of beauty will entice you to return to those basic areas which you have failed to master. They make the most simple needs in life seem fantastically interesting. And that is part of their job--to prepare us so we have enough experience that we are ready to make the next step into the sphere of the sun. In the solar sphere, we join ourselves to divinity, to pure light, and become radiant servants of life.

Initiation into Hermetics, Chapter 1, Mental Level

There are four exercises for the mental level in chapter 1. In all of Bardón's exercises, it sometimes helps to imagine you have already mastered the exercise. This is an exercise in imagination. It gives you a chance to feel what it is like to do something you do not yet know how to do. And there is a sense that if you can imagine it then you can get it. The thought or image of already being able to do something creates energy which generates momentum and success.

Exercise 1: Observing your thoughts. Taking the perspective of an alert and silent observer, close your eyes and observe your thoughts. Do this for a minute and work up to five minutes. Try to recall all that happens within your mind.

Comments: This exercise makes you more conscious of your mental body and the processes and contents of your mind. When I first tried this exercise, I felt very odd not only noticing mental events but also trying to remember what had occurred while meditating. I notice, though, that the exercise made my mind sharper and more observant.

I could recall, by the way, up to six separate mental events but six things is about all I can remember. I feel a little odd to be observing mental events and then trying also to remember them as well but I take it that this is also part of the exercise.

If you are alert enough to notice the smallest change in your mental

activity, you also become very observant about what is happening immediately in front of you. All five senses become more alert. It seems natural for me, however, to also become acquainted with other individuals who practiced various kinds of mental control and meditation.

For example, I once sat in a beginning class at a Zen monastery. The teacher had us sitting almost elbow to elbow facing a wall a few feet in front of us. We were to think no thoughts. I noticed right off that if you practice this form of sensory deprivation afterwards a small sensory stimulus feels colorful, enchanting, and full of life.

After the meditation, the instructor debriefed each of us. He wanted to know in detail what had occurred within our minds. There it is again--that expectation that you are to recall what occurred when you were supposed to not be thinking. To be honest, I felt like telling him, "It is none of your business." I did not want to be subject to another individual's influence by letting him know my strengths and weaknesses. I just wanted the discipline and sharing that comes with joining in a group committed to mastering the self. Later on, I did meet a Zen master who never once asked me what I was thinking or tried to teach me anything. He was great for me. I could see directly in his mind what I wanted to learn.

There are advantages and disadvantages to training with others. There is a powerful social pressure when you meditate with individuals on each side of you who can hear the slightest difference in your breathing or notice the smallest change in your posture. When working with a group, you have access to the strengths of the group but also are influenced by its weaknesses and its lack of commitment to universal truths.

Another Buddhist group I was in would sit for an hour, sometimes for all day, and even for thirty day periods practicing ten hours a day. They would focus their minds for many hours on just one thing like the air moving through the nose, the rising and falling of the chest, or the belly. I found this very enjoyable since I was interested in these things. But I noticed also a real problem with the group.

Because I was training as a magician, I could sense their individual brain waves and the general pattern of thoughts in the minds of those in the room. Again, they were practicing a form of sensory deprivation without also training their imagination. Their psychological attitude was of someone going into and sitting in a dark closet. Their minds were bottled up, rigid, and confined rather than open and clear like the sky at night.

Their doctrines told them to limit themselves to observing only those layers of mental vibration which arise out of their body and personality experiences. They did this to prove to themselves that there is no need to be attached to anything. Every thought, feeling, and perception is in flux and subject to change. I did not have a problem with that doctrine. It seemed obvious. I felt they should not stop and limit their concentration practices. I found it natural to concentrate in the same way on the mental vibration within a rock, a tree, the sea, the colors of light, and other minds as well. You master the mind by both understanding and being free of every mental vibration which can occur within it.

Some people suggest viewing passing thoughts as clouds passing through a clear sky. Each time a thought arises you imagine you are seeing it from a distance. You note it but allow it to do whatever it wants without reacting to it. In this way, you acquire a neutrality and detachment.

Many meditation systems assume that it takes years to arrive at a level where thoughts no longer arise. Most monastic settings are fairly tranquil. Some monasteries teach Budo and the martial arts on very high levels and so those develop another part of the brain. In our lower brains is the ancient hunter.

The hunter can track his prey for hours noticing every sign and trace of the trail he is following and this he does without any distractions occurring in his awareness. This aggressive form of concentration is an aspect of power or fire whereas the tranquility approach belongs to the

element of water. It is nice to learn both. Bardon's system happens to emphasize power and will. It is up to the student to find his or her own best approach.

Exercise 2: Mindfulness. This exercise involves being fully attentive to whatever task you are performing without being distracted or letting other thoughts intrude. I imagine there are a number of ways to approach this exercise. Bardon emphasizes you should be able to be fully conscious and alert whether you are at work or engage in something simple and seemingly trivial. You should work at this exercise until it becomes a life long habit. This kind of exercise is common in the Orient and is often referred to as practicing mindfulness.

In Zen, they say words to the effect, "When you tie your shoes, you tie your shoes. When you drink tea, you drink tea." Of course if you are living in a completely artificial environment like a monastery dedicated to practicing austerities you have an atmosphere conducive for cultivating mental discipline. The building, the students, the master, and the daily schedule are like a magical ritual designed to enhance and reinforce very specific kinds of awareness.

Still, it is important to internalize the Zen monastery within oneself. This means being able to focus your entire mental body on whatever you are doing as if this moment is of significance and important--not the activity but whatever you happen to be doing in this moment of time. This practice strengthens the ties between your mind, soul, and body. The mental, astral, and physical are united in your awareness. This opens consciousness to akasha--to a timeless and spaceless state of awareness. It makes anything you do a spiritual activity.

This may not seem very important but it is extremely valuable. It provides support for your consciousness after engaging in the incredible set of explorations of the psyche which Bardon's system encourages. You need to know that when you are done with a psychic or mystical practice you can return to your ordinary consciousness without any part of your awareness being elsewhere. There is nothing allowed to intrude upon or disturb your focus. Most people do not need this skill but a magician does.

Having made my point, I will discuss here and elsewhere why this may cause problems for some individuals. The Bardon system is extremely dangerous, from my perspective, if you overdevelop your mind to the exclusion of your feelings and ability to express adequately your emotions. Often unexpected thoughts, feelings, and sensations may interject themselves into your awareness during the day or night. These may signal deep feelings or intuitions stirring within you which you need to attend to.

Some individuals worry too much or constantly. One way of working with that problem is to set aside a regular time when all you do is worry. In this way, you take charge of whatever is bothering you. You give it the attention it demands.

Similarly, if something is bothering or upsetting you, then it is not a good idea to "exclude" it from your thoughts. This is repression. You can get away with it for days, months, or even years. Eventually, however, either you solve the problem or it will grow strong enough to demand your total attention by undermining your motivation or making your ill showing up in other ways.

Elsewhere I mention that the mind Bardon wants to develop in the student is open like the sky, flowing like water, serene like moonlight, intense like lightning about to strike, radiant like the sun, empty like a void, and so forth. When you develop a high caliber level of concentration, you also have to apply it so it harmonizes your personal life.

For example, I can listen to my wife with a magical level of concentration. My mental body is then like a mirror in which she can see herself more clearly. And she enjoys this attention.

But what she likes a whole lot better is when I change my brain waves to match her own. Then the interactions between the left and right sides of my brain are more rapid. Then thoughts, emotions, and body language are more blended and expressive. In other words, as magicians we are after a mental concentration but one which is flexible and not rigid. Bardon says that the student should be able to change his personality completely upon entering different situations such as being at home versus being at work.

Exercise 3: Attending to one thought or a thought train. In this exercise, focus on one thought or a train of thoughts without any other non-related thoughts intruding. I am about to do my income tax so I could just sort through everything I will need to do to get my taxes done. That would be a thought train. I could pick a simple thought such as my dog or the tree in the backyard. I could focus on an affirmation such as, "I feel a deep sense of inner peace." Bardon does not elaborate on the level or way we are to approach this exercise but it seems fairly straightforward. We already practiced focusing on one activity in exercise two so now we simply focus on one mental activity instead of something physical.

Everyone, of course, already knows how to do this exercise to some extent. Just consider thinking about something you love doing or are emotionally involved with. Your interest alone should be able to keep you focused without distraction. I have sat down at 8 PM playing a computer game and was surprised when I saw sunlight outside the window because time had flown and now it was dawn. The only thoughts in my mind during this time related to the game I was playing. That kind of recreational activity is more a way of being absorbed than it is being alert and conscious but it reminds me of what I am capable of doing. The idea, however, is to train your mind so you have a habit of focusing without distraction.

Exercise 4: Controlling thoughts. In this exercise, practice meditating without any thoughts entering your mind until you can do so for ten minutes.

There is a real advantage to being able to do this. Having an open and empty mind which is fully alert and attentive greatly enhances understanding. It means you can regard something without having to search immediately for a label or concept to explain it. This is a mental ability which you rarely run into. Most people have a mental anxiety which means they have to identify everything as something familiar or else they do not care enough to notice what is in front of them.

Having a mind capable of being empty of thoughts means you can put a lot of things in this mind without causing a reaction. You can then consider a problem from all sides. You hold the entire problem within your mind while remaining completely relaxed and clear. Again, this ability is absolutely essential for a magician.

A magician often deals with unknown experiences and new perceptions. If he tries to label them or make them fit what he believes or already thinks he distorts their content. A clear and empty mind is also a psychic tool. It can receive extremely faint impressions and then amplify them which is like looking at something under a magnifying glass. This is because there is nothing else in your consciousness than what you are focusing upon.

My original notes show I was able to do this exercise after about a month and a half of regular daily practice. I believe, however, it is very easy to lose this emptiness of mind practice once you learn it. You have to keep yourself in shape. It is as easy as breathing for me to stop all thinking for three or four minutes. To do so for ten minutes takes more effort. After working with a few spirits like Jah-Hel of the Mercury sphere, I acquired a taste for meditating for three or four hours at a time. I take a lot of breaks during this time. For example, I write up

what is occurring but everything I write about arises from within an empty mind.

I notice, however, that if I force myself to be free of thoughts there is a strain on my nervous system. Bardon mentions practicing while being relaxed and this took me a long time to learn. It is also easy for me to cheat on this exercise by placing my mind in an akashic trance--a timeless and spaceless state of awareness. In akasha, there is no vibration relating to thinking unless you place it there. But using trance or self-hypnosis to perform this exercise is off track. The idea is to be free of thoughts in a way which is natural, comfortable, and even enjoyable.

As I practice now I notice that my thoughts and mental activities are very distant. They do not even appear as a thought or an idea because I am sensitive to the vibration thinking possesses. I can shun it before it enters the linguistic or mental part of my brain where an action occurs which I label thinking. If you sense the mental vibration you can send it off quickly without deciphering it in terms of a sensory perception or interpreting it in terms of ideas and language, symbols, images, etc. I can also feel each thought as an energy or sensation somewhere in my body usually, e.g., as a faint flash of sensation in my throat or head, etc.

What I am saying here is that not thinking has a certain vibration, energy field, or set of brain waves associated with it. If you can sense that energy field and remain within it you also in effect stop thinking. But this ability came much later in my practice. If I were giving advice to myself when I was first beginning this exercise I would suggest working on my sense of peace, stillness, and feeling a part of the planet earth. Then when I meditate I would be in an emotional and mental state where thoughts do not vibrate.

There are other advantages to getting this exercise. I notice that every time a thought appears it briefly breaks the connection with whatever I am concentrating on or attempting to attune myself with. The mind is like a television set which blinks off or a telephone conversation when static intervenes and obscures the words being spoken.

My mother often says to me when we talk long distance that it sounds like I next door. The connection is excellent through the satellite relays. That is what you want for telepathy, clairvoyance, clairsentience, and magical practices--a crystal clear receptivity and sending capacity. If you make a connection to an elemental being or spirit, you want to be confident that the connection is complete and that there are no interruptions. You want to be able to say, "I am here. Speak to me. What is the answer to my question?"

To receive that answer often takes some time in the beginning because you may be trying to receive into your mind a mental vibration which is different from anything you have experienced before. In order to listen, you have to switch off the mental activity in your own mind so you can receive what is being sent to you.

Of course, many individuals are used to concentrating on a hobby or activity for thirty minutes or longer without a single extraneous thought entering their minds. They are completely involved with what they are doing so that their interest stops all distractions. The empty mind is just the same mental vibration but without a specific content.

For example, I raced sailboats for years and was accustomed to concentrate on the wind interacting with the sail for many hours at a time with an absolute minimum of conversation. When I imagine myself sailing again, I can notice how my concentration intensifies so that I feel nothing else in the world exists but what I am doing. When I close my eyes and keep the concentration without any imagery, this form of concentration is like acid--it dissolves thoughts before they enter my mind. You might try this for yourself by gearing your mind up to a mental level of concentration which you have already developed through some other activity. Then switch back and forth between the activity which engages you and an empty mind.

I would also mention the situation where an Oriental teacher will bring his method of training to Westerners. A Vipassana teacher, e.g., teaches concentrating on breath, the body, the mind and so forth for extended period of time. I know one individual who loves this sort of thing. She feels she has come home by participating in one of these retreats.

But other Americans have some serious difficulties. Though the Vipassana teacher's methods are very clear, he does not in fact teach what many Americans do not have. From his culture in India, he has acquired a wonderful sense of well-being and peace. This is part of his etheric body. He had a love of spiritual things from childhood and the culture supported this kind of endeavor and exploration. But Western culture in many instances has been extremely hostile to inner exploration of the psyche and spirit. To empty your mind is to also allow not only thoughts but powerful emotions to arise. It is as if you are opening a door to a realm whose existence has been denied for thousands of years.

I do not mean to overplay this example but I think you have to feel there is some sort of greater harmony or purpose to which you are connected. Otherwise, an individual may find himself having to deal not with the point of the exercise--controlling thoughts--but with another question: What happens to your identity or to your self when there are no thoughts within the mind? This question is not answered intellectually nor does it belong to the mental body. It belongs to the astral body which will demand of you at some point that you feel loved and supported without having a mental reference point for your identity.

The reason for this is that only in love can individuals let go of identity and undergo transformation without needing to know who they are or know in advance what they are becoming. The great voids and empty spaces within the heart, soul, mind, and spirit are not crossed by those with great will. They are crossed by those who love because love can contain everything within its heart. Bardou, of course, requires an equal development of the physical, astral, and mental bodies.

I would also mention that the earthzone spirit Alosom, 25 degrees Sagittarius, specializes in the magick of silence. I have a write up on my experiences with Alosom on my web page. Silence is not just an empty mind. It has astral and physical qualities. One of the nicest images I got from working with Alosom was of sitting in silence in a room filled with masters from all ages. All of them have an appreciation for silence and the mystery of the earth.

You can also explore the imagery and feeling of a rock, a tree, or a mountain. We do this later on in mental projection in which we identify our consciousness with things in nature. The energies within nature provide a natural support to becoming free of thoughts. I often get the impression from the Bardou gnomes that they could walk through a mountain or a forest for months without thinking a single thought. They are conscious, alert, and perceiving but without any thinking occurring. Gnomes embody the energies of the earth.

A not uncommon problem with heavy mental training is that for some individuals empty mind and sense concentration exercises place too much pressure on their third eyes. The third eye chakra behind the eye brows becomes over energized. They then get headaches, feel tension in their skulls, or find themselves locked into the mental plane.

The remedy, again, is to only concentrate when you are completely relaxed. Try to perfect the state of relaxation so that it is always able to match your magical development. Stay in touch with nature's energies. Study forests and water and air. Keep your astral body charged up with organic energy. Do not allow yourself to be separate from others like a hermit because your concentration is so intense.

Learn to use and appreciate your five senses to the same extent you develop your mental detachment. If necessary, stop practicing magical exercises until you get you reestablish your natural vitality. There were times when I would get headaches from practicing too much. One way I got

rid of those headaches was to go for a walk for thirty minutes in the woods. This allowed the energy in my feet and first chakra to balance and relax the energy in my third eye.

In Kundalini yoga, they often suggest drinking such things as a sweet, milk rich tea. The caffeine, sugar, and milk serve to dissolve the tension in the brain and head. As with any physical side effects you may experience from meditating, the idea is to take it a little slower. Do not be obsessed on concentration exercises. Each individual has a natural rhythm and balance which you do not want to lose by burning out or over doing it. Learn to become sensitive to the onset of problems so you can eventually monitor your own health and vitality in a conscious manner.

In various Hindu yogas such as Hatha yoga, the idea is to first stretch and relax the body while doing slow and steady breathing. This builds up an organic surcharge of vitality in the body. The mind is then able to rest within this relaxed and radiant vitality. In so doing, many of the normal concerns which give rise to thoughts disappear. In this way, the mental body is supported by the energy of the physical body and the tranquility of the astral body. Again, students will have to experiment for themselves to discover what procedure works best for them individually and in what ways they may need to compensate or utilize other resources to perform Bardon's exercises successfully.

Astral Level

There are four parts to this exercise. You summarize in a diary all the "bad sides of your soul." These include all bad habits, deficiencies, weaknesses of character and temperament, failings, passions, and negative aspects of yourself.

Second, assign each fault to one of the four elements or as indifferent. Third, rate each fault on three levels as to its degree of difficulty. Fourth, repeat the first three steps for the positive side of yourself as well.

This exercise relates to attaining a magical equilibrium within the astral body. I followed this exercise exactly as Bardon laid it out. This seemed to work fairly well for me since I tend to analyze things and I like to describe behaviors. I spent a lot of time on it. I was not very happy with my results, however. Every time I think I understand my astral body something new comes bubbling up from the depths which defies all analysis. It is only lately that I am beginning to understand how the elements work on the astral plane.

Bardon's approach in this matter, however, follows some traditions in the Western world which do ascribe psychological traits to the four elements. The air element for example is sanguine, casual, friendly, cheerful, welcoming, curious, sometimes over familiar, at ease, balanced, and so forth. Earth is solid, stable, enduring, hard working, persevering, and practical. The earth element emphasizes attaining real, physical results. The fire element is energetic, dynamic, bright and shiny, intense and earnest, etc. The water element is sensitive, caring, empathic, giving, nurturing, etc. .

This approach follows astrology fairly closely so you could just as easily branch off into a study of yourself in terms of your natal chart. Gemini, Libra, and Aquarius relate to the air element though as signs of the zodiac they each contain a host of qualities. Gemini is straightforward and direct, down to earth, but still curious and loves communication on practical matters. Libra is balanced in really enjoying connecting to others in ways which are mutually satisfying. Libra adapts like air to a situation seeking to retain freedom while also being closely connected. Aquarius is like the sky. It seeks overviews and the great picture of what is going on. Like air, it craves harmony and like air it

seeks to serve universal, wide-ranging ideals and purposes.

So, in this sense, working on oneself in terms of self-analysis of the four elements in one's soul has a lot in common with astrology. Some Bardon students simply convert the mirrors of the soul into studies of astrology. Astrologers do not usually, however, say to you that if you have a lot of fire you need to work on the zodiac signs pertaining to water and so forth. They do not tell you to integrate your natal chart so you in effect create four grand triunes through your own psychological work.

I once met an extremely talented astrologer who did a marvelous interpretation of my natal chart and progressions. I told her she should counsel people like therapists who meet regularly with a client over a long period of time. She did not understand. For her, her job was done once she had conveyed the information. But this information has to be applied. It takes a lot of work to use the knowledge so something comes of it.

For example, I have an Aquarius Mars direct opposition to a Leo Pluto in my natal chart. It doesn't really do a lot for me when the astrologer says, "You will always find yourself opposed by institutions and individuals with great power. They represent tradition, authority, and order. You represent vision, freedom, and creativity. This conflict will remain with you your entire life. It will be your greatest challenge and also a source of extreme frustration."

I could put that down in my magic notebook as a high caliber problem with the fire element. Within me, there is a kind of plutonic fire burning which involves great power on nearly a cosmic dimension. At the same time, a Mars Pluto opposition also gives me a direct link into the minds of those with great power. I can read their thoughts and understand the weaknesses within their systems and within their wills.

There is a personal component to this aspect and that relates to learning to control anger and not getting depressed or obsessed with things I can not control. I think this is Bardon's immediate concern in the mirrors of the soul--to take charge of your own astral body and get to work on harmonizing and balancing your personality. But this conflict remains for me. It requires specifically that I master the cosmic letter K which relates to authority and issues governing human and divine power, magical jurisdiction and spiritual sovereignty. The letter K is a letter of fire. It is extremely intense and it rules by virtue of its brightness and ability to understand whatever it contacts. To master the letter K, however, requires also that I balance the fire with the other three elements in equal measure.

Psychologists are often like astrologers in not asking much of an individual. The psychological system which analyzes individual's traits in terms of thinking/feeling, sensate/intuitive, administrative/perceiving, and so forth (if I have that right) does not tell you to work on those qualities you are weak at so you attain a balance and equilibrium. Psychologists are not that aggressive nor do they conceive of a master plan for spiritual development. But this is precisely what Bardon does conceive of and so he asks you to spend some time trying to make sense of the elements at the beginning of your work. Obviously, it would help if we had a number of books relating to the elements and the psychologies of transformation associated with them and this will come fairly quickly I hope.

There is somewhat of a gap in Bardon's first book on Initiation when it comes to the elements. He mentions the qualities of the elements and magic mirrors at the beginning. And he has the student work on condensing the four elements within himself fairly early on. Around chapter 6 he has the student meditate on the four elemental qualities on the mental plane--feeling, thinking, will, and consciousness. And then at the end of the book he has the student begin meeting the elementals and also working with the four divine aspects of the four elements--immortality, omnipotence, omniscience, and omnipresence.

This leaves a lot of work to be done on connecting the energies of the elements in the personality to those of divinity. And also a student has to figure out how the elemental energies themselves exist as a continuum between our everyday personality experiences and our experiences with the four elements on the inner planes and as aspects of Divine Providence.

In my stories with the elemental beings, my interactions with Bardons' elementals often lead into discussions of what it is like to feel and think and perceive as an elemental being. I know individuals who on occasion act like a sylph or a salamander or a gnome. There is an overlap between the astral bodies of human beings and elemental beings and I continually try to explore that. To this end, I have written four essays and meditations on how to find the undine/sylph/gnome/salamander in yourself. I use the specific qualities of four elemental beings to assist me in those essays.

For example, in meditating with the gnome Erami I work with him on developing four steps for mastering his aura. I happen to like that approach. It is kind of shamanistic. It involves increasing your attentiveness to the land where you live. Some of the etheric energy in the land then makes its way into your aura. You begin to feel a part of the earth the way a gnome like Erami does. This results in a feeling of well-being and of being grounded.

I have already met individuals who have Erami's sense of well-being. I have kept an eye on them and communicated with them for decades watching how they live their lives and how they think and feel. But until I worked with Erami on this inner peace I have not seen anything in literature or psychology which gives me the faintest clue as to how to develop these qualities in myself. You could say for me that to balance my magic mirror I really need to make the elemental beings close friends. They possess many of the astral qualities I need in order to feel whole and complete. I am extremely grateful for having had the chance to meet so many masters from different religious traditions. Yet none of these masters can hold a candle to the powers and energies which are found in these elementals mentioned by Bardons as least as far as the astral and etheric planes are concerned.

As is typical in Bardons, you can work with a spirit to master an energy or quality. You can also just work with the energy itself without connecting to a spirit. In this later case, we are doing a kind of psychology--we are universalizing our astral body little by little so we are comfortable with the energies within the natural world around us. For example, we can meet loving people. We can also contemplate divine love and omnipresence. But the undines embody an expansive awareness of love which exists between the human personality and the consciousness of divinity.

We do not need to evoke an undine but the seas of the earth shine with a magnetic field which has the nature of love. Sailors do not know about this. Theologians and scholars are completely ignorant of this bliss. Scientists dismiss the possibility as ridiculous. Lovers occasionally but only occasionally encounter ecstasy this rich. But off and on a poet or a mystic will gaze upon the ocean and feel in their heart that God's hand has designed this wonder so that when we are ready we will understand something of His nature. You have to understand, that in a galaxy such as ours it takes perhaps a billion stars to produce a planet this beautiful, a planet in which the four elements are this rich and this magnificent.

My point is that the astral body of a human being is very important. We need to understand our own personal peculiarities and our strengths and weaknesses. Then we are more prepared to introduce within our astral bodies the vast fields of energy already existing around us. When we study the water element in all its qualities within human beings, then an encounter with an undine is not so shocking and enchanting. The undine is simply a part of our own nature. He or she embodies the qualities we ourselves are intended to master.

Can you close your eyes and focus upon your own feelings and then feel

flowing directly like a strong current or the taste of the water in a clear mountain pool the astral body of anyone else on earth? This open, receptive and free clairsentience is the most natural of things. But how could it ever be learned?

If you are with an undine like Isaphil or Istiphul, they can meditate for a moment and feel the waves breaking on any shore on any island on this planet. They can feel the rivers that flow and hear the songs of the whales anywhere they choose. They can sing a note so beautiful the entire magnetic field of an ocean for a moment is captured in that song and lends its power to what they desire.

Jungian psychologists would call descriptions such as these archetypes and to some extent the Bardon elementals resemble archetypes. They are both the same and yet always unique and different for each individual who encounters them. Their domain is the collective unconscious but they are more than this. They have an intelligence of their own, their own harmony and nature, and also are void of the human preoccupation with a personal identity. They reveal themselves in a unique manner to whomever they are with. But they are more the consciousness which the human race has yet to attain--an awareness of all the energies which shape and animate this planet on which we live.

At what point does your magic mirror of the soul lead you to connect to these archetypes? Bardon leaves this to the last chapter of his first book on initiation. They are also the first set of beings to work within his second book on evocation. Bardon prepares you for these encounters by having you develop immense mental, psychic, and etheric powers. But again I would like more literature, psychology, and methods of transformation relating to the elements set forth as a compliment to Bardon's system. And this is one of the main things I am working on.

A number of the earthzone spirits also specialize in magical equilibrium such as Jvar at 4 degrees Leo. And others specialize in astrology. There is on a higher level backup and wisdom for those who can make those kind of connections. Once, for example (in my third year of practicing Bardon), Jvar suggested I internalize within myself a sylph's light, airy cheerfulness and playfulness since I tend to be overly serious. I think his suggestion was right on and still this is an area I continue to work on. That light airy quality also manifests as an artistic temperament. Another earthzone spirit, Zagriona, brought back from a former life a sympathy for writing poetry which falls under the air element also.

Still, as much as we need a lot of material to help us better understand the four elements, Bardon himself is emphasizing that the student develop direct perception of his own astral body. For example, when you internalize and breathe in fire you get a feeling for that degree of heat and the intensity of fire. You can sense it is energizing and expansive and this naturally leads to a feeling of being in charge and commanding. When we are angry, we can supposedly notice that anger is also astral fire energy but more negative--it is demanding and forceful and out of control.

Now anger has been studied a great deal in psychology but certainly not in these terms of fiery qualities. A magician can certainly learn a lot from the physiology and psychology of anger in terms of how to deal with it. But a magician also goes on to work with fire on the astral planes and in encounters with elemental beings and then psychology is not going to be real helpful. Psychologists, for example, do not understand a whole lot about the power which is used by politicians or the political will to survive or the will that only wants more.

The salamanders have immense powers in their astral bodies relating to many aspects of fire which are still fairly unfamiliar to science and to scholarship. I again have sought to describe these fiery qualities in a number of stories I have written on my encounters with the Bardon salamanders. And yet when we raise the fire content in our astral bodies from working with fire in some form we still have to be acutely aware of how this fire effects our personalities.

It is counterproductive to master fire on the inner planes only to end up being a manic depressive and domineering individual in our personal lives. The latter will cancel out the advantages of achieving the former. Magical aptitude will then be controlled and expressed by our weaknesses rather than by our higher intuition and conscience. And this is probably the strongest reason for seeking to attain magical equilibrium. Without it, all spiritual and magical abilities become the playthings of an out of control personality. You can see this again and again in the lives of various spiritual masters who in their daily lives are sometimes driven by obsession with illusions they have never bothered to examine.

Also, in a number of my encounters with the earthzone spirits I often get in a trance where the four elements are in perfect balance. Sometimes this is just like Bardon suggests with earth in the legs, water in the abdomen, air in the chest, and fire in the head. Other times it is more like the cosmic letter J in the cosmic language in which the four elements, like the colors in opal, shine in and through each other blending together in harmony. Sometimes as with Cigila, an earthzone spirit in Pisces, the four elements become indistinguishable and fused into one consciousness. So, there is an integration to be achieved, a wholeness, and a completion in working with the four elements.

There are however countless ways for seeking mastery and integration of the four elements. If you take the alchemical motif, there is often an intensive internal process which goes on inside the individual. You seal your senses and aura off from the outer world in some way during practice to blend and fuse the elements together during a process of refining and purification.

When I do this with the gnome Erami it feels wonderful but gnomes, that is, the earth element also includes the energies within nature relating to the animal and plant kingdoms. So when I run into a new energy which is powerful I often will find myself transferring my awareness into some suitable image from nature. I did this when I wrote the poem on the wolverine which I posted under poems and stories on my web site. That is more a shamanistic exploration of the elemental energies but a magician should feel comfortable transferring his awareness into anything. After all, actors like Anthony Hopkins and Dusty Hoffman have incredible range when it comes to identifying with characters and they do so in an effective and convincing manner.

When I work with the gnome Mentifil, his methods are supremely advanced and also feel really neat but his system requires many years to master. Mentifil is like a physicist who emphasizes mastering the energies of the periodic table at least as far as the planetary metals are concerned. But his method is also typically alchemical in that it is very internal and sealed off from the external world.

Meeting and working with the elemental beings is not at all internal. You become acquainted with the elemental energies and then transfer your consciousness into the elementals realms and gradually make their domains a second home, a place you learn to know very well. When you return to your ordinary personality, eventually you feel balanced and detached like sylphs or incredibly empathic like undines, astonishingly grounded like gnomes, or intense like a navy seal or a commander in the special forces. Indeed, some salamanders present themselves as pure power which is focused only on the mission under consideration.

There is, then, a center point the hermeticist wishes to attain on the tetrapolar cross in balancing the four elements in himself. And there is also a gradually alchemical process of transmuting the dark qualities and energies into bright and transforming energies. I am interested in transpersonal psychology because within it I find some tools which emphasize a gradually process of self-exploration which lead to wholeness. These psychologists also insist that the dark aspects of the personality, e.g., the shadow, are essential to explore in order to become transformed. The dark contains the energy and the unconscious awareness which eventually becomes a clairvoyant tool and healing energy in the hands of

the magician, that is, when you finally master it.

But in the beginning, as in alchemy or the cosmic letter OE which relates to alchemy, there must be acceptance, appreciation, and compassion for yourself. You do not flee from self-knowledge. You become aware of all aspects of a problem. You observe your history, your behavior, your thoughts, your emotions, and the dynamics of how these interact. Then, with this expanded awareness, you are ready to undergo a process of transformation.

I would suggest that magick is also a study of creativity in all its forms. Ira Progoff points out that creative individuals have a special way of taking the impulses and intuitions they have and constantly reviewing and monitoring them. There is a continuous interaction between their conscious minds and the streams of energy running through them on deeper levels. Creativity finds ways to express these deeper streams sometimes sinking into them and flowing with them without having the faintest clue as to where they are going. And sometimes with great effort you consciously dig a well down to them so they can be brought up to the light of day and used in practical ways.

A lot of great masters do not emphasize art because they have reached a level where life is art and what could compare to the sounds and sights they can hear and see just by closing their eyes and contemplating? And what need is there to share art with others to express themselves when their very presence is inspiring? But I think for students it is really important to cultivate the ability to express one's feelings and intuitions in any suitable manner as a way of sharing with and enriching other's lives.

And it is also important to emphasize keeping oneself inspired for this is one of the great paths to transformation--having the light present in one's soul which possesses sufficient beauty and desire that it can take hold of all other desires and conflicts and, absorbing them into itself, transform them on to a higher level. Bardon does not seem to mention anything in the area of having and maintaining a rich devotional life or some means through which inspiration is cultivated. He does talk about having high and pure thoughts before going to sleep at night as a way to influence the subconscious. And, as I have mentioned, at the end of Initiation identifying with Divine Providence becomes a formal exercise. Also, in his third book, he mentions combinations of cosmic letters which are used purely as an adoration for Divine Providence.

Acts of devotion, adoration, meditation, contemplation, appreciation, worship, faith, etc. are also a means for spiritualizing the astral body. I notice that the Order of Bards, Ovates, and Druids likes to collect and publish students poems. This serves as a means for the members to share their inspiration and experience with each other. Under the Home Page of akasha on my web site I have written some poems on the cosmic letters which are inspiring for me and reminders of my own experiences during meditation.

I know some people are shocked and upset that I write publicly about the elemental beings. But I am convinced that some of the undines, e.g., would love to have a woman portray their songs and dances on a stage on Broadway if the musical was well written. Water encompasses this planet and hears the songs of the stars at night. The human race has barely begun to perceive and listen to the dreams which water contains. These dreams are part of our destiny when we are ready to listen.

In other words, I do not see a group of secretive masters developing out of the Bardon tradition--not after Bardon has gone to such great lengths to publish the sigils and descriptions of over five hundred spirits along with the cosmic language and a training system which prepares you to use these things. I conceive of a community of individuals in which nature, human, and divine are joined and celebrated. This light and inspiration are so radiant and engaging they transform our world. According to legend, there once was a civilization in which scientist, poet, politician, warrior, and magician all shared the same

heartful inspiration. The time has come for this to return.

The fourth part of this exercise is to list all the positive aspects of yourself, assign these to the four elements, and rate them also on three levels. It may be easy to ignore this exercise but it is also important. One of our great tasks in life is to find situations where our unique skills and abilities can be of greatest service to others. To do this, we must also know ourselves very well and learn to rely upon our strengths.

Astral Level Part II: The psychology of the elements

Note: For this essay, I worked with Jvar, a spirit in Leo of the earthzone who specializes in developing an equilibrium between the four elements.

Introduction to the Psychology of the Four Elements

The first step in working with a psychology of the four elements involves creating elemental sensations within ourselves through force of imagination. The sensation relating to each element has to be fully felt. Once we can generate a particular sensation in ourselves by will, we can then tie that sensation into the basic qualities of the element. This approach illuminates many aspects of the astral body which modern psychology fails to consider.

In regard to each of four elements, I refer you to my separate essays on finding the sylph, gnome, salamander, and undine in yourself. Though these articles derive directly from working with elemental beings, I present the results as meditations which require that you venture no further than the domain of your own imagination.

Also see my different dialogues with the elemental beings. For all their metaphysical explorations, these are not platonic dialogues. They take place in a state of trance in which I encounter and wrestle with the inner core essence of these marvelous spirits of nature. Yet though I present these stories as journeys into invisible and magical realms, the elemental beings embody treasures of spirit and feeling which are part of our own nature.

Fire

We practice seeing and feeling fire. We evoke the sensation of intense heat within ourselves. The basic procedure is to imagine that our bodies are hollow inside and so able to accumulate any energy we wish. When we are done, we imagine that the energy dissolves again into the universe. Let us talk about the difficulties with this concentration exercise.

Some individuals will be hesitant to work directly with fire. This may be because fire is dangerous. It can burn you.

It may also be that they are uneasy with the idea of developing their will and power. They may feel it is hard enough keeping one's desires and impulses in check. If you develop your power, you immediately run the risk of abusing that power. Passions out of control may end up controlling you and causing all sorts of harm to yourself and others. These concerns are very important and individuals should listen to their own consciences on these matters.

You will recall from Greek mythology that Zeus chained the titan Prometheus to a mountain crag and had hawks tear out his liver. Zeus was mad at Prometheus for giving fire to the human race. Each day the titan's liver would regenerate only to be torn out again.

The liver can be seen as representing natural growth and spiritual consciousness. In bestowing the gift of fire to humanity, Prometheus was giving power without the spiritual ability to know how to use it wisely.

One way to work with the element of fire is to review fire in all the ways it exists in nature, in society, and within ourselves. Life was able to appear on our planet because of the heat and light of the sun. But it took billions of years for this to occur and the earth had to have a stable orbit and the right distance from the sun.

There are many forms of fire which exist in nature. The volcano and forest fire are impersonal forces and extremely dangerous to life. And yet the fire in the earth moves continents, uplifts mountains, creates islands, and provides a variety of ecological habitats. As civilization has developed, we have learned to use the wood, coal, coke, oil, and gas fires turning their heat to productive ends. Consider the history of technology and both the positive and negative purposes to which fire has been dedicated. Fire itself, like a knife, can be used for healthy or for destructive ends.

Consider also the importance of warmth and heat to the human body. For the past thirty thousand years, we have managed to survive ice ages, winters, and freezing environments. We have developed clothing, insulation, and various heating systems to keep us warm. We have used fire to cook and produce many new kinds of food.

The point is that if you imagine your body filled with fiery flames and heat you encounter a racial memory of all that fire means. When you are evoking fire within yourself through the force of your imagination, you need to make peace with both its productive and its destructive aspects. You have to be comfortable with your ability to use its power in natural ways which fulfil spiritual purposes.

On the other hand, try as they may some individuals will find it hard to form a sensation of heat through concentration. They may visualize a fire in front of them. They can just as easily see a fire inside of their bodies. But nothing happens. There is no sensation of heat which accompanies this imagery.

If, for example, the individual repeatedly places his hands near a fire, he is still unable to get his nervous system to reproduce the sensation of heat through concentration. The problem here is that the individual's concentration on the mental plane is unable to produce astral sensations. The astral body adds feelings of life and immediacy to the imagery. When your concentration is effective on the astral plane, as in a dream, you feel you are really there amid whatever you visualize.

There are any number of ways of resolving this difficulty. Basically, the idea is to become the fire. Make the fire part of yourself. Treat fire as an extension of your own aura. Nourish it. Care for it. Offer it welcome. Invite fire into yourself so it finds a home and a place where it can grow strong.

For example, take some time to imagine you are collecting some dry leaves and wood so that you can start an open fire out of doors. Give your full attention to the match as it ignites and then starts the dry leaves and wood burning. Assist the fire by placing small twigs into the flames so that it can take hold. Then place a pan of water over the fire with the intent you are going to bring the water to a boil.

Assume the role of the fire like a cheerleader who encourages her team to succeed. Become the heat which starts small bubbles and then larger ones to appear in the water until the water finally boils. Then imagine this entire visualization has taken place within your own body. If in some way you can place emotion into your activity, then it is easy to full the sensations which occur on the astral plane. The heat in the fire then moves from a mental picture to an actual

sensation which is intense enough to feel real.

As I have pointed out elsewhere, there are Tibetan yogis who visualize fire and manage to increase their body temperature by seventeen degrees. This is no longer just a perceived sensation. Scientists have measured it with a thermometer.

The next step is to imagine and believe quite clearly that the presence of this element within yourself is the same as embodying will. In psychological terms, fire radiates urgency, power, and light. It is full of conviction and it dissolves fear. Because of its warmth and dynamic presence, it gathers others to itself. It offers leadership, courage, and a zest for living life.

Consider the affirmation: "I am a strong and assertive individual. I present myself in a clear and convincing way to other people." It is possible to form a picture in your mind that you indeed embody these qualities. But others may still see you as a whimp. They may treat you like you are helpless and ineffective.

The reason for this is that you have failed to create an astral component for this thought form. Your aura does not radiate any power or charisma. The task is to combine the mental affirmation with an astral sensation which radiates fiery power. Others will then immediately feel the warmth of your aura and a source of power within you which can take charge of any situation.

Again, there is the other extreme. Some individuals will find it easy to produce in themselves the hot, burning sensation of a fire. Some individuals with ease can imagine the entire world as one vast sea of flames and feel that heat extending around them for miles. They can do this because they have a natural ability or else they have a vivid astral imagination.

But there may be a downside to this. If they expand the fire element in their auras, they may lack the ethics, character, and commitment to use this force wisely. Sometimes at a red light, an individual in one car with casually glance at someone in another car. The second person may have an astral body full of fire which is ready to ignite. The glance is like striking a match. The encounter results in violence.

In this case, the feeling of power with its urgent need to act and to dominate the situation produces negative results. The fire has not been channeled through an alert and clear mind. Blind emotion has taken control.

Consequently, when the fiery element in the astral body is easily stimulated, the individual has to spend more time working on the mental plane. The purposes for which will and power are to be used must be carefully reviewed. The individual has to identify and commit himself to core values which are persuasive enough to hold the negative aspects of fire in check.

Air

As with fire, you imagine your body is a hollow space and that only the air element exists within you. You might imagine yourself to be like a helium balloon so you feel weightless. You feel yourself float up into the sky. The sensation of weightlessness and floating is basic.

Then you extend your imagination further. You imagine the winds are part of your body. The vacuum into which air flows is like your lungs exerting a pull as you inhale. Actually, there is a rhythmic flow in the winds and the seasons which is like breathing. Like a sylph, you probe and search for the harmony underlying air movements and weather patterns.

And finally you become the winds. If you open your mind and meditate, you become the trade winds, the north wind, the

hurricane, the thunderstorm, and the tiny gust that twirls the leaves in your garden. In meditation, there is no light or energy the mind can not find and reproduce to some extent within itself. Becoming familiar with the sky is just a matter of practice and taking time.

The air element can also be overdeveloped within an individual. If you make astral contact with the air element or communicate with sylphs, there is a tendency for the other elements in yourself to be shoved aside. This may lead you to a part of yourself which is wild and restless. It is impersonal, distant, and aloof. It is not at all concerned with the worries and responsibilities of human beings. It knows itself to be free and so it no longer cares about the demands of society, personality, or human feeling.

An individual with this passive aspect of the air element may be alert, detached, and balanced within himself. But he can also be insensitive to the extent of becoming amoral. This is not new information. Psychology talks about psychopaths and authors write about individuals who have lost their connections to others.

However, the phenomenon I am describing derives from an astral enchantment. Part of the individual's astral body is no longer focused on human existence. The individual perceives the way a sylph perceives or as the fairies of lore who enchant human beings to come away with them to the inner planes. As William Butler Yeats describes it:

Come away, O human child!
To the waters and the wild
With a fairy, hand in hand,
For the world's more full of weeping than you can understand.

Again, psychologists such as Carl Jung have written about a circle of enchantment which holds human beings in enthrallment. The individual is haunted and possessed by what is unfilled in the past, by the unmet needs of childhood and family. He does not see the actual situations he enters and other human beings as they are but only a distorted reflection, an illusion seen from afar. Giving and receiving, bonding, and intimacy are twisted and bent because the heart is incomplete.

But the enchantment of air is slightly different. The individual has an over abundance of the air element which lacks positive expression. There is nothing a matter with having a sylph's heightened awareness. The Dalai Lama's weather controller possesses this as did ancient druids.

The sylph's sensitivity can take the form of a detachment which blends freedom with a delight in pure perception. It is a thrilling experience as are hang gliding and parasailing. It is easy when you feel this relaxed and free to say to yourself, "I am not a human being. The life within me is altogether different that from what others feel and see." When we are at play or entertained, we may temporarily feel the same thing. We give ourselves permission to forget about the rest of life for the duration.

But this suspending of daily demands, besides being a way to recharge ourselves, has a productive side. An altered state of perception enables us to see the world in new ways. The challenge is to share this with others.

The poet does this. He perceives the delicate fragility and the hidden beauty shining within each moment. When he writes or speaks, he is sufficiently distant that he can savor pure feelings. But he knows these feelings can only be expressed, found and met, within the details and specific experiences of our lives. Each poem is a steppingstone leading across the stream separating humanity from the realms of fairy and the astral plane.

The artist does this. He says, "Behold my art. It is a creation of

my imagination. Its images are a mirror capturing the light I see reflected in life." And musicians do this when the music is just right. They are no longer aware of themselves. The notes carry them along. The song takes on its own life and they are within both the human plane and another domain.

Too much airy substance in the soul tempts us all to let go and forget our ties to others. Legend tells us of a race which could not longer compete with human beings and so retreated from our world to become a race of fairies. But even to these we might now say, "Return again and dwell among us. Share with us the things you see and know that we too might behold the beauty of the world around us." The remedy is not to retreat into detachment and a realm of inner peace but to create new ways of sharing heart to heart.

And finally there is the basic problem of developing astral sensitivity. Many individuals see no further than the activities of their daily lives. The consequence is that their emotional life is limited in scope. In fact, most religions guide their practitioners into a few sets of sacred experiences which are charged with astral energy. Conversion, devotion, rapture, and commitment are controlled and channeled in acceptable ways. Other profound emotional experiences are labeled taboo and placed off limits or else are ignored and considered to be irrelevant.

But if you look at a cloud it is constantly changing. If you focus on a feeling within you and give it enough space to move, it will continuously transform. Feelings are like the waters of the earth. They run in underground streams. They are in the lakes, the seas, the clouds, the rivers, the rain, and the ice caps.

A sylph is aware of every aspect of a changing cloud and yet the sylph remains detached. To work with the air element is to have both inner balance and a sensitivity to every nuance and aspect of feelings. Developing this sensitivity is something which psychology shares in common with magick. Elsewhere I write about the method of focusing which bridges the gap between transpersonal psychology and magical practice.

Water

To develop the sensation of water which is cold and wet, imagine you are swimming and diving in a stream, river, lake, or ocean. It is possible to extend your meditations along these lines until the sensations of water become quite strong. At some point along the way, imagine yourself becoming the water surrounding your body. Feel the swimmer and the diver moving through your space. And again feel the coldness of water within your body as if your body is hollow inside.

In my various stories about my encounters with the undines, I go into detailed descriptions about their specific astral natures. The four I describe are all loving, receptive, sensitive, empathic, healing, and nurturing. Also, they each have a slightly different way they communicate the bliss and ecstasy within the water element. These undines are very enchanting and possess many magical secrets relating to the water element.

From my experience, undines extend their auras out into the watery domains surrounding them. If they wish to create an atmosphere like a wondrous festival full of dancing and song, the water is magnetized to express their feeling. If they wish to communicate a profound state of oneness and love, again, the water element becomes a vehicle which carries and amplifies their intentions.

Our task in exploring the psychology of water is to do something

similar. Once we can clearly produce the sensations of cold water in and around ourselves, then we imagine that this watery expanse acts to express our feelings. Water absorbs, releases, flows and circulates energy. In a similar way, our aura encompasses and revives the life of those with whom we have contact. It produces a magical space in which individuals are free to be receptive to each other and to feel acceptance and love.

As with the other elements, we now combine the energies of the mental and astral planes. We need a clear definition and commitment in our minds to all that water represents in its highest sense. Again, the qualities are love, healing, nurturing, sensitivity, acceptance, clairsentience, serenity, tranquility, purity, and so forth. And we need a total and complete conviction that we exist within and are a part of a magnetic watery field of energy flowing through us and encompassing ourselves and others as well.

Both the mental and astral planes with their different approach to water must then be united in a natural way. Part of our success in this endeavor will arise from our study and appreciation of other individuals who express feelings and ideals of love in their personalities. And part of our work will involve recognizing the great variety of sensations and ways in which water exists in the world of nature. Again, I have given examples through poems and stories of ways the undines have sought to deepen my understanding of the environment and element of water in which they live. Ultimately, their domain and their range of activities are also our own.

Earth

If we conceive of fire as will, air as intelligence and clarity of mind, and water as love and affection, what then shall we make of the element of earth? In way can earth represent the integration and strength of consciousness?

The granite boulder is stable. It retains its shape, its form and mass, and only very gradually changes. The precious stone is harder and more enduring and yet its structure permits the energy of light to pass through it. Ice is water in a solid form. Its molecules though fixed cover a wider expanse so that it floats. Air is in water and water is in the volcanic magma as it explodes. As the heat is released, the flowing lava turns to stone.

Plants grow on the rich nutrients of volcanic islands. Topsoil develops and then forests. The land mass provides an environment where life can flourish.

Consciousness integrates the different aspects of ourselves. It is the enduring and stable landscape where our soul and spirit accomplish their tasks. Consciousness sets priorities, identifies values, and applies its resources and time to productive ends. There are conflicts between values, goals, desires, and different individuals. Consciousness uses the understanding of air, the will of fire, and the empathy of water to arrive at practical and satisfying solutions.

The main sensations we are after with the earth element are weight and density. You imagine yourself as a little more heavy. Like a tree, you are rooted in the ground. Like a boulder, you are solid and easily resist external influence. Increasing your sense of weight and being grounded are part of the arts of Aikido and also Tai Chi Chuan.

With the right piece of rock, there is a sense of time being suspended. You remember the past. You endure for ages. Even the far future feels near at hand. The earth element has a stronger

continuity. Past, present, and future form a continuum. The events of life occur along a time line. You do not have to rush anywhere. You just use the present moment in the best way you can.

I place my hand on a standing stone five thousand years old. There is nothing fancy about this stone circle. It seems quite casual like an afterthought the way it is set down at the end of a cow pasture on Mull Island, Scotland. But I think to myself that all the events of human history from the Egyptian pyramids to the present unfolded while these stone have stood here and waited.

Consciousness can take the events of our lives and give them order and definition. It can say, "This relationship and that event are important to me. They always will be. These ideals I live for--they are what give my life purpose. You see, amid all the changes--the accidents, the failures, and the wrong turns--there is a core set of values within myself which I uphold and experiences which I honor."

Fire is tenacious but earth is persevering. Water offers love and support, sweet intimacy and pleasure. But earth builds and provides those things which satisfy our deepest desires. The air element likes to think and to reason. It offers clarity so vast that the thought process is lost in the illumination. But the earth element knows in its heart that it is alive and participates in those purposes which endure through all ages of time.

Earth cuts to the bottom line. It is not distracted by the urgency and rapacious hunger of fire and all the issues surrounding the maintenance of power. It is not so easily distracted by the enchantments, romance, and passions of love. And though it too seeks and reaches for peaks of understanding and illumination, it does not fly off content to be detached or aloof.

Earth stays focused on the concrete and practical ways we can materialize our ideals and operate in an effective manner in accordance with our core values. It leaves behind a legacy. It provides a foundation upon which future generations will build. And if this sounds too abstract, then we can apply the same to our own lives. In each stage of our life, we act with integrity and accomplish our basic tasks. Then we are able to move forward and succeed with what comes next.

In summary, this is only a tiny introduction to the psychology of the four elements. I have not discussed here the ecstasies of the four elements. And there are the four divine attributes relating to different elements--omnipotence, enlightenment, omnipresence or all-encompassing love, and immortality.

I have suggested elsewhere that the twelve signs of the zodiac and astrology also provide insight into the four elements. An important step in this area will be identifying for each of the twelve signs of the zodiac its corresponding elemental sensation. Then that rich set of symbols and interpretations can be integrated into the psychology of the elements. To do this will require a shamanistic approach to the symbols which characterize the zodiac signs.

Psychic Level Part III: Introduction to Fire

When we explore wind and sea, we can savor the delightful sensuality and the familiar sensations contained in these elements. The stories of sylphs and undines stimulate our emotional life even as they call forth balance and harmony. The songs in water and air are of freedom, gentleness, and empathy. The gnomes also are not so distant from us. They are the intelligence and the consciousness in the rocks upon which we sit or the mountains we climb.

But fire is different. Here we enter a domain of

pure power and will. Volcanoes exploding, raging forest fires, lava flows--these exhibitions within nature strike a different cord as they resonate within our souls.

Fire is expansive and uninhibited. We know what it is to feel exuberance, excitement, and exhilaration. We have all been thrilled and enthralled. In such feelings, there is a amplification and intensification of our energy. And, at times, there is an explosion of vitality combined with zeal.

On the other hand, being obsessed, infatuated, or spellbound--these emotional states result in part from a weakness of the fire element within ourselves. We have failed to master the sources of power which animate our souls. Consequently, there are times when we may find ourselves attracted to experiences or people who are unfamiliar and yet strangely appealing. Captivating images may come to us in dreams or we may encounter ideals which bedazzle our imaginations.

Another person may bring into our lives a vision of happiness and joy we have never known. A dream may remind us of the love we once shared. An ideal may seize us, asking us to make a commitment or to live on a higher level. A religion or a new set of beliefs may insist we make peace with ourselves.

However, we must be wise as we approach such radiant sources of inspiration. They may seem to offer us feelings of being more alive and energized. They may appear to offer direction and purpose. But if we are unable to find the light and power shining in these images within our own being, we risk becoming dependent on something external. This need for external stimulation is typical in drug addiction.

Those, for example, with an addiction to amphetamine have the greatest difficulty living without the rush, the push, and drive which the drug generates within their nervous system. Drugs may induce temporary but heightened states of fearlessness and aggression as adrenalin is released into the bloodstream. The sympathetic nervous system takes over.

The rate, force, and amplitude of heartbeat increase along with blood pressure. Blood vessels throughout the body constrict. The bronchii of the lungs dilate increasing the body's ability to engage in vigorous muscular activity. The liver releases more glucose into the bloodstream. The processing of glycogen to lactic acid in the muscles increases. Muscles go taut, the mind hypervigilant.

The lower brain takes control. Our sense perceptions seem more acute. Our pupils dilate. The sympathetic nervous system increases our instinct for survival and, at times, our capacity to take charge of our lives. Yet the price the drug addict pays is also very great. Their bodies and brains become exhausted. The fire, rather than illuminating and healing, burns up their health and devours their souls.

When we work with fire, we are working with will and power. Fire is more wild and uninhibited compared to the other elements. To that extent, therefore, we must always be conscious of the purposes which we are pursuing. Since fire increases our influence and our options, we must be careful about the choices we make as its power is amplified within us.

Traditional symbols handed down for many millennia

have honored and paid tribute to this power and the wisdom within the fire element. Fire has symbolized a means for understanding how we shape our destinies. Such symbols still speak to us. They remind us that fire is at the roots of our deepest motivations and sources of inspiration.

For example, the ancients decorated the night sky with their mythologies. Astronomy and astrology were one and the same. Consequently, cosmology and human destiny were not separate. Human will and Divine will worked together in the unfolding the universe. Is this such a quaint notion when we now know that the choices we make as a species will maintain or destroy the biosphere?

Consider that profession of disrepute known as alchemy. Its practitioners, in part, sought to transmute one metal into another. But we now create conditions in our laboratories in which atoms melt together. Losing their separate identities, they form "superatoms", matter which no longer even exists in nature. The human race is experimenting with the powers which gave birth to the stars. Scientists are attempting to track down what happened in the first instant in which the universe was created.

As we unravel one secret of nature after another, it is easy to lose our sense of priorities in the excitement to apply what we have discovered. It is easy to deny our responsibilities. At the last moment, when we witness the work of our hands, we may suddenly find ourselves turning, like Robert Oppenheimer, to mythology to comprehend our orbit of action--

As Oppenheimer witnessed the result of the Manhattan project which he directed--at the first nuclear explosion--Oppenheimer quoted Sri Krishna from the Hindu Bhagavad-Gita. Oppenheimer said, "I am become Death, the shatterer of worlds."

Let us not forget that from the deepest visions of the heart and soul we shape our own destinies. The foundations of society derive from our values and the pattern of life which we seek to uphold. Not necessity but our greatest sources of inspiration empower our lives.

As we turn to fire, let us consider the voice with which mythology speaks to us through the ancient system of astrology. Let us consider the way fire bears on human will. In astrology, we have three fire signs. The first of these is Aries.

Aries, the ram, is the one who forges by his will the sacred weapons he needs to defeat all enemies and to surmount all barriers. Aries, alone and without support, is empowered to cross through the unknown wilderness of the soul and spirit. He defies the darkness and all that opposes. His very nature is courage. He takes everything that confronts him as a challenge which he will master. He moves without fear and none may defeat him when his will is aligned with the universe.

There exist many traditions which insist we discover the great spiritual truths of life within the core of our being. Belief may contain the seed we seek to bring to fruition. But a path of growth within the soul requires that we confront the actual powers which lie dormant and asleep within us.

For example, in some mystery religions, fire contains a magic which relates to the strengthening of will power. Concentration on the sensations associated with fire amplify this will. Fire meditations can be used to

build resolution. The property of heat, for example, to expand indefinitely relates to will. As concentration on the intensity in heat increases so does the feeling of being able to overcome obstacles with courage and without fear.

The second fire sign in the zodiac is Leo. Leo, the lion, shines like the sun and his confidence and leadership is such that others find it easy to follow him. Aries, though the dimmest of the twelve constellations, has a fire which burns hotter than any other. Aries can, then, intensify his will in order to destroy all obstacles. In Leo, by contrast, fire illuminates the world. Leo offers a center of inspiration and guidance around which our actions may be directed. Leo fashions and sustains a community by his will.

A second aspect of the magic of fire also relates to the sign of Leo. This is the ability to condense and to contain energy. Fire expands outward illuminating space. By will, we learn how to draw energy into a small place and to control it. In this way, we transform energy into light. Rather than crushing or else allowing passions to burn wild and destructive, we learn to tame their powers for the purposes of love.

Fire, under the control of will, is directed so that it animates and nurtures the world. The fire is contained so that it is not a threat or a danger. Similarly, leadership offers a center of power and will around which others may be nourished and their lives fulfilled.

The power to rule, in part, derives from mastery of oneself. Controlling great pressures and intensities within ourselves, we can direct desires to useful ends. We are also able to guide others' motivations in the same way we work with the drives and hungers within ourselves.

The third fire sign in the zodiac is Sagittarius, the archer. Sagittarius seeks to find and proclaim those ideals and principles which illuminate our minds. This sign seeks justice, wisdom, and the transformation of the world. There is a purity in the Sagittarian vision which inspires the will to commitment and the heart to devotion. Sagittarians are the explorers who search for the truth. They are tenacious and dauntless when it comes to fulfilling a quest.

A third magic within fire is a concentration Sagittarians possess. Fire captures and focuses our attention. It sharpens our ability to remain calm and centered within ourselves. Fire contains the intensity which leads to inner illumination. When we discover this source of power within ourselves, nothing disturbs or distracts us--our concentration is unassailable.

Because this energy is so dynamic and yet directed by our will, there is no need for diversions or external stimulation and excitement. We measure and gauge the tasks we choose to fulfill in the world by the light illuminating us from within. We set our priorities in accordance with how we wish to reshape the world. Our movements are in accord with our inner being.

Fire takes the fuel it needs from its environment. It is not hesitant nor shy. Its will is ferocious and wild. But when fire is guided and controlled by a greater will, its power to transform, transmute, and refine is clear and unmistakable.

Fire is the sword of spirit which cuts through all

obstacles. Its warmth heals and regenerates. Its light opens the pathways which lead out of darkness. By its might are the worlds created. Time and space unfold according to the plans concealed within it.

Fire is part of the symbol of Divine Providence, of the One Light which holds the universe within its palm. Those who would be born of the spirit, who would enter the mysteries, those who would accomplish their work on earth--they seek to master the sacred fires which burn within their bodies and at the center of their hearts.

Physical Exercises

There are four exercises for the physical level. They correspond roughly to the four elements. The first helps wake you up in the morning and relates to the invigorating and cleansing aspect of fire. The second dealing with breath relates to air. The third involves food and is mostly earth. The fourth relates to the water element.

1. The Material Body: Stretching and Skin Maintenance

The first exercise relates to stretching the body and rubbing the skin. That seems fairly straightforward and I will let the book speak for itself on that point. As with other exercises, each person has to find their own pace and way of applying the exercise so it fulfills its purpose.

2. Conscious Breathing/Mystery of Breathing

The second exercise relates to breathing. Basically, you breathe in starting with seven breaths and gradually increasing the number. You do this twice a day. Eventually you practice for about ten minutes a day.

As you breathe in, you place a thought or wish within the air you are inhaling. The air serves as a medium for transmitting your desire through the planes to the akashic plane within your body. From this level, it then seeks to manifest as reality. The idea is to stick to desires which relate to you directly and which serve to strengthen your health, harmony, and spirit.

To do this you need to be very relaxed. You also need to imagine the desire in a way so you feel the outcome is completely real for you. In other words, if you desire health, you visualize or feel yourself being completely healthy. If you are after inner peace, happiness, contentment, confidence, etc. you imagine this as being the reality right now.

This is, in effect, a magical ritual utilizing the air element. It is taking something ordinary and, as with the following exercise involving eating, turning it into a sacred act. Normally, breathing exercises fall under the study of pranayama. There are a great many specific practices involved with pranayama. Sufis, Buddhists, Hindu's, Moslems, Taoists and many other traditions work with breathing and approach the exercises according to their own interests and purposes. In one Hindu practice, you must swear forever that you will not reveal the secret teaching about the specific route the breath follows as it enters your body.

Bardon mentions the four elements are present in air. Sufis breathe in through the nose and out through the mouth, vice versa, or in other ways so as to focus on specific elements. Taoists breathe the chi in the air into the body and circulate it through various meridians. In Hatha

Yoga, you can breathe air into the muscles you are stretching.

I have written an essay called, Finding the Sylph within Yourself, based on the sylph Cargoste's qualities. In this approach, the idea is to increase your awareness of the etheric energy in the air element which surrounds your body. As I inhale now, I tend to identify with the air element since focusing completely on breathing leads me in this direction. In other words, I sense the etheric airy energy field around myself. It is incredibly relaxed, vibrant, uplifting, buoyant, and energizing. Its very nature is harmony and freedom.

As I inhale, I observe the process of breathing from the point of view of this energy field of etheric air. I feel part of that energy field circulating through my lungs, blood, and body. During this process, it feels like my aura is expanding and joining with the air around me.

Since the air element contains qualities I am interested in internalizing within myself, it seems to me superfluous to place a thought form into the air I am breathing. In fact, I have a great deal of difficulty doing magick on an ordinary level like this. The "thought" tends to rush through the air and my body and then center itself in my mental body where it creates more tension than I feel comfortable having inside myself. It could be I just need to lighten up and concentrate in a more gentle way. I do not think this is a problem for others but it tends to be something I personally have to be very careful with.

The other thing I would suggest in performing breathing exercises is to spend some time observing all you can about the breathing process itself. You might like to review the anatomy and physiology of breathing. You can also notice how first your upper chest, then your ribs, and finally your belly expand outward as you inhale. You can focus on the sensation of air as it moves between your nostrils and your lungs. You can concentrate on your sinus cavities as you are breathing.

You may also be able to notice the particular vibration or vitality in the air as it moves into your lungs and circulates through your body. You may feel your heart beat and how the heart muscles are more "hungry" for oxygen than other muscles. The heart muscles die without adequate oxygen supply whereas other muscles can sustain their strength longer without air.

When it comes to breathing exercises, I like to combine breathing with movement. I enjoy Tai Chi Chuan and Chi Kung exercises. For me, there is a different feeling and use of vitality in the Tai Chi Chuan forms of different Chinese masters. This is even more noticeable in different Chi Kung forms. One set of Taoist Chi Kung forms leaves me feeling like I am sitting amid a tranquil mountain pool. Another walking form stimulates the lung meridians which helps to open up the nose and sinuses. Other forms imitate flowers, animals, clouds, and to some extent produce the etheric energy of these aspects of nature in the practitioner.

I would also point out that the two Chinese meridians relating to the air element are the lung and large intestine meridians. The lung meridian tends to carry with it a feeling of harmonious movement into the future. This contrasts with the opposite feelings of having anxiety or worrying about future events. The large intestine meridian carries with it a feeling of being relaxed, balanced, and at ease. This contrasts with a feeling of depression or of being pulled down.

Altogether, the air element has within it the qualities of clarity, unhindered movement, freedom, balance, harmony, etc. As you work with breath, try to notice how your own emotional and mental states effect your breathing. Breathing is a celebration of the air element and of participating in a vast ocean of life force which surrounds us.

On the other hand, it is easy to fall into emotional states such as worry and insecurity which rob us of this connection. Besides becoming an addictive habit, some individuals use smoking as a means to evoke a state of harmony and detachment. As soon as the cigarette is lit and the smoke enters their lungs, their anxiety and distress are banished. It is as if they have created a psychic bubble around themselves which the concerns of

the world can not penetrate. In this case, the air element in the lungs is neutralized. The individual can then see and feel in a different way. The worries and the disharmonies are briefly relieved.

The breathing exercise serves a similar purpose. As you focus completely on breathing, time and space are suspended. You are immersed within a state of harmony and freedom. You feel united to a greater presence. But in this case, the feelings are not generated by suppressing the air element. The etheric or vital energy in air enters into and supports your meditation.

3. Conscious Reception of Food

This exercise is similar to conscious breathing. If we can place a thought in the air which we inhale, we can do the same with food and drink. Food, being more material, is used more for material desires or those relating to our bodies.

Before you eat, concentrate a thought or wish into your food as if what you desire is real right now. As you eat, stay focused on your thought or meditation as you imagine your desire entering every cell of your body. Eat all the food.

Once again, we are taking something ordinary and turning it into a magical act. We are converting eating into a sacred ritual. Bardón says this is similar to the communion of Christians.

These days many individuals eat fast foods and they eat while watching TV, talking, or doing other things. To some extent, this may be unavoidable for some individuals depending on their work situations and other factors. Once when I was talking to an Islamic Sheik at a university, he exclaimed that he could not understand how the students could eat in public much less while walking between classes. In fact, in his tradition it was inappropriate for a man to eat in the presence of a woman--and this even though he had three wives! For him, eating was a carefully construed ritual activity.

As with the breathing exercises, if I place a thought into the food I am eating, I can feel the vibration of that thought transferred immediately to my mental body. I do not think this is a real concern for others. Any form of ritual magick is fairly powerful for me and I have to be careful with how I use it. That is, I have to be sure to align myself with natural processes as much as possible and avoid over use of mental forms of concentration.

If we compare eating to taking communion, it relates to the eucharistic mystery. This is a vast topic which can be explored from many sides. For myself, I like to concentrate on food imagining the sources from which it comes. I see the grapefruit on the tree and the grape juice as grapes on a vine. I see the bread as wheat in the field, the carrots in the ground, etc.

I then place my mind within the food. I try to feel the vibration of the physical substance of the food I am about to eat. I also try to sense the life force within it. I join my mind with both the physical substance and the energy of the food. This produces in me a feeling of being grounded, of being connected to the earth, of being strong, vibrant, and stable.

This method is more alchemical than the procedure of concentrating a thought into the food. Those who study the cosmic language will notice that the letter OE pertains to alchemy. The OE uses both sensations of weight belonging to the earth element and the penetrating sensation of akasha. OE carries with it a sense of perfectly accepting and joining your conscious to what you are working on.

First you understand something exactly as it is. But because you are penetrating it with your awareness, you also sense the subtle, etheric energy underlying it. And finally, you come to see the perfection of this material in its highest etheric vibration. The OE deals with the

philosopher's stone or the quintessence of life force drawn from out of what already exists within nature.

Since I am working with gnome magicians, the alchemical method is more comfortable for me. As I mention elsewhere, a gnome will place his awareness within a precious stone to accomplish a specific effect. He might also work with an area of the earth such as a mountain or rock outcropping. When he is done, the physical location is invested with an astral and etheric vibration such as well-being and peace.

Conscious eating can be done in a similar way. By briefly joining your spirit with the food before you eat it, you transform it raising and refining its vibration. In a sense, this activity can also express itself by visualizing the food or concentrating into it the thought that the food is a universal healing energy or an elixir of life.

Also, Bardon says of the cosmic letter C that it relates to quabbalistic alchemy--the "modification of matter by the word." That is, you impregnate a material form with a spiritual, mental, or astral quality. The eucharistic celebration pertains to the letter C as compared to the letter OE.

The goal in letter C is not so much the perfection of the life force of nature. The letter C is useful for embodying high spiritual or divine qualities within oneself. Except for the Celtic Church in Ireland, the early Christian monks in their monasteries were not usually concerned with nature spirits or the life force in the trees, fruits, wheat, and harvest.

The early monks conceived of joining themselves to a love so pure and radiant that a small part of God's presence could be felt and reflected within them. And so we have the words of Christ (as a variation on many ancient rituals of joining with deity) saying, "Take and eat, for this is my flesh...."

There is a tendency for monks in monasteries to obsess with the mental and akashic planes when they approach divinity. As opposed to this, I think what Christ was offering in the Last Supper was a way of making a direct connection to him on the astral plane. In this case, the effect is not to produce austerities and withdrawal from the world so typical of monastic traditions. The effect was intended to produce a powerful empathy and a dynamic compassion which exerts a transforming effect when one person interacts with another.

What I am suggesting is that when you impregnate food with a desire be sure to include an astral component. Astral images are emotionally moving, satisfying, and fulfilling. They enhance and add beauty to the person you already are.

The final thing I would say about conscious eating is that we are practicing not only alchemy and the eucharistic mystery. We are blessing food just as someone might pray and ask a blessing on the food before they eat. The power to bless also falls under the cosmic language--the cosmic letter G. This letter has a watery sensation and a green color which relates to the sphere of Venus.

On the various planes, the letter G produces divine grace, mercy, blessing, peacefulness, satisfaction, happiness, and abundance. The letter G embodies the blessing which we often associate with the benevolent presence of an angel. If you practice conscious eating for decades, you are acquiring some of these magical abilities--the OE with its refinement of nature's life force; the C with its embodiment of divinity within us; and the G with its angelic power to bless and to inspire.

But the basic practice remains: we turn eating into something sacred. By performing it consciously aware of not only the material but the other planes as well, it becomes a magical action. By giving of ourselves completely to the moment, we enter briefly and commune with the spirit within us, akasha, and the Eternal Now.

4. The Magick of Water

Bardon points out that water can also be impregnated as can any substance through the akasha principle which is part of it. However, water also has a magnetic aspect which is especially useful as an accumulator of energy. The magnetic aspect Bardon is interested in is strongest around 39 degrees F and slowly loses its power as it becomes warmer until around 97 degrees F where it no longer operates.

In the first part of this exercise, as you wash yourself with water, imagine that whatever weakness, illness, or unhappiness that afflicts you is removed from yourself and absorbed by the water. You can do this while you take a shower, with your hands under a tap, by placing your hands in a bowl of water, or by taking a dip in a stream. As you wash yourself, also use soap. Do not let another individual come in contact with the water you use.

You can also impregnate a bowl of water with a desire. Place your hands in the water and concentrate on absorbing the realization of your desire into yourself. You can also wash yourself of some weakness in one bowl of water and then absorb into yourself your wish realization with a second bowl.

Bardon also mentions two other possibilities. A woman can magnetize some water with the idea of becoming more attractive with a more youthful face and skin. In this case, she can add a bit of borax to the water. She can wash or, better, dip her face in the water seven times (seven relating to the sphere of Venus) as she does this.

Bardon also mentions a similar aspect for strengthening the eyes or developing clairvoyance by using an eye bath. I will leave this last exercise as it is stated in the book. Some undines such as Istiphul use water for seeing into the future.

There are quite a few practices involving water. Some individuals I know would mention adding various ingredients to bath water--herbs, spices, fragrances, etc. Different herbs are said to produce different influences on the physical and astral bodies. Hydrotherapy is also a speciality of one of the earthzone spirits Bardon mentions in his second book.

At one Taoist monastery, we heated pine cones, eucalyptus bark, and fresh ginger in a pot and then dipped the water on to towels. We then gave massages through the hot towels. Obviously, there are a number of different spices or herbs which can be used for this kind of herbal massage.

When I use water to cleanse myself, something similar happens to me as when I do the earlier breathing exercise. With breath, I sense and identify with the air element around me almost as if I am a sylph. Working with water, I spontaneously feel myself surrounded by water. This comes from concentrating on the water to the exclusion of all other sensory impressions.

When I first wrote about the undine Isaphil about five years ago, I presented an exercise for connecting to the water element. You place your hands in a sink or bowl filled with cold water. You concentrate on that cold sensation on your skin.

Then you extend your mind into the water around your hands. You place your consciousness within this water as if it is part of yourself. Then you imagine you are the water surrounding your hands. You feel your hands from the point of view of the cold water.

At this point, as you bring your hands out of the water, try to sustain the sensation of cold water surrounding them. You may also be able to feel a magnetic field around your hands which you can also sustain with your mind. This magnetic field is the medium in which undines often operate. It is the etheric energy underlying the water element. This preliminary exercise seems to do a lot for me in terms of attuning my mind to water.

Just now I did the first part of the exercise in which I was imagining

water absorbing the excess tension in my body. I held my hands under the bathtub tap for several minutes. As I focused solely on the water flowing over my hands, I again rather spontaneously visualized the source of this water--clouds and rain over the nearby mountains. Water dripping from the leaves of trees and running into streams and flowing over falls and also sinking down into the water table. I could smell the air and imagine I was there. This imaginative extension of the exercise seems to increase its effectiveness for me.

For the part of the exercise in which we work on a desire, I held my hands over a sink filled with cold water. I charged the water with the feeling of serenity--of being very happy, peaceful, and clear. I imagined this energy/charge flowing from my hands into the water. And I also pictured this wish within the water.

Then I placed my hands in the water and absorbed the wish back into myself along with the magnetic charge within the water. This time as I placed my hands in the water I felt my whole body under the ocean surrounded my miles of watery energy. Absorbing the serenity into myself seems to produce a very soothing feeling. Some of the etheric energy in water is transferred back into me.

IIH Step 2

Mental Level

SUMMARY OF EXERCISE. In the mental level exercise for the second chapter, you practice concentrating on the five senses one after the other. The goal is to concentrate on a sensory perception from one of the five senses for five minutes without any mental distraction or interference from another sense. You accomplish this first with your eyes closed and then with them open.

Start with the sense of sight. Notice something around you like a pencil, a lamp, an apple, a chair, etc. Then close your eyes and visualize this object. You exert your imagination so that the visual image is completely real as if it is right there in front of you. You note distractions which occur while you practice. At first, practice no more than ten minutes but eventually work up to a half hour. Keep working with different visualizations until you can hold the picture of an object clearly in your mind for five minutes.

Then you do the same exercise with your eyes open. The object hangs in the air in front of you. You focus on it to the exclusion of anything else such as the background or other nearby objects. You proceed to practice in this way with the other four senses also until your concentration on each is equal to that of any other sense.

VISUALIZATION

"Of all the gifts we have received, of all our five senses, sight is perhaps the most precious. As the first among equals, sight imposes order in the chaotic world of the senses. Sight also has direct access to the higher functions of the human brain and holds the key to the hidden world of the unconscious. The very fact that this thought can be expressed in this way--using the metaphor of a key--is because the sense of sight has allowed us to develop the powerful language of symbolism." Elizabeth Nash

Some individuals do not use visual images when they think. One individual I met fell asleep whenever she tried to visualize something or even meditate. I used to not think in pictures. Working with the Bardon exercises changed my thought process to where I now visualize with ease. It is perhaps easier for me to visualize an object in front of me with my eyes opened than closed.

Individuals often write me and say they have a lot of difficulty practicing visualization exercises. Bardon presents his exercises in a straightforward and dry manner. He explains to you what he wants and expects you to work through it and then move on to the next exercise. I find it is true that if you practice an exercise even for one minute a day over the period of a month, a year, ten years, thirty years, whatever, you will arrive at complete mastery in the end. Some of the Bardon exercises are like that. You do them until they become second nature.

On the other hand, it is possible to play with all of these exercises so you turn them into something enjoyable and even fun. I used to do pencil drawings of individual's faces, animals, nature scenes, etc. to help my visualization. I notice, however, that my mind already is extremely adept at visualization. But if I try this chapter 2 visualization exercise by starting with a pencil or a clock as Bardon suggests, it seems quite difficult. On the other hand, if I recall an emotionally charged memory, some event or encounter which was dramatic and intense, I can visualize the memory as if I am again within it.

Emotional involvement, mood, and enthusiasm, then, play a role in the development of our senses. You might try testing your visual abilities in terms of seeing which memories are more clear in terms of visual detail. This kind of recollection serves to activate at least temporarily the part of your brain which relates to visualization. Try visualizing ordinary objects after you evoke some memories with strong visual content.

A Van Gogh painting of a chair, a table, or flowers exudes a feeling of life. If you bring to these exercises an artist's appreciation of color, form, image, detail, texture, and composition, more of the brain and emotions are involved in the exercise. It then becomes easier to get results. If you watch TV, go to the movies, or play computer games, you might try visualizing your favorite characters and scenes. Again, this should serve to remind you of the level of ability you already possess.

Neurolinguists like to tell us how individuals will use different combinations of senses when they solve problems or work through emotions. If you recall someone, you may first see them in your mind. The picture then evokes a feeling of being in the other person's presence. You may see the person as if you are there with them and in the picture or perhaps from a third person perspective in which you are not present. This mental process may continue to where you begin to talk to yourself about this individual so that you describe what you feel or perhaps you recall their voice or a conversation you had with him or her.

There are a great variety of ways individuals employ their five senses in mental processing in everyday life. An attorney may note and be able to recall the body posture and facial expression of every jury member when he argues a case in a court room. When he gets home, he may put aside his astute powers of observation and fail to make eye contact with his wife or notice what his children are feeling.

A movie director may exercise total command over his material. He can visualize what each camera on the set is recording and imagine every scene in the script from a number of angles. As the shoot continues, he is already editing the film in his mind selecting which shots to splice together to establish the mood and dramatic

presentation he is after. But when he is at a party he acts timid and vulnerable. Other people seem to invade his personal space. He has switched from dominant visual and auditory senses to a feeling mode.

My kids have an interesting way of visualizing the characters when they read a novel. One of my children uses the same pictures over and over again transposing the picture of a character from one book to another book the way Hollywood uses well-known actors to play parts in different movies. Another of my children makes up new pictures of the people in each novel he reads. When I read, I tend to visualize the scenery very carefully and also I hear the conversations as if they are spoken aloud but I usually do not go into any detail in visualizing the characters. I will do so from now on.

Long ago, I once met a theosophist who told me he could look at a table or a car in front of him and then shrink it down into a tiny picture while the real object vanished from his sight. I thought at the time that this ability was very exotic. I had trouble imagining being able to do that. Now it seems perfectly natural to edit pictures in my mind in any way I wish.

Over the years, I have noticed the cultural difference in how the five senses were developed in different esoteric systems. A Tibetan lama would casually tell a student to go sit in the temple for six hours and visualize the Tibetan writing for Om. This was no big deal because the lama could visualize in his mind hundreds of entities from different mandalas all at the same time. In one practice, individuals in the British Isles visualize an entire castle and explore each room. In doing pathworking in various systems such as druidry, the individuals walk through forests, visualize groves and stone circles and explore whole landscapes from nature during meditation.

About six years ago, I took a class in the psychology of imagery. The teacher pointed out that she was one of the only two teachers in the United States who taught this subject. She tried to present the whole gamut of what was available in psychological research involving visualization. This covered topics such as healing, relaxation, various psychological experiments, physiological research, etc. Since she had also been a Zen practitioner for decades, she had a feel for the topic. But I was still amazed at how incredibly arrogant and uninformed conventional psychologists are in regard to the encyclopedia of practices from around the world which use visualization as a central component. Psychology seems to be preoccupied with the conscious mind and immediate subconscious. It is otherwise sweetly oblivious to the nature of spiritual practice.

In ancient druidry, the bards would spend seven years training in darkness. Besides enhancing their sensitivity to sound, this practice would allow them to visualize images which arises from deep within the unconscious. In a Tibetan practice involving dream yoga, the students spend a number of days living in a house in complete darkness. This again enhances the ability to visual and in particular to enter a dream state so that the images you are visualizing are real to you.

Though the Bardon exercise in visualization is clear, you as a student are free to practice visualizing anything you wish. Colors, for example, are part of the cosmic language in Quabbalah. They have a vibration and can be used to alter consciousness and evoke different states of trance. You can practice visualizing objects and shapes using the entire color spectrum in your beginning practices.

Though Bardon obviously wants the beginning student to practice visualizing ordinary objects, you can also practice visualizing symbols. You can visualize Tarot cards, yidams and tantras, places of beauty or great works of art. For a man, a woman is a symbol of

attaining completion--she is the unknown, the part of himself he has not yet met as well as being a companion, partner, lover, friend, etc. Consequently, the right female image can influence, awaken, or stimulate every aspect of his nervous system and chakras within his body.

If you enter a meditative state in which you are relaxed and your mind is clear, you can contemplate problems or experiences and see them in symbolic terms. Ira Progoff explores this approach. There are, for example, your inner and outer experiences in life. You can find an image for the outer and also for the inner.

You then take the two images and hold them in your mind allowing them to interact in their own way until a third image appears which represents their connection. This third image offers you new insight and clarity. It grants new feelings and ways of being alive.

You can also visualize sigils, symbolic or occult diagrams which represent the energy of spiritual beings. If you visualize a sigil with the correct color in front of you with energy and concentration, it serves to connect you to the spirit. If you have psychic ability or are sensitive, you may be able to sense this connection. If you use enough force when you concentrate and imagine the sigil on the physical, astral, and mental planes, this action can draw the spirit of the sigil into your room.

The eye does not just receive impressions. It transmits and projects pictures, feeling, energy, and it forms connections. In martial arts, they talk about a hard versus a soft gaze. If you are tense, the tension narrows what you are able to see. If you relax and observe your environment from your Tan Tien or the center of your abdomen, your observation is more alert. You see more detail and possibilities.

If you gaze from your heart, you project healing energy. When lovers are together, their eyes influence each others' auras. Looking at another with acceptance and love is like a prayer. It uplifts and blesses.

Bardon mentions that visualization relates to the power of will. Obviously, having a keen sense of shape, location, and spacial geometry enhances your sense of being able to manage your environment. You can think in terms of action, change, and movement. The power to visualize is like being able to say, "I see things as they are now but I can also imagine them differently."

In effect, you extend your visualization beyond the spacial sense. You visualize things in terms of time. You can then say, "At this point in time things are like this. At another point in time things can be changed. I can see how to get from here to there."

For a magician who works with akasha, a visual image is not just a picture within his mind. Visualizing a person or spirit links the magician's mind directly to the other. The magician sees the other's aura and energy on different planes. With a slight shift in consciousness, the magician not only links to the other but holds within his consciousness the other's energy field. He identifies with it and experiences it from within himself.

On a more simple level, images and visualizations can be used to alter our outlook and understanding. Individuals' emotions often limit their imagination to the present. They can not visualize a situation or relationship in a way inconsistent with what they are currently feeling. The imagination and heart are slaves to emotions.

Many traditions use various methods to get around this. Jose Silva outlines a concise method. You visualize your situation or problem exactly as it is right now. You see this as a picture on a white screen in front of you. You move the screen, for example, over to the right. Now visualize a second picture. This one is of the same situation or problem when it is the way you would like it. You

see the future right now and the problem solved. You then move this picture over to the right.

Now you visualize a third picture. In this picture, you see yourself as being in a situation in the future where this problem no longer comes up. You have moved beyond it and are involved in another stage of life. The process of working with these three pictures is that it enables individuals, through the process of visualizing, to feel what it is like to be free of whatever is holding them back. The emotional bottleneck or feeling of being closed in is temporarily overcome. The mind is then able to think about how to bring these situations about.

Sight relates to will also in that light is a function of fire. Light and fire are powerful, expansive, explosive, and dynamic. They refine and transform. By visualizing, you illuminate the emotions and the unconscious. When you look at the world through the heart of compassion or the eyes of divine love, you realize the astonishing things which can be brought into being. An image which is held with powerful concentration gathers energy to itself and seeks to manifest as reality.

AUDITORY

"Hearing is the sense which binds the other senses together in harmony. It is also the sense most concerned with interaction between human beings: it is the foundation of language, which is communication between minds, and music which is the communication between hearts." Elizabeth Nash

"Magick involves a great deal of listening and a little technique." Peter Beagle

"I sometimes fool deer. They think I am one of them because I can stand perfectly still for a half hour listening to the wind. I sometimes fool gnomes. They think I am one of their own because it is clear that silence is my home. I sometimes fool spirits of the earthzone. They think I am like unto them--a guardian of the world--because in my heart is a void, an empty space where you can hear the stars sing, the song in the wind, and discover the peace from which the Earth dreams Her dreams."

You practice sounds in a similar way to visualizing a picture. You concentrate on different sounds again seeking to be free of distraction and from allowing other senses to interfere. Take any sounds from your environment and practice imagining you can hear them one by one. There is the song of the bird, the cat meowing, the dog barking, the clock ticking, wind howling, lightning thundering, different musical instruments, etc.

Sound, like sight, also has psychological, spiritual, and magical aspects. Children who grow up in homes where the family often sings are more adjusted and outgoing. Song carries with it a sense of joy and a willingness to express feeling.

In a more magical vein, you can take a song or symphony and reduce all your impressions and feelings about that song into one note. You then allow that note to be the only thing in your awareness. In practicing the cosmic language, the student adds notes to the color and sensation concentrations.

Bardon also mentions how the undines practice tone magick. By singing one note, a undine can create a magical space of enchantment and love. A sylph suggested to me that in order to better understand the mind of sylphs I should practice imagining a different note for each weather phenomenon I observe. The

thunderstorm has a note as do the trade winds , fog, clouds, the mountain breeze as well as the entire sky. Translating weather into sound attunes your mind to the air element in which the sylph exists.

Also note that words are powerful. Words can command, bind, illuminate, set free, and heal. They can convey love and inflict pain. When we use our voice, we are free to speak from any or all of our seven chakras, from our heart, from our mind, from our spirit exerting our will or offering kindness and understanding.

Again, some individuals will find sound concentration exercises easy and others will find them extremely difficult. Just as someone who paints portraits is more likely to observe and recall faces better than other people, it is probably easier for a musician to recall tones and sounds better than others. Similarly, the dramatist who writes dialogue has developed an ear for diction and spoken language. Try to recall as many different individual voices as you can. Start with people you know and also actors you like.

In terms of professions, a skilled therapist, for example, is a excellent listener. He or she notices the subtle changes in voice. By noticing the loudness, speed, intonation, pitch, diction, and word choice, the psychologist discerns changes in emotions and attitude in the other individual. A friend, for example, in listening carefully creates a psychic space in which another person can feel safe and accepted. Listening is itself a magical power. Like akasha, it offers another a chance to grow and to discover who they are.

Scientists have observed that the ear not only registers sounds. The mechanism in the inner ear can transmit measurable sounds as well. If you think the notes of a song, your ear emits those notes though the auditory signal is very weak.

There is a documented case of a blind teenager who makes clicks with his mouth. He then hears the echo of these clicks as they bounce off objects around him. Using this ability, he can ride a bicycle through a parking lot around the cars and poles because his mind fashions an accurate image of what is present.

TACTILE

"Only touch can make the world completely real: it is the first and last link which connects us to life and to each other. 'Keep in touch' we say; 'Let us not lose touch.' And if our emotions are affected by something, we say that it is 'touching.' It is the most basic of all the senses, the foundation: it is also the most generous and compassionate."

Elizabeth Nash

For practicing the sense of touch, Bardon mentions concentrating on sensations such as hunger, thirst, tiredness, etc. One of the special features of Bardon's system is his emphasis on the four elements. He works with these constantly. In the most basic sense, for the earth element you concentrate on weight; for air, weightlessness; for fire, heat; and for water, coldness. The heat and coldness also produce phenomena relating to electricity and magnetism.

These four sensations are used in many ways in meditation. If you relax your muscles, the blood vessels open and the skin becomes warmer. Some Tibetan yogis can raise their body temperature seventeen degrees and sustain that temperature even in a freezing cold environment. In magick, by concentrating on these sensations, you create energy fields which are, in effect, like the domains where elemental beings such as salamanders, sylphs, undines, and gnomes dwell.

As I have mentioned elsewhere, I have had the hardest time

concentrating on hot and cold sensations. Finally, after visualizing a universe full of fire I can evoke a heat sensation and sustain that without using the other senses. For the cold sensation, I have actually practice holding ice cubes in my hands and doing this repeatedly until my brain could figure out how to reproduce this sensation through concentration. It has taken me years to get something so basic but now the concentration is easy and feels natural.

In exploring body sensations, we are opening the doors to our entire nervous system. Addictions, obsessions, and fascinations all involve strong bodily sensations rooted in neurology and biochemistry. Nonetheless, these sensations are susceptible to conscious control. There are bodily sensations involved in any form of bonding with others. The more acquainted you are with your body--your breathing, your ability to relax, the feel of your stomach, your heart, your internal organs, and the whole spectrum of body sensations from prenatal to adult--the more creative you can be in interacting with others.

In shamanistic practice, individuals often imagine themselves as various animals. This serves to heighten sensory impressions. It also introduces the individuals to the bodily sense and the drives and desires within the animal world. In working with magick, we often discover and meet within ourselves desires and instinctual energies which are outside the band of normal consciousness. We feel the fire of the tiger, the acute alertness of the deer, the mesmeric concentration of the snake, and the inner strength of the bear. Consequently, it is important not to ignore or underestimate the influence of bodily sensations. By knowing them well and working through them with our minds, we strengthen our consciousness and expand our ability to feel.

Some individuals have a remarkable sensitivity to touch and the sensory perception it opens up. Scientists have studied how some individuals can sense earthquakes as or before they are happening. They sense the low wave frequencies earthquakes give off. Some individuals can sense changes in another person's body temperature across a room. Empaths can often feel the sensations in other's bodies as pain, excitement, and strong emotions. The other person's sensations manifest in the empaths' bodies as if it is their own.

Touch grants a fantastic array of experiences when it is mastered. Mastering touch is almost like being able to relive any memory as if you are there and it is happening right now. You can enter any dream or imaginary scene and live within it and experience it as real. The mind has this capacity but you learn to control it consciously through practice.

In psychic terms, there is a rolfer who works with deep massage on other's bodies. He discovers that through only imagination he can get the same results as he can when he physically manipulates their bodies. If he concentrates on another person and uses only his mind to work on their muscles, he can present photos of the individual before and after his work showing the way in which their posture, musculature, and spine have changed alignment.

In clairfeeling, you extend your touch anywhere. You can be with another person who is not present. Space and distance are suspended. But first it helps to be able to imagine any sensation you can experience so clearly it feels real.

TASTE

The sense of taste can be explored magically in that you become more sensitive to the food you are eating and prepare your body to better digest it. You sense in advance how a food is going to affect

you and what its quality and energy level are.

In more mundane terms, taste and eating are very grounding. Like the sense of smell, taste strengthens the stability of your consciousness. Sight, sound, and touch can be used to take you away into imaginary worlds but focusing on the taste of something you are eating brings you back immediately to your body.

In one system of telepathy, the teacher pointed out it is probably easier for most people to transmit tastes and smells to each other than pictures or sounds. These sensations engage a more primitive part of our brains. These sensations have a very strong connection to our bodies and so they can also short circuit our thinking process. Eating and drinking have a remarkable ability to change mood especially because they are so closely tied to pleasure and satisfaction.

A mediator I know once came upon a man and woman fighting violently. She acted on her intuition not knowing what to do and went up and knocked on the door. She told the man she had the pizza he had ordered with anchovies and mushrooms. If you think about tasting a food, you can not remain angry. The sense of taste switches the mind from the picture of the other person's face and the sound of the words being spoken. Taste is not part of the neurological process which anger utilizes to sustain its intensity.

There are a lot of cultural, psychological, and physiological aspects to taste and our choice of diet. We often associate feelings of well-being and festivity, family life and love with certain diets and menus. Switching to a different diet, an individual may get the same or better nutrition but lose something in the process.

The mind may not pick up on it but the body is uncomfortable with the change. An individual may change diets for philosophic reasons thinking its a great idea but he may sabotage his sense of enjoyment by doing so. The politically correct diet actually produces more stress for his body because he has lost his childhood sense of well-being and association with past memories. To overcome this, bring good feelings to the food you eat.

As you practice taste, try to notice your own cultural and psychological preferences. Notice too the vibration of the food and the qualities conveyed through taste. Working with gnomes, they take me directly into minerals and elements so that my consciousness identifies with the molecular and atomic vibrations. You can do this also with an apple, wine, vegetables, and so forth. You sense the vitality and qualities of the food you are eating when it was in its original form on a farm. You can sense how your various organs and the digestive track respond to food as it is breaking down and being absorbed into your system. I used to tell people what they had eaten during their last meal because my stomach could feel what was in their stomach and I would then get a picture of the food they ate.

To some extent, Bardons exercise of absorbing vitality into your body through the pores of your skin relates to the sense of taste and digestion. You are turning your skin into a tongue and a mouth. Like the leaves of a tree which absorbs sunlight and carbon dioxide, your body is gathering energy directly from the air. Breathing and digestion both provide usable energy and nutrition for the blood.

Though pranayama is often put in a mental or religious context, as an exercise, there is a very primal and instinctual aspect of the psyche which is being activated during this practice. Pranayama takes the ancient stalking and devouring of the prey by the predator and transforms it into a very refined and spiritual activity. Air becomes a supplementary energy source.

SMELL

Smell, like taste, serves to ground us. Animals have a high developed olfactory sense. They can discern a vast array of scents.

Incense is used in evocation, to supports states of trance, and it is also used in aromotherapy. In psychic work, some individuals may learn how to smell energy. You can smell when there is an astral presence of a spirit or some other entity near. They can smell the vibration of a house or location. In this way, the sense of smell alerts an individual to the quality of the space they are entering.

In another way, smell can take on a symbolic and intuitive function. "Something doesn't smell right," someone will say. Their intuition is using the sense of smell to convey a gut feeling or psychic impression to the conscious mind.

I don't know anyone who does this, but as I think about it I notice I can smell an aroma for the seven chakras of the body of someone I am concentrating on. With each chakra, I discern a scent and also I get a picture of the flower which goes with that scent. The scent offers me direct immersion in the other's energy. It is not for nothing that the chakras are sometimes referred to as lotus blossoms. They radiate energy but you can learn to perceive this energy with any of your five senses.

The Five Senses

If you observe carefully different world leaders, you can notice something they share in common. Their voice, eyes, and face are used in combination to extend their power and their ability to connect to others. One of these three things will often be very hard, tough, and commanding. Another will be very soft, gentle, and inviting almost to the point of seduction. The third may then be neutral--it is steady and unchanging.

One individual may have a voice which is warm, empathic, and almost hypnotic in its resonance. But his face is like a steel mask while his eyes are clear, shiny, and affirming. Another individual has a harsh, argumentative voice but his face is warm like a teddy bear while his eyes are vulnerable and shy.

It the combination which enables these leaders to reach out and connect even to their enemies on an unconscious level without compromising their own strength. By studying how we and others use our senses both to receive and to project energy, we are extending our magical skills. In the earthzone, the spirit Amagestol's eyes see oneness and love and his touch is kindness and acceptance. But he speaks with the voice of prophecy, of what shall be. His voice calls things into being. It is a dynamic combination and through working with this spirit, you can learn to approximate his abilities which are fabulous for resolving conflicts and attaining harmony. The study of the human aura and the aura of spirits, then, compliment each other.

Another aspect of the five senses is that the human brain has cells for each sense which are located within areas of the brain relating to the other four senses. When you see, you are also hearing, tasting, smelling, and touching and so on with each sense. You can take, therefore, any sense and get a sensory impression from another sense to replace it.

Men enjoy looking at women. The sight activates the brain to release endorphins and opiates into the blood stream. They don't just see women. They feel an entire spectrum of emotions at the same time.

This may seem rather mundane but there is a spiritual side to it. The Dalai Lama during the Kalachakra initiation invites the five thousand individuals present to enter his body and pass through his chakras. His body serves as a vehicle of initiation for transforming consciousness.

If you place your mind in the Dalai Lama's heart chakra, you experience an infinite sea of compassion. It is perfectly natural for him to say, "As long as suffering remains to sentient beings, I will remain to serve." This is the voice of his heart chakra.

I experience his compassion as a tactile sense--as being immersed in a sea of water whose quality is love. Tibetan monks, on the other hand, practice visualizing the yidam figures of Avalokiteshvara whom the Dalai Lama represents in incarnation and they practice his mantra of Om Mani Padma Hum. In this way, they attune themselves to enlightened compassion mainly through the use of sight and hearing.

The point is that we perceive with our five senses in our immediate environment. Through training and concentration, we can learn to use our senses to see spiritual realms and perceive with illumination. Then the ordinary and the spiritual become woven together. The entire universe is one energy field and we are all joined within it.

The senses also relate to akasha, that is, they each open to akasha. Practicing concentration with a sense is a way of refining that sense's ability to perceive higher vibrations. On the other hand, one way to become psychic is to suspend the element related to that sense so the sense no longer perceives in the physical world. Freed of the tie to the immediate environment, the sense then perceives on the inner planes or through space and time.

If you stare at a crystal ball, you tire or wear out the fire in the eyes so that your eyes then receive impressions from the astral plane. If you dance or listen to the right music, your ears lose their air element and you then hear spirits speaking to you and so forth. This is kind of a tricky procedure since it may exhaust your nervous system and be difficult to restore harmony when you are done. If you master the elements, you can replace the energy you use up in this procedure. You could also just concentrate into your eyes a quality of light which is itself clairvoyant and then you accomplish the same results or better.

Buddhists like to point out that the five senses are empty, that is, they have no inherent existence or intrinsic nature which sustains their being. Form and emptiness, matter and akasha are interexchangeable. For Buddhists, the mind has no need to attach itself to anything--it is pure, luminous openness.

Undines know this according to their own element. Water extends the sense of touch through the entire oceans of the earth. You can touch what is in front of you and you can touch what is anywhere else. They know that you can create love just by feeling. If you imagine the watery energy of love, sweet caresses, and oneness, they come into being through the power of your mind and heart. Some undines are magical in that their aura automatically creates love in and around whatever it touches.

For the Taoist, the five senses tie into the vitality and organ energy in the body. By mastering them, you are gaining the ability to conserve and refine the chi in your body. Ideally, the Taoist would use this saved life force to attain astral if not physical immortality.

For the poet, the five senses are gates of perception, doors which open to infinity. For the mystic, the senses exist so we can give and receive circulating love with all other beings throughout the universe. For the magician, the five senses represent the power of

spirit to materialize its purposes. You learn to use and master your senses on each of the four planes. Then you are able to reach your highest level of creativity.

In this chapter, we work at attaining astral equilibrium with the four elements by (1) Fight or control, (2) auto-suggestion and/or (3) transmutation or transforming it into its opposite quality.

To review, in the psychic exercise for the first chapter, we began the practice of introspection. We recorded our positive and negative qualities of character using the four elements as a guide. We then rated the relative strength of the different qualities within us dividing them into three groups. This gave us a kind of mirror of the soul, a reference point for quickly viewing our state of astral equilibrium.

The task in chapter two is to establish a balance between the four elements. For Bardon, "The scholar ought, therefore, to endeavor quickly and surely to get rid of those passions which most hinder him from being successful in the magic art." And, "The refinement of character should be aspired after, during the entire course, but, as early as on this level, faults rapidly gaining ground and bad qualities handicapping development in a higher order, ought to be eradicated."

Since in the next chapter, chapter 3, we begin accumulating the four elements in the astral body, Bardon insists "Before starting on the training for this step (Chapter 3), the astral equipoise of the elements in the soul has to be established by introspection and self-control unless you wish to do mischief to yourself." Bardon asserts that "Without a balance of the elements in the astral body or in the soul, there is no possible progress or rise."

At the beginning of Chapter 2, Bardon discusses autosuggestion. If you are working on a personal fault such as a lack of enthusiasm or conviction, the idea is to phrase your self-suggestion in the present tense or imperative: "I am full of enthusiasm," or, "I have strong conviction." You then practice this autosuggestion by repeating the phrase a number of times, especially as you fall asleep at night or wake up in the morning. Bardon says, "The main point is that you do imagine your wish as being realized already and having actual existence."

It would seem that from Bardon's perspective, the subconscious--the source of faults, weaknesses, and passions--views the conscious mind as being kind of stupid. People say what they want, are planning, or wishing for, but they do not really believe it. The conscious self acts to defeat itself by lacking conviction when it speaks. To not be completely certain about succeeding when you make a wish is to plan for your own failure. And what is far worse from the subconscious point of view is that the conscious mind fails all reasonable tests when it comes to imagining in a concrete and graphic way what it wishes to be or to accomplish.

Since part of the job of the subconscious is to contain and store energy, it is pretty much a waste of its time and resources to cooperate with the conscious mind. The conscious mind acts arbitrarily, unreasonably, impulsively, and without any regard for the real issues of life. It is as if the conscious self intentionally refuses to speak the language of the subconscious or show any respect when it makes its requests.

The remedy for this situation is to demonstrate real conviction, feeling, and imagination when seeking to bring about a change in yourself. The conviction is in part demonstrated by imagining that what you want is real right now in this moment. So again, as Bardon points out, you make your wish in the present tense without any hesitation or doubt: For example, you say "I am full of enthusiasm" if your problem is apathy or being phlegmatic.

To this you add feeling. You have to search your own memory and experiences with others until you conjure up a completely convincing set of examples about what it is to be enthusiastic. Then you put yourself within those images or reflect on them until you can accurately reproduce in yourself the feeling of enthusiasm. At this point, your subconscious will be able to say, "Ah, now you are speaking my language. Now I know what you mean when you say, 'I am full of enthusiasm.'"

And finally, you have to explore with your imagination what it means for your wish to be completely real right now, as something already accomplished. Bardon mentions the great advantage of using autosuggestion when you are falling asleep or waking up from sleep. Then your brain waves shift from beta through theta to alpha. When you wake up from sleep, the brain waves will remain in alpha for around five minutes. If you practice autosuggestion during this time, you have a stronger access to and communication with your subconscious.

This is where daydreaming or imaginative explorations take on the power of magick. Again, what would that be like if what you wish for has already become real? Your subconscious would sure like to know the answer to that question. This is because the subconscious has to take all the energy it has allotted to one set of behaviors, beliefs, and emotions and rechannel that energy into a new set of behaviors, beliefs, and emotions.

If you just sit there saying what you want to be and feeling it as real, you are still making a half-hearted effort from the subconscious point of view. You have not really done your homework when it comes to communicating what you want to your subconscious.

Your subconscious wants you to enter a dream of the future and walk around inside of it and experience it as if it is totally real right now. Get involved with details. Use all your five senses. Make the experience so real and graphic that it feels as if you are living it right now. The imagination has to convince itself that what it envisions, at least during the practice, is absolutely real in the here and now.

This is not asking too much. You see, the subconscious produces dreams every single night which seem completely real to the dreaming mind. If you want to succeed with the subconscious, you have to use its own tools and language. You have to become clever and subtle enough to convince your subconscious that you are able to take over some of its functions.

If the dream of what you wish to be is a 100% real to you within your astral body, then you already radiate the energy of what it is like to be what you want. Your actions and thoughts then change in order to fall into alignment with this new self-image, energy, feeling, and thought. This is my summary or version of Bardon's perspective on autosuggestion.

If you want a quick and easy method which many individuals find extremely useful, you might try Jose Silva's exercise in mind control. This involves visualizing three pictures one after the other. First, you visualize your problem on a white screen in front of you. Imagine all aspects of the situation. This is the way things are right now.

Next, you move this screen off to the left side. Then on another white screen you visualize the solution to the problem, that is, exactly how you would like things to be. This is a point in the future where the problem is solved. You look at it right now in front of you. Again, make it real and convincing. Now move this screen also off to the left side.

Finally, you visualize yourself on another screen in front of you. This is a further point in the future where the problem no longer even comes up. You are altogether beyond it and involved in other things.

As an exercise in Silva Mind Control, this is an exercise you can do in several minutes. It is often very helpful for individuals who can not even imagine what a resolution of their problem would be like. I like to take exercises like this and expand on them. I practice them not for a few minutes but more like for a half hour or more. I make them into a deep contemplative exercise.

In this case, I continually test myself to see if I feel and can imagine myself being 100% within the picture I am visualizing. Since some of the qualities we seek to embody within ourselves are not only completely new to our experience but also involve remarkable psychological and spiritual virtues, the visualization is also a high art of self-transformation. It is the thought, the feeling, the image, and the energy--all of these at once which we are generating or creating within ourselves during the practice.

Note also that ritual can be used to reinforce autosuggestion. It is common in new age seminars to write down the problem you have and then surrender or give that problem to the fire element. You place the paper on which you have written your problem into the fire in the solemn presence of others. If done in the right group and in the right mood, this can be helpful. The action lays hold of your subconscious on a deep level.

Bardon mentions working simple elemental magick like the above later on in his first book. Bardon also mentions how one time he was concentrating his wish so intensely on the surface of a mirror that the mirror actually shattered. Right before I became acquainted with Bardon's book, I had been visualizing myself in some of the major arcana of the Tarot cards every day for about four months. One of the cards was The Magician. Sometimes you have to work at your wish with a lot of concentration and persistence.

An Astral Equilibrium Meditation

When I use my psychic intuition and focus in on what Bardon wants in regard to astral equilibrium, it seems to me that he wants the student to experience first hand the state of astral equipoise. You should be able to feel what it is like when the four elements are in harmony and balanced in your astral body. Though this is obviously jumping ahead, I would like to explain a little more about this.

You might try this as an exercise. Imagine dark violet light shining in and around your body. This light represents akasha. The light shines outward from you penetrating through space and time. And you are this light. You are after a physical sensation of penetrating through space and time with your consciousness. Nothing limits what you can feel, observe, think, and experience.

Now add to this identification with akasha the qualities of the four elements as they act within the personality. You see and feel yourself embodying the powers of water--you are loving, sensitive to others, empathic, vivacious, nurturing, and tender. Add to this the powers of air--you are bright, alert, detached, objective, articulate, understanding, and wise.

Now add the powers of earth--you are solid, stable, rugged, persevering, hard-working, shrewd, practical, down-to-earth, and attentive to details. And also add the powers of fire--you are in charge, determined, committed, commanding, full of conviction and certainty about your purposes, dynamic, and courageous.

Take some time and blend the four elemental sets of qualities into the akasha which radiates from your body. Move between the four elements until you gain the sense that each is fully present within you. Feel the confidence and reassurance which comes from having this harmony. And notice how each element is complimented, supported, and strengthened by being aligned with the other three

elements.

Having the balance of the four elements within the astral body is a highly creative state. It grants an individual great adaptability and flexibility. Magicians often use magick circles during their evocational practices. The four directions often symbolize the four elements. But establishing magical equilibrium within yourself is a way of internalizing the magick circle. It offers a great deal of protection by insuring that your aura is not vulnerable to being influenced or infiltrated by outside energies.

See also my essay on Focusing under Transpersonal Psychology on my web site. I often will focus on a personal problem or difficulty following Eugene Gendlin's six steps. But I extend Gendlin's method by taking more time and employing more concentration just as do with Jose Silva's exercise. I change the exercise into a magical form of contemplation which works more directly with energy than what these men usually imagine. Note that while Silva's visualizations involve the sense of sight, Gendlin's focusing is for those who work more with the tactile or kinesthetic sense.

I also like to use Ira Progoff's journalizing method and method of dialoguing. Progoff is more verbal or auditory oriented though he has you writing things down. Again, there are a vast number of ways to interact with the subconscious. You can intervene and change your behavior directly as is done in some methods of behavioral psychology. Or you can use a more cognitive approach monitoring and reframing your thoughts.

You can engage in introspection and contemplation by processing your feelings. You can turn personal problems into a spiritual quest or reframe them as a journey through a spiritual landscape of the soul. This is a kind of pathworking, symbolic exploration, tantra, or free association in a state of trance. You can do all of these one after the other or all at once. Self-transformation is a vast area of study and many methods and resources are available and should be available to those who pass this way.

Some Personal Comments

Years ago, I pursued this exercise on magical equilibrium with great effort. I would emphasize the importance of attaining magical equilibrium along with Bardon. Before an individual enters a spiritual universe through opening his psychic senses and spiritual intuition, he needs to have mastered the habit of being fully attentive to accomplishing every responsibility in his daily life. If you can do this, your personality is then defined by clear boundaries. Mystical feelings and cosmic awareness do not blur or confuse your responses. There is no hazy ambiguity or emotional undercurrent present when you interact with others.

In astral equilibrium, we are pursuing character qualities associated with how we act in our everyday lives. We are making the ordinary into a spiritual training ground. In doing this, we are reinforcing our will so it becomes as strong as steel. This is absolutely necessary since a magician can not afford to be weak or carry excess emotional baggage from the past.

And this brings us to great paradox in this exercise. If you find a loose thread in a shirt, you can snap it off. But if you pull on that thread even gently, sometimes you will rend the fabric. You discover the material is flawed almost to the point of being worthless.

If you find a leak in the hull of a wooden boat, you can patch it. But if you push a needle into the wood, you may find the outer varnished surface has dry rot hidden beneath it. The needle slips

right through the wood as if it is cheese or plaster board. In this case, a much larger area needs to be replaced.

The same is sometimes true about our exercise. You can say to yourself, "I am going to work on my personal faults and weaknesses," and then you proceed to do so. This can be like spring cleaning of a house. You perform annual maintenance. You wash the windows and steam clean the carpets and throw out the junk you have been accumulating over the past year.

But your attitude of self-questioning and probing may be the same as holding in your hands a key to a door into your psyche which you would never otherwise unlock. One time my father was checking the slanting wall of the attic in our house. He found a lever hidden out of sight. He pulled on it and a hidden door clicked open. The door lead into a secret room which was used for stockpiling liquor smuggled into the United States from Canada during Prohibition. The door was disguised to look exactly like the wood supporting the shingles of the roof.

The psyche is similar. If you find the latch and then give something ordinary a gentle push, you may find yourself gazing into an entire dungeon of memories, pain, and unresolved conflicts. These may be in part your own and they may also be an accumulation of karmic debt handed down from previous generations. These may also seem like unexplored, forbidden, and taboo areas of the collective unconscious carefully cordoned off and sealed away from the emotions and instincts acceptable to our society. Our cultures often are built on great strengths but they all conceal areas of great darkness in their foundations.

To put it simply, if you wish to be, for example, more assertive, you may run into an inner conflict. Part of you may wish to not be assertive until you have overcome the abuses of power exercised for generations in your family. On the other hand, if you wish to be more sensitive to others' feelings, as you develop your empathy you may feel you are adrift on an ocean of pain. These are not your personal feelings. Instead, your empathy comes wrapped up in a profound insight into the quiet desperation and sorrow hidden in others' lives. For some individuals, such insight is overwhelming and too much to handle.

Our simple exercise, then, is like an individual going into see a therapist. The therapist asks, "What do you want me to do for you?" The individual replies, "I want to be more in charge of my life. I want to use my time better so I can get more done." The therapist then asks, "Tell me about what you feel is holding you back from doing this?" And shortly thereafter the client recalls after years of repression the memory of how he or she was raped as a child. This actually happened in a class I was teaching. A woman suddenly recalled and then related to the group--a bunch of navy sailors who had little ability to understand--this incredibly intense personal trauma. Suddenly the simple task of learning time management, of setting priorities and goals, evokes a pain which seems at first impossible to bear.

Perhaps an individual inherits a susceptibility for alcoholism, drug abuse, insanity, or violence from his family or past. There can be any number of nightmares ready and waiting to awaken if you engage in self-exploration. These can be are so deeply rooted in yourself you do not know how or where to begin working on them.

Consequently, in some encounter and therapy groups, the members are kept focused on the present and on the specific behaviors and feelings they can actually change. The deeper feelings and motivations which are more diffuse and less susceptible to conscious control are carefully screened out and pushed off to the side. There are often immediate advantages to this approach. Even small success in changing your behavior, self-talk, and feelings build

self-confidence and strengthens the individual's will.

The downside of this approach is that the individual's psyche then becomes like a house with some locked rooms containing the unknown. The problem is that an individual who strengthens his will and identity without processing his deeper emotions and fully exploring the depths of himself lacks well-being and inner peace. He is not fully at home in the world of his psyche. On some level, he knows there are inner barriers--questions he must not ask, feelings he must never awaken, and dreams he must never dream.

This may seem like a subtle point but if you are going to learn to exert your full will or open your five senses to perceiving on the inner planes, you have to be free of fear. You can not bring your microcosm into harmony with the macrocosm when there are parts of your psyche and history which you can not accept and transform. These barriers to inner life can be observed in others even in ordinary conversations and personal interactions. When you talk to someone, you may find there are parts of them which are not transparent. There are things about them they do not want to talk about not because they are private or personal but because the pain is unresolved. The topic evokes anxiety and denial.

When I review all of Bardon's exercises in his three books on magick, the most difficult exercise for me is establishing magical equilibrium. It is a life long work and there is no end to it. If you study Aikido for forty years with real passion and zeal, you become a sixth don master. If you practice Tai Chi Chuan for forty years with a great master so that you mind becomes one with you inner chi, ten or even twenty men can not push you over when you stand your ground.

If you had the time and money, you could study with the great psychologists of the world earning three Ph.d.'s. You would engage in intense personal work exploring your personal shadow and subconscious. Then, as a therapist and facilitator, you would be able to lead others through the intricate pathways and corridors of their souls through the darkness and pain and back again into healing and light. But the Aikido and Tai Chi master and even the psychologist do not need to attain to astral equilibrium. It is definitely not a requirement of their professions. The idea never enters their imagination.

In my experience, there were two main problems I ran into in first working with establishing astral equilibrium. To begin with, Bardon's first book, Initiation into Hermetics, is for me an incredibly tedious and boring set of exercises. As Bardon points out, these exercises take a nearly superhuman patience and tough endurance to master. Progress, though sometimes rapid, is more often accomplished in millimeters. The time frame is not weeks or months but often years before basic exercises are mastered.

This level of difficulty, however, has some great advantages. For example, such taxing work leaves no room for inflation of ego or for fanatical devotion. Both of these attitudes demand quick results and measure progress by comparing oneself to other human beings. The notion that "I am practicing the highest and greatest magical system on earth" eventually must come to grips with the realization that actually I am practicing the most challenging and demanding magical system on earth.

The fanatical, pious, holier than thou mind set (so commonly found in monasteries, religious organizations, and cults) which says "I am special and superior to others" runs into the realization that Bardon's system demands absolute self-awareness and total self-mastery. You can not afford to carry self-delusions with you when you are constantly exploring unknown worlds both of the imagination and on the inner planes. There is simply no room for

arrogance or self-righteousness.

Akasha, for example, loves to play with young magicians. With more stealth than any archdemon and like a lover with wild passion, it leads new magicians through a maze of self-knowledge to a central encounter with that darkness within themselves which contains their greatest fears. What the lover and the archdemon share in common is they both love to test your boundaries. Though using different methods, they will take you to that very place in yourself which is forbidden and unknown. It is only there that the fire of spirit dwelling within you is unleashed and finally freed.

But a great martial artist, a self-made billionaire, or a masterful politician who overcomes all opposition can still afford to feel superior and indulge him or herself in feeling he is above others. But not a magician. This is because a magician is not in competition with other human beings. His goal is not to dominate, out shine, or out perform others.

His spiritual identity is not defined by his peer group, society, culture, civilization, philosophy, religion, or occult tradition. Instead, the ineffable, wondrous, and magnificent beauty of Divine Providence walks by his side and is his guide. When you have this inspiration in your heart, glory, fame, honor, and power mean very little to you. You can use them to serve your purposes but in themselves they are without merit or interest.

And so the first difficulty--the great amount of work extending over years--requires of you that you have your own inspiration and motivation to sustain your commitment. For me, Bardon provides very little in the way of inspiration and it is a strain for me to try to find a devotional sentence in his books. You could say that this is because of the milieu in which Bardon wrote. He was systematic, analytical, detailed, and required that his students master every single exercise before going on to the next.

Still, when I think about Bardon's work, I recall how I spent three days meditating one time in a stone circle on Mull Island in Scotland. Each stone embodies a different cosmic letter or druid Ogham letter from some ancient time. The energies were placed in those stones as a legacy to be passed down to future generations. One of the stones embodied the cosmic letter R. This is solar energy--dazzling, bright, self-radiant, and eternal light.

But this stone also cloaks itself. When you first approach it and place your hand upon it, it hides and conceals its power and joy lest those who are exposed too quickly before their time become blinded and no longer treasure the experiences of daily life. You have to sit with this stone for a while in complete stillness. Then like an old friend who has mastered all wisdom on our planet, it greets you and invites you to discuss whatever is on your heart and in your mind.

Bardon is like that for me. I see him as a gate keeper or as a dean of admissions to a spiritual college. He is both friendly but he also takes a very close look at your credentials as he evaluates your level of commitment. His books, then, naturally are open, inviting, and also very demanding. They put questions to you which you did not expect and that require you be fully alert and forceful in reply.

The second difficulty I have had with attaining astral equilibrium is that I find there is no continuity in the practice. Psychologists, for example, like to take society for granted. It is the training field and arena in which personality is challenged. For this reason, psychologists like to assist in making individuals successful, creative, satisfied, happy, and fulfilled.

But a magician is not practicing magical equilibrium in order to be more successful and fulfilled within his society. He is striving to attain equilibrium in the midst of other practices involving high magick. He is continuously developing and testing the boundaries

of his imagination as well as learning to enter at will worlds which are invisible to the people around him.

Consequently, in high magick, you continuously bring new treasures of spirit, new insights and fabulous experiences, back with you into your ordinary life. Unless you proceed with great caution and remain in complete charge of your life, these experiences can easily overwhelm and overshadow everything else you are doing. They are all assaults on magical equilibrium. They heighten, twist, or intensify one element over the others. And so you have to work to keep the four elements within yourself in balance. In order words, no matter how much I think I know about myself and my astral body, working with Bardon's system constantly forces me to confront new and unexpected aspects of myself.

Let me put this another way. Studying magick for me is like having a life long relationship with an extremely seductive mistress. She is so incredibly beautiful! With ease, she uncovers my most secret desires. She produces exotic states of intoxication, bliss, and ecstasy so that I really begin to wonder if it would ever be possible to live my life without her.

Don't laugh. I occasionally meet real women like that. One of the goals of magick is to hold conversation with your Holy Guardian Angel or to evoke the highest aspect of your inner spirit--the immortal, eternal, enlightened, and utterly transcendent aspect of yourself. When I casually hold hands with one woman, this transcendent guardian spirit appears visible to my eyes in the room. This psychic result would seem to be one of those odd things which sometimes happen when you practice magick.

Some of Bardon's exercises introduce you to the infinite freedom existing on the inner planes. All four planes open up to you. Then you behold an astonishing universe. Like I say, magick is like an extremely seductive woman--she is completely inside of you and knows your every thought, dream, and desire. Next to her beauty and affection, everything else is pale by comparison.

This of course is also a powerful assault on magical equilibrium. The magick is itself an addiction. You can swear the addiction off by returning again and again to mastering the basic exercises. But even as you work so hard on them she (magick) will come back to you and offer you some new, unexpected gift--a new magical ability or way of seeing or changing the world which is so astonishing and dramatic you fall again under her spell.

Am I just saying what gurus have been hounding on for ages--namely, working with psychic powers and siddhis are a sure way of losing your spiritual path? The glamour automatically inflates the individual's ego and sense of power so that the journey to the higher planes is lost?

I think if I had been able to study directly with Bardon during the late forties and early fifties, my practice would have been completely different. I would have mastered the dense aspects of the four elements. That is, I would have had far more etheric power. My personal will would have been far more than it is now. Bardon would have had me laboring away on the first book for ten years without permitting me to take a peek at his other works. My astral psychic perception would be fabulous.

But this did not happen. Until recently, I knew only a few students who practiced Bardon and they provided very little support. Though I have studied many esoteric traditions, I have worked with no magicians or esoteric lodges. I proceeded on my own.

Consequently, it was very important for me in the beginning to probe the entire metaphysical system Bardon was presenting. I needed to authenticate it and also to make it my own. Early on, I spent much of three years using my psychic abilities to tune into the vast array of spiritual beings whom Bardon describes in such rich

and suggestive detail in his second book on evocation. My goal has been to build a very clear picture of the entire spiritual universe so I could reflect its beauty, majesty, and wonder within my astral body.

For Bardon, astral equilibrium is a state of being in balance and in control of the four elements in your personality. For me, astral equilibrium is this. But it is also a state of rapture, a trance, and an ecstasy in which I feel at one with everything that exists. Jvar, the spirit of Leo in the earthzone who specializes in magical equilibrium, pointed this out to me. He said it is natural for me to radiate the cosmic letter J on the akashic plane. This is a feeling of cosmic love. It fills in for something which is missing in myself.

And so my response to the gurus who complain about magicians pursuing siddhis and magical powers is this: "I have studied this mistress and searched her soul. And she, in turn, has revealed to me her secret, magical name.

"Her name is cosmic love--and nothing in the universe is separate from her beauty. She holds the world within her heart. There is no aspect of life or ideal she places higher than something else. No plane of awareness is pursued or considered to be of greater merit than any other. Truth understands every individual's unique path of fulfillment and also the oneness which sustains the whole."

I would suggest something in addition to the rigorous practice of attaining the magical equilibrium as Bardon describes it. I would suggest that the student right at the beginning explore his or her own sense of the sacred. It is the degree and quality of your inspiration which also empowers you to balance and harmonize the four elements in yourself. To this end, I have included an exercise on transcendence on my web page under this second chapter psychic practice.

Astral Level: Seeking Transcendence I

Part of the task in Bardon's first book, *Initiation into Hermetics*, is to come in contact with your Guardian Angel. You also seek to encounter and to identify with Divine Providence in its four aspects of all-embracing love, power, wisdom, and immortality. These are very high ideals and goals. I suggest, then, at the very beginning of practicing with Bardon that the student take stock of what his own individual sense of the sacred and of transcendence is.

According to the mythologist Joseph Campbell, the first and primary condition any mythology or spiritual training system must fulfill is to awaken and sustain awe and gratitude within us. It is possible to perceive life as radiant with light and wonder. This is a mental realization. It is a matter of perception-- a way of experiencing the world as new.

Life as portrayed by the mythologies of the world has a dimension of mystery. It is both terrifying and fascinating. It is full of horror and wonder. In it, we encounter danger and beauty, the unknown and also true love.

There is a mystical, emotional awakening, or a spiritual rebirth which is essential for living life to the fullest. With it, we are able to step back from our identities and social roles and gain a perspective on who we are. At the same time, through contact with these archetypal domains, we are introduced to a vast, spiritual landscape existing within each of us, a place where we can discover those resources and treasures which best fulfill our lives.

(The following is from my essay on the Spirit Jachil). This first function of any religion or spiritual training system takes us into a state of transcendence. Transcendence develops in us a state of mind which is completely detached and separate from life. And yet

it is so illuminated we are free to embrace all that is within life with both passion and compassion.

The druid, for example, creates in his mind a grove of trees or stone circle on the astral plane. There he is free to meet and interact and to be inspired by all the wise men and women of his tradition. There he meets the Goddess and celebrates the illumination of the sun.

When druid is in his inner plane grove, he is completely there with all of his imagination. It is a waking dream and his well-being and peace are complete. If he finds a difficulty or disturbance within his psyche or if he has a traumatic experience in his personal life, the grove offers him support and insight for working through it.

At the same time, the difficulties in his outer life serve to challenge him to explore more deeply the spiritual resources available within his grove. The journey within must be profound enough to encompass with wisdom and love all that he experiences in life. In this way, his personal problems are captured and transformed through a spiritual quest.

The imagery of transcendence, like the center of a grove or circle, becomes a sacred place where we gather the wisdom and joy from all that we experience in life. It is a place of celebration. Yet we continuously journey outward from the center of the circle in order to grow and to experience new things. Growth involves going outward and focusing ourselves on specific tasks as well as returning within to attain oneness.

The druid has a personal spiritual path symbolized by a personal grove. And yet he also delights in sharing the his path and sacred imagery with others. There is a collective grove to which he also belongs. This grove is where the wise men and women from all ages of his tradition come together to share their experiences and inspiration. This imagery, then, offers reassurance. It keeps him from feelings isolated or stuck. In place of feeling anxiety or desperation when he discovers the darkness within him, he finds joy and strength in the challenges which lie before him. He has the connections and the resources to help him follow his path.

Exercise: Exploring Your Own Transcendence

Take a few minutes and consider what the sacred is to you. That is, what are your greatest sources of inspiration? When and where have you had encounters with the greatest beauty, wonder, awe, and mystery? When did life feel most alive, most precious, full of hope and joy? When did love share with you its greatest treasures and gifts?

These questions are answered by reflecting on your personal experience. But the personal, in this case, also contains transpersonal depths. Feel the light and the energy underlying your experiences. This brings you into contact with sacred. In these moments, you were able to see life from a great distance, as if standing on the outside looking in. But also the depths of life were open to and flowing through you.

Some individuals will imagine and recall specific locations where they have been or specific individuals whom they interacted with. For others, feelings come to the surface. However you wish to recall the sacred, imagine now that you can connect to these experiences again whenever you wish.

The sacred is a place of mind and heart, like the center of the circle, to which you return again and again. It is what you enter into whenever you begin a spiritual journey. It is what guides you and it is to where you return. Our experiences with life enable us to enrich our sense of the sacred. It grows stronger as does our identification

with akasha, the one light that shines throughout the universe who some call Divine Providence.

At the same time, when we are amid a great difficulty, conflict, or state of confusion, we can enter the center of the circle, symbolizing akasha. Then we can undertake a inner plane pathworking or series of meditations in search of the resources and experiences we need in order to be more effective in life. Akasha, the center of the circle, grove, our inner plane temple, or place of the sacred is where we begin our journeys and it is where we return from them.

There is a process of processing, gathering in, and integrating the essence of all we have learned from life. And there is also a joy and conviction we exude as we depart on new journeys into the unknown. From this psychological and spiritual perspective, our difficulties and problems become challenges. They contain the elements of the great work we willingly embrace in order to transform ourselves and the world through the power of love.

Spiritual Community

At the same time, our individual sense of the sacred is not an isolated and private experience. We belong to spiritual communities. There are others like ourselves who wish to taste fully and to celebrate life's great mysteries. Therefore, along side our individual symbolism and imagery of the sacred there is also a collective imagery.

For the druid, there is a personal grove where he goes to work. There is also a collective grove which is a place on the inner planes. Part of our exercise, then, is to continue on and imagine what this place of meeting would be like as well.

In chapter 9 of Initiation into Hermetics, Bardón gives an exercise relating to mastering the four fundamental divine qualities. He says, "The truly wise adept, who always considers the four elements in his development, will represent the concept of God in four aspects according to the laws of the universe, namely, the omnipotence, corresponding to the fire-principle, the omniscience and wisdom belonging to the air principle, the omnipresence with the water principle and the immortality with the earth principle." As you contemplate and enter into these divine qualities, Bardón says, "The meditation has to be so profound, so pervasive and so convincing that the astral body becomes, as it were, identical with the virtue."

Bardón's work emphasizes individual initiative and accomplishment. There is certainly also a collective or community of those who seek to master and to celebrate the highest light of akasha or Divine Providence. As the above quote indicates, for the magician, the divine is represented in four aspects. As an exercise, take any or all of these four aspects and imagine what a community would be like which is committed to embodying these qualities.

If you think of a community of loving individuals, imagine what that would be like. Imagine it as a community in the real world. And imagine and experience it concretely as a inner plane experience. As if all those on our earth who indeed seek to love with all of their hearts are able to meet with each other and to share their vast array of experiences. Visit this place on the inner planes. Make it part of your heart.

Much of magick relates to the power of imagination. If you can imagine something and experience it a 100% as real, then it is much easier for it to manifest. You already embody it within your heart, mind, and feelings. Those in contact with you can sense its presence and influence. These exercises, then, serve to uplift the vibration of the world we are in. The images serve as mental and

astral vehicles for establishing telepathic rapport and communication with others. We are then drawn to, nourished by, and inspired by those who share the same high ideals.

(See also my posting under Asmodel, a spirit of universal and cosmic love, under Planetary Spirits, in which I give four steps for meditating on a community dedicated to the highest ideals of love, light, and service).

Astral Level: Seeking Transcendence II

In my last article on transcendence, I mentioned how I thought it might be advantageous for students of Bardonn to imagine and work with the divine qualities of each of the four elements right at the beginning of their training.

I sometimes am asked by individuals if they can become my student. I usually reply that I myself am a student. I can share my experiences but I am not in a position to take responsibility for guiding another's spiritual life. I have never met anyone in fact who I consider capable of guiding another individual's spiritual life though I see lots of people trying to do so. I imagine we are all responsible for our own spiritual lives.

Nonetheless, speaking for myself, if an individual asked me if he or she was ready to study the Bardonn system, my response would be to ask in return if they have experienced any transcendence.

Briefly, can you detach yourself from life and see it as from a great distance the way the young girl learns to do in Wilder's play, *Our Town*? Having died, she is permitted to return and relive one day of her life. Obviously, there is no room for complaining, for jealousy, envy, or worrying about trivial things when you realize how precious, wonderful, and fragile life is. Detachment belongs to the air element and to some extent so does wonder. There are of course many other aspects of the air element which lead to transcendence. In my essays on the cosmic letter A and the sylph Cargoste I indicate a few.

Do you have any faith or conviction? Faith in one sense is a feeling you discover within yourself that you are united to omnipotent power, to the Creator of the universe. Conviction is a sense of certainty about your ability to accomplish what you intend to do. I know individuals who have been using ceremonial wands for decades who lack conviction and faith. What good is it to practice in a magical tradition for years and to rise through the grades if you can not find at the core of your being that you are united to the Creator of life and the universe? Who are you trying to kid? To such an individual I would have to state my opinion, "You are not ready to enter the Mysteries."

You find things by seeking them. If you don't look, you won't even see what is right in front of you. Faith, conviction, and the omnipotence belong to the fire element. Fire is in every breath, every heartbeat, in lightning, in candles, in the sun and stars, and the entire center of the earth is in effect on fire. Who can live in the presence of so much power and not feel it or find it within oneself? I have discussed some basic exercises with the fire element in my article on the salamander's Tapheth, Aphtiph, and Pyrhum. See also my forthcoming article on the cosmic letter K which pursues specifically issues and problems of faith and omnipotence.

So do not come to me and tell me you have been practicing magick for years and that you have doubts about your faith. I will tell you to go back and start over at the beginning. Find the sources

of power which exists within you. To learn magick, you have to have some magick to begin with and I tell you magick is in every breath, every heartbeat, every thought, every feeling, and every sensation.

On some level, can you love others, even those you hate? A basic question put to those who would undergo initiation is, "Can you accept all the suffering in life as well as all the love?" This is an especially challenging question. It goes to the core of our being, to what it is to feel alive, to what it is to dream, to hope, and seek healing in ourselves and to offer healing to others.

The religions of the world are most clever. They take selfish individuals wrapped up in hatred and greed and dazzle them with truly magnificent ideals of enlightenment, love, wisdom, and divine missions to fulfill. But in any individual, examining each on a case by case basis, you can still find and touch the energy which is hatred, greed, selfishness, jealousy, fear, insecurity, and rage.

So the question remains, in spite of all the religious stuff, the ceremonies, rituals, and service, all the devotion, dedication, and sacrifice--Can you get yourself into a space of mind or heart in which you can embrace all that life is, the suffering and the love? If you can not, the mystery of the water element is hidden from you. The gate is closed, it is sealed, it is locked. All the magical training and the wisdom in the world will not transform you. You may find great power and achieve great things but you yourself will remain locked in heart that is impoverished.

What good is it to call yourself a magician and an initiate if you can not feel the serenity in moonlight so it shines in every cell of your being, the joy which surges through the sea of the stars, or the bliss in the seas of the earth which have nourished and given birth to all life on earth?

To the water element is the transcendence called omnipresence. It is being able to feel others' feelings, to sense the joys and sufferings of their lives as if they are your own. In the Bardon tradition, the practice of omnipresence involves learning to transfer your consciousness into every aspect of nature and every kind of human being and spirit. This practice is at the center of his training. You want wisdom? You want power? You want purposes and work which endure through all ages of the world? Then love with all of your heart.

The earth element, of course, is practical, realistic, solid, and "down to earth." When I study the auras of the various planets in our solar system, I am struck by how much the aura of our planet has to do with building things and making things which endure. If you are serious about life, you seek to leave behind when you are gone something of enduring value, something which enriches life for others. This can be spiritual like contemplation. It can be physical like the Empire State Building. It can be a principle you seek to manifest such as justice and equality as seen in the words of the Constitution of the United States. But whatever the activity, something of value remains and continues on.

This principle of contributing something of enduring value can be very difficult to come to terms with. If anything is true about human civilizations, they rise and fall, they pass away, they fade like grass as the Psalmist says in Psalms 90. The years of our lives are like a dream and then we are no more.

It is a wonderful thing to have a job and work. It plugs you into the economy of your nation and the world. It is one way to participate in this great endeavor called human life. But the psalmist points out as does the Buddha that everything fades away and everything changes. The mystery of the earth element is not

wisdom, power, or love. It is inner silence. It is the stillness in the command, "Be still and know that I am God."

One of things we do in life as we grow up and also as we develop civilizations is to take a hostile world and make a home within it. We take danger and we make peace. We take ignorance and we make wisdom. We take hatred and we make love. There is no end to this process. It is part of what we call life.

The mystery of silence is to understand that everything is transitory and yet to be as responsible as you can for what you control, to contribute whatever you can that is of value. We make a home in the world and yet as the Psalmist says our dwelling place is God. The earth element unites the other three--fire, air, and water--will, wisdom, and love. As we do this, we transform the world with our lives. The world is a better place for our having passed through it.

The question relating to the transcendence in the earth element is most basic--What actions, what substance of value do you intend to contribute to life? To put it another way, I think each person has to answer in his or her heart, "Am I giving all I have to give? Am I giving the best of what I have to give?"

I can not put this question to you nor can I hear your answer as if I am your Zen master listening to see if you have answered my koan. You answer this question in the presence of God and before the mystery of the universe which exists within your heart. Without embracing this silence, the seed can not sleep in the earth in winter to later give birth to new life in spring. And you will not be able to endure the winter of your soul, to find and dream your deepest dreams, to being them into being, and to become the person you are meant to be. This may sound inspirational but as I say it is most basic and practical. It is about getting up in the morning and getting done what you need to do.

These four aspects of transcendence--faith and omnipotence, love and omnipresence, wisdom and enlightenment, and silence from which arises our greatest work--these can be restated as wonder, awe, and gratitude for being alive. If you wish to study the mysteries, find and nourish these things within yourself at the beginning. They are at the core of your self and you will return to them again and again and they in turn will provide you with limitless inspiration.

Three years ago, a wonderful friendship came to end which caused me a great deal of grief. Shortly after this, I was meditating with a spirit of the sphere of Mercury named Azriel and it is he who put to me my life koan, "What is the source within you which heals the wounds of your heart?"

I wrote a poem in reply which I will share with you again in this place. The reason I am writing this essay is that last week another friendship came to an end. It was the kind of friendship which is meant to last for a life time. Sometimes between human hearts the flow of empathy and understanding is very deep. But even the very best things in life come to an end as the spirit who is the Chief Judge of the sphere of Saturn likes to remind me. These endings are sacred as are new beginnings.

One reason to pursue transcendence through all of your training is because it is not just what inspires you to live life fully and to embrace all that life holds. It is your experiences in life which will challenge and test you to see just how deep and rich your transcendence is. The process and flow move in both directions. And so, as I say, there are times when we must return to the core of our being to discover what is sacred to us and what illuminates us from within.

Today I sat within akasha, the akasha of the sphere of Saturn and the cosmic letter E. The color of dark violet in this case represents for me the oneness of the universe and of all creatures--we all share in one life, in one being, and in one ultimate destiny. The sound of "D" in this case symbolizes for me the truth of the physical and the spiritual universe. Nothing is hidden. There is nothing which can not be found out. There is nothing which shall not be revealed. The penetrating sensation, penetrating through space and time, brings everything near so that the life which flows through every being and heart I am united to as well. I am within that openness and that willingness to embrace and to understand.

And with this Saturnian meditation I could feel the pain and loss within me fade away. I did not take two months as it did five years before. It took a few days and the right spirit within me. Which is another way to say and to feel at the bottom of my heart that I accept all that is within life, all the suffering and also all of the love.

From akasha, from within this place of spirit which is what akasha is, proceed the four elements which make up the world.

And with the air element, in this moment, I can feel joined to the entire atmosphere of the earth. The light of the sky, its freedom, wisdom, and delight shine within my mind. With the water element, I can feel the oceans of the earth, the ice caps, entire seasons without light, the darkness of the ocean trench, the flow of the rivers, the calm serenity of mountain lakes, the nurturing rain, the flowing fog and rising mist--they fills my dreams with acceptance, love, and peace.

The mountains, the plains, the minerals, the rocks--silence embraces all their changes as I embrace the silence with which this planet moves through space. This silence which is behind the changes of nature and within the purposes of God, this silence is my home.

And to fire, I sense that the power in the stars is the same power within my heart and there is no limit to it. Within it is the first light of creation and the ability to dream new dreams and to bring them into being. The work that has been given to me I shall accomplish for all of my heart, my love, my soul and my faith are within it.

The way I said all of this five years ago is in this poem in answer to the koan of my life--What is the source within you which heals the wounds of your heart? This is one way to describe the part of myself or the spirit within me which is transcendent. This is its voice--

My mind is the sky--
Pure, clear, and open
Its air flows through my chest
Its winds are my breath

My body is the Earth--
In me, Her Silence and endurance reach consciousness
Like Her, I shelter and I protect
I am one of Her fruits
I am the strength and nourishment upon which others thrive

The oceans are my magnetism and love
Rivers my bloodstream
Rain my moist fluids
Lightning my heartbeat
Thunder my voice
I am life sustaining and giving birth to life

The volcano and magma at the center of the earth
Are my will and power unfolding
I burn, I consume, I destroy
Yet I heal the broken heart
And bring joy and excitement to life

The turning of the seasons
The circle of the stars dancing
I am Eternity uniting with time
I am the nobility of the sun
Its inner union and fusion of opposites
And through its light
My Song streams forth to the ends of the universe

I am the serenity of the moon
Fluid, malleable, and changing
I am harsh, cold, and empty
I choose the place of your birth
I am warm, sweet, and nurturing
I reunite what is lost
All dreams arise from my light
I am tenderness overflowing from the heart

I am within and I awaken
The seeds of spirit hidden within all things
I am the Celebration of Life
I am the deepest peace within the soul
I only exist to reveal the gifts
Which otherwise remain unknown
And there is no where I will not go
To bless or join with those who love.

To put it simply, the beauty of the universe, of creation, and nature
are a source of inspiration which heals and nourishes me when I
experience pain and loss. Each of us no doubt will have our own
sources of inspiration which heal us and renew us again and again.

Seeking Transcendence III – God, Presence and Hermetic Metaphysics

Introduction.

I would like to speak briefly about my view of God and religion
drawing from what I have learned from personal experience. But
first I would like to speak of Franz Bardon's point of view since
he has been of great assistance to me in the areas of method and
practice. Bardon, however, does not give specific rituals and
ceremonies which an individual might utilize to further his
devotional life.

In part, Bardon feels that it is fine for an individual to reply upon
the religion of his upbringing if that is where the individual is most
comfortable. By contrast, Bardon's interest is in training an
individual according to universal principles rather than in promoting
specific forms of worship, devotion, and traditional ways of
communing with God. Let's consider this view briefly.

From Bardon's point of view, man is in the image of God and
God is within him. Specifically, a magician according to Bardon
seeks to know God in all his aspects which are analogous to the four

elements: "the fiery principle involves the almightiness and the omnipotence, the airy original principle owns the wisdom, purity and clearness, from the aspect of which proceeds the universal lawfulness. Love and eternal life are attributed to the watery principle, and the omnipresence, immortality and consequently eternity belong to the earthy principle. These four aspects together represent the supreme Godhead."

In brief, the entire universe on all planes and all physical and spiritual beings have been fashioned from out of the four elements. Each human being is a microcosm reflecting the consciousness and the energies in the entire universe, the macrocosm. In training, therefore, the idea is to move step by step and systematically toward becoming conscious of these energies discovering them and mastering them first within oneself. This involves mastering each of the four elements with equal ability on each of the planes from the physical world to the highest levels of God consciousness.

Revealed religions often present a very personal God who can be approached through specific ways. These ways are often specified according to orthodox interpretations by individuals claiming to be authorities. Now it is a wonderful thing to go to a place or follow certain practices which offer a feeling and reassurance that one is in right alignment with God. I am all for that freedom of choice. Yet there is also a tradition in which Jacob wrestled with an angel and God commands, "Be still and know that I am God." There is something to be said for first hand, direct, and personal experience. Bardón emphasizes this path of direct experience.

Now in the Bardón system, in addition to the elaborate beginning practices, there is a grand metaphysics which you can explore depending on your own inclinations and abilities. Besides the beings representing the four elements, the aura of the earth contains vast numbers of highly developed spiritual beings. Bardón describes a few paragraphs for over 360 of these beings. If you are a little psychic or intuitive, it is not so difficult to interact with these spirits and get to know them in a friendly sort of way. See my article on Some Dialogues with Earthzone Spirits and also the articles under Spirits of the Earthzone.

There are also spirits associated with the auras of the various planets in our solar system--beginning with the moon, Mercury, Venus, the Sun, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune. Bardón has also described a great number of these beings as well. In terms of the Jewish Kabbalah, I consider most of these beings to be spirits who are presided over to some extent by an archangel of that planetary sphere.

For example, the 28 spirits of the lunar zone which Bardón describes are associated with the archangel Gabriel. These 28 spirits are of less comprehensive ability and power than the archangel. You could say they are specialists whereas the archangel is more universal and has a wider range of influence.

From my experience, the spirits Bardón describes are very capable of teaching and acting within their areas of ability. Some are and some are not particularly friendly. That is, they do not like to be bothered unless you are quite serious in your purpose and clearly know what you are doing. In other words, they are kind of like university professors. They are busy and active and do not have time for nonsense.

Archangels, by contrast, are much more friendly and personable. They are like presidents of colleges, the head of the alumni association, or the dean of admissions. They actively promote good feelings about their college or area of spiritual activity. They are in public relations. They have a reputation to maintain. And all of them have interacted in human history in very specific ways. They know human beings.

The problem with talking to an archangel is that they are so

positive and friendly, it is easy to come away being deceived about the level of difficulty involved in whatever you are trying to accomplish. I can talk to the head of a medical school or a specific college and if they feel my interest is genuine and my commitment real they will speak in lavish terms of the career opportunities available after I have finished my training at their institute. But this does not mean in any way that organic chemistry, calculus, or statistics are going to be any less easy as classes to get through. You still have to do your homework and attend class if you are going to accomplish anything at all.

I met an individual recently who knows Bill Gates and Paul Allen, the founders of Microsoft and Apple computers. I do not think she really understands the industries they are involved with or their significance and influence. Her response is based on personal tastes and opinions about how someone should act. The same is true in my experience with archangels. They are easy to get to know personally but these beings stand within eternity and oversee the entire history of the human race so interacting with them always carries with it the possibility of self-deception for the simple reason that they are often too vast to comprehend. I describe some of my experiences with Gabriel under the section Spirits of the Planetary Spheres.

In brief, then, I find that in addition to the over five hundred spirits Bardon describes, there remain the traditional Kabbalist archangels which preside over these spirits in their respective spheres. Bardon mentions a few of these such as Metatron. I was asked recently whether these archangels relate only to our solar system. In my experience, this is pretty much the case. There are spirits of other stars, solar systems, galaxies, and so forth which on occasion involve themselves elsewhere to fulfill some purpose.

Having considered this metaphysical outline of a magician's spiritual universe, we return to the question about God and religion. In Kabbalah, there are ten sephiroth which represent the ways God emanates energy to the universe. These sephiroth present God's Presence in ten different ways according to different themes and purposes. The auras and spirits of the planets embody these themes and purposes in more concrete ways. This is analogous to universities again. If you want science and technology, you might consider MIT. If you want to teach, you might consider the University of Chicago. If you want theology, you go to a divinity school, law to a law school, and for the armed forces you go to a military school such as Annapolis or West Point.

Similarly, if you want contentment and peace you go to the lunar zone. If you want intelligence and science, you go to the Mercury zone. If you want ecstatic love and art, you go to the sphere of Venus. If you want universal light, love, and service, you to the sphere of the sun. If you want total self-mastery and divine power you meditate within the sphere of Mars. If you want to vastly expand your opportunities for new experiences and service you go to the sphere of Jupiter. If you want to comprehend first hand cosmic justice, fate, and the purpose of life's limitations, you go to the sphere of Saturn, and so forth. All of these other spheres are represented in a more practical and approachable manner in the 360 spirits of the earthzone.

Nonetheless, there is a remarkable difference between specific beings and God's Presence as presented in the ten sephiroth. Human beings are found in the physical world. Spirits such as elementals are found on the astral plane. Higher spirits are found on the mental plane or in the planetary spheres and so forth. These beings all have specific and limited abilities no matter how wide ranging or vast their influence and sphere of action.

But the God Presence is found on all plane, in all spheres, and it is not finite. It is infinite. Its creative capacity is without beginning or end and no specific thing in the universe can define it. It is best known by studying all that it has created by it and joining with this Presence itself in an act of creation. Lovers, therefore, present the best analogy to who and what God is. I offer this poem expressing the voice of Vehuiah of the sphere of Mercury with whom I was discussing this very issue:

What is like unto God?
What breath can express His Presence?
Whose voice can sing His songs?
What created thing reflects His Essence?
What image captures His form?

What priest or sage can measure His mystery?
What prophet or mage can comprehend His plans?
Is there an artist anywhere in the universe,
A sculptor whose hands are so skilled,
That he can create beauty like unto the beauty
God creates on a billion billion worlds?
Can the creature ever understand the Creator?

But wait! Lovers are like this--
They anoint each other with their bliss.
Their souls embrace, their innermost essence they taste.
There is nothing they hold back in the giving.
Love is their breath, their voice, their song, and their art.
Their love celebrates and partakes of God's beauty.
This wonder is at the heart of the universe--

It is a pageantry like no other,
A drama of immense suspense.
Wisdom, power, and magick play only supporting parts.
I impart faith, conviction, and the perfection of will
So divine love might enter the earth.

For myself, I find that God's Presence expresses itself through the themes and purposes of the ten sephiroth. In other words, through each sphere and planet's aura in our solar system, God's Presence is found underneath as an infinite energy and limitless consciousness which creates in the following ways:

In Malkuth/the Earth: It creates strength, endurance, and abundance--all of life's experiences are here to be appreciated and fulfilled.

In Yesod/the Moon: It creates peace and contentment, happiness and satisfaction.

In Hod/Mercury: It creates whatever you need to fulfill your purposes--the perfection of intelligence forming and shaping the world.

In Netzach/Venus: It creates oneness, personal beauty, harmony, and love.

In Tipareth/the Sun: It creates integration, unity, full consciousness of all aspects of life and the universe--a cosmic harmony and union. The entire universe exists in a state of oneness yet who is conscious of this?

In Gevurah/Mars: It creates the will and the power to overcome all opposition and obstacles.

In Chesed/Jupiter: It creates opportunities for new experience, for fulfillment, and for wealth on every level and in every area of life.

In Binah/Saturn: It creates justice, order, balance, and responsibility--that is, responsibility for everything that exists.

In Chockmah/Uranus: It creates new destinies, new paths of life. It lays the foundations for new civilizations. It makes all things new by the power of its voice.

In Kether/Neptune: It is within everything, a part of everything, and it is the source from which all things arise. It creates visions, dreams, intimations, and prophecies of what can be which reveal the depths of life and of the mysteries of the heart. All of the sephiroth are contained and interwoven as one here just as all of the sephiroth are manifested in some concrete, physical, and distinct manner in Malkuth.

In summary, then, my experience indicates that entering God's Presence, the "Be still and know that I am God," leads to experiencing the infinite power to create in accord with these ten different themes and purposes. Again, you can sit down with the president of a college, the President, e.g., of the United States, or Bill Gates for that matter. But when you shake hands and talk, it does not mean that this encounter grants you a college degree, the right to command the armed forces, or the ability to write a simple program using C++ computer language.

It does mean, however, that you can ask questions and get answers from individuals who have responsibility for and who exercise oversight over their respective disciplines, nations, and industries. Likewise, when you enter God's presence you understand that the entire universe is an on-going creation of infinite love and beauty. And that there is infinite power open and available for participating in and celebrating this wonder.

In my experience, these sephiroth or emanations of God's Presence are like ten gates. I do not find anyone, any spirit, or being guarding these gates. No archangel embodies even one per cent of God Presence. No created being is in a position to say, "This is where God is or this is the way in which God is active." This temple of God's Being is found within each of our hearts. Each of us has the freedom and the prerogative to seek this Presence, this creative power, in our own way, in our own time, and according to our own unique vision.

Astral Level – The Shadow in Psychology and Magick

The shadow in psychology is often thought of as the part of ourselves which we deny and find unsavory. We like to think of ourselves as being in charge of our lives. We like to feel that we are motivated in specific ways in accordance with our ideals and our beliefs. And so naturally we are uneasy with those things in

ourselves which do not fit our conscious self-image.

But in terms of psychology the shadow is always there. It exists as a reflection of or counterpart to our social existence and the roles we take on in life. The shadow is the opposite of who you are not in the sense of your gender and polar opposite. Instead, the shadow is the part of your self you have not integrated into your consciousness. Therefore, as a constellation or necessary component of psychic life, it has an invaluable role to play in spiritual growth.

One way to sense your shadow is to note those moments when you find yourself disliking or hating someone else. The very thing in them which you find obnoxious or evil is your own shadow. The other's face acts as a mirror image reflecting back what is hidden in yourself. The dislike or animosity you may feel is not identical with the other's actions or beliefs. The shadow is more subtle than that.

Instead, it may be that what you dislike is that the other person is giving vent through their life to something you have repressed in yourself. It is the other's motivation of hate, fear, greed, arrogance, lust, malice, cravings, obsessions, etc. which is the voice of your own shadow calling out to you to recognize and find a form of expression for what you deny in yourself.

If this were not the case, you would be more sympathetic and understanding of the motivation behind the other's actions. You would not need to agree with them or accept their agendas. But you would not be personally repulsed by them. You would feel more objective and perhaps even understand what they are going through and the natural way they will learn through experience.

The shadow is a paradox. If you give into it and surrender to its demands, you act in gross and unwholesome ways. If you deny or repress it, you lose your creativity and momentum, for it has the power to undermine your motivation. It knows the source of the instincts which grant you your greatest power and energy.

Therefore, the shadow requires of us that we invent new ways of living and being. The shadow is the precise balancing factor which appears because we find ourselves restrained and inhibited by our conventional ways of thinking and living.

In this sense, the shadow is a life long companion, friend, and guardian spirit. It saves us from falling into rigid life style and patterns of thought which deny the free movement of spirit and natural energy within us. The shadow does not possess the zest and light which shines in the faces of those who are fully alive. But the shadow is a guardian spirit who appears as a disguised voice of conscience.

The shadow reminds us that we are not yet fully alive. It asks of us, therefore, to search out the depths of ourselves and to honor every aspect of instinctual life within us. It is not satisfied that we succeed in life and accomplish much. It asks, instead, that when we shine, we shine with a transforming radiance--that innocence be combined with timeless wisdom, that youth be combined with the knowledge of the ancestors, that love be combined with power, that tenderness be combined with self-mastery, that dream be combined with material expression, etc.

The shadow, then, is the darkness cast by the light of consciousness. By defining ourselves in a specific way, we automatically leave out much of what is active within us. This can be instinctual cravings, desires, needs, ways of acting and being which we not only dislike and disown but which we have in some way managed to convince ourselves do not exist within us.

In terms of the psychological shadow, the danger for a magician is that he may be tempted to over rely on his sense of authority. That is, he emphasizes his sense of conviction, purpose, and commitment and then ends up ignoring his personal desires and

needs. In effect, he may deny those legitimate desires and instinctual needs within himself which have a genuine claim on his life and consciousness.

Magick is a life long commitment and path of training. But being a magician does not mean you are exempt from fulfilling the karmic tasks belonging to each stage of your life. A magician seeks to be completely responsible for all aspects of his life so that he frees up the time he needs to train and to practice.

But in regard to authority, the magician's will is balanced by an extraordinary sensitivity. He is always willing to find a way to process his feelings and emotions. That is, his commitment to magical equilibrium makes him completely alert so that he gives his total attention to his experience.

A client works within the atmosphere of trust with a therapist. There he discloses and talks about what he feels and his experiences with the past. The therapist, if only by listening, offers the client protection and understanding.

But the magician internalizes this process within himself. The client may return again and again over years to talk with the therapist about conflicts which remain unresolved in himself. But the magician brings the full force of his magical concentration and psychic intuition to bear upon whatever aspect of his inner life he focuses upon. It may also take the magician many years to resolve his inner conflicts, but he has the advantage of having an entire divine hierarchy of spirits to assist him. They amplify his intuition and grant him many insights based upon the wisdom they possess.

The alchemist starts with the darkest, most impenetrable material. This is what he works upon to attain his elixir of life. And the individual who becomes enlightened must in the end have a final encounter with the lord of all demons. It is the darkest and most incorrigible which comes forth to certify whether or not you have attained absolute freedom--whether anything remains which can obstruct you.

Part of the task of developing magical equilibrium, therefore, involves becoming acquainted with your own shadow. You get to know yourself extremely well. You are always alert to observe your own behavior, thoughts, and feelings. One individual I know who has her own temple and order has appointed an individual in her lodge to act as an advocate for what she may be denying or repressing. She has given the shadow a permanent role to play. The other individual's job is to insure that this woman's conscious mind has taken into consideration all factors which are relevant to her decisions.

The Shadow in Magick

Those who undertake inward journeys of exploration will encounter a darkness within. They may think that their goal is to ascend into the light. But the moment they close their eyes and journey within they are also going downward into the unconscious.

This is because the higher light embraces all that exists. It denies nothing. It is omniscient and omnipresent. It knows everything and it is everywhere and within everything. It is only a fool who thinks he can lay hold of and command part of the human spirit at the expense of shunning other parts. The inner self is a whole. It does not tolerate for long separation or division.

Therefore, on an inward journey, the individual will pass doorways which are locked and gates which are sealed. He will move past forms of life which appear dead or dying. But, like the conscious self, these personal, collective, and ancient desires and longing wish to survive. The secrets of the ancestors and the hidden

pain and sorrow buried for ages has a claim on those who pass by. These things wish to be alive again, to flourish and to expand, so that nothing within them is denied. They wish to be reborn and to be transformed, to be healed or to be reunited with the whole so that they find that place where they rightfully belong.

Part of a spiritual process, then, is to be aware that in your journey you will reawaken your forgotten hopes and dreams. And the pain and fear which are buried with you will come forth again seeking to be healed and to be changed. Within us there are desires so stifled and repressed that when they emerge they appear as demons. There is no hope or anything positive within them. They are so ravenous and in pain that they destroy whatever they touch.

As in the story of the apprentice magician who inadvertently evokes a demon, the spirit appears and then asks, "For what purpose have you called me?" We have desires within us which have no avenue of expression in our world. Some of the desires within us are our own. Some are those which our parents and line of ancestors have never been able to satisfy for centuries or ages. And so they are handed down to us as part of our tradition or culture as liabilities carried forth from the past into the present. Some desires predate the human race by billions of years.

If you are receptive and open to what is within you, if you journey far enough, these desires will appear and you had best be prepared to give a very good answer when they ask you, "For what purpose have I been awakened again into life by the echo of your feet, by the light in your eyes, by the warmth of your body, and by the touch of your soul as you pass by?"

For a magician, it is absolutely essential to develop an identification with the highest light. It is the basis for the mage's authority. It is what defines his acts, his purposes, and his goals in life. If you are within an unknown realm on the inner planes, you never want to give the impression that you are lost or confused. This invites whatever you encounter to offer you assistance by taking over your life and making decisions for you.

Whether in trance, contemplation, or meditation, then, a magician develops an extremely strong tie to Divine Providence in its power aspect of omnipotence. The magician seeks to be sovereign lord over the components of his inner psyche. He seeks to direct at will the power they contain. And he seeks to understand and penetrate them so completely with his consciousness that they are more than willing to obey his command.

The magician also has a shadow since he has a personality. There is no question about it. But the magician finds it much more easy to work creatively with his shadow. The shadow loves being associated with someone who can hear and respond in new ways to everything it has to say.

The magician as a magician, however, has what we could call a cosmic shadow. This darkness, which is the opposite of himself, is the entire hierarchy of demons. In the Bardonic system, for every positive spirit, there is a negative counterpart. The auras of negative beings are darker than the auras of the positive spirits. Lower astral entities which possess people and which priests seek to exorcise through their various rituals are not a particular problem for a magician. It is the higher demons he runs into and which show up on occasion to see what he is doing.

These negative beings have important jobs in the universe. From the point of view of Saturn, both the positive and negative spirits serve to assist human growth and development. To work with the 49 Judges of Saturn, (See my essays on Finding Saturn in Yourself) you need to have internalized in yourself an absolute commitment to attaining enlightenment or total cosmic freedom. The worlds of form exist as a training field in which we can experience and then

master all aspects of life. It is wise if we understand that life is imbued with this purpose.

The negative spirits tend to tie individuals to the denser planes of form. They will offer all manner of gifts, psychic and even spiritual powers, as long as you do not seek to grow beyond their domain of authority and power of reach. To be free of them, you have to do exactly what you would have needed to do anyway if you wished to penetrate the sphere of Saturn--make an absolute commitment to becoming completely enlightened and to embodying cosmic freedom.

The negative spirits will so entrap individuals and tie them into specific limiting situations through which they are unable to grow that these individuals will eventually listen to their conscience. Their conscience will remind them that life is sacred and holy. Any price is worth paying to let the indescribable beauty which is in every aspect of life to shine within them. When individuals arrive at this realization, the negative beings have fulfilled their hidden purpose. These negative beings no longer have any significant spiritual influence over those who turned toward the light from within their hearts.

Bardon does not mention this danger about demonic visitations in his first book. In his second book, however, *The Practice of Magical Evocation*, he refers to the example of a reincarnated magician who has in a former life worked with negative spirits. The same negative entities will with real cunning seek to visit the individual in a new incarnation if and when he chooses to practice magick.

I think there is more going on than this. I suspect that for many genuine magicians negative spirits will show up early on in their practice, even at the very beginning. This is not inappropriate from my point of view. The Bardom system, with its full disclosure of the means and ways to master divine power, requires, again, an absolute commitment to serve Divine Providence. The level of power is so great that in even minor ways the magician is already rubbing shoulders and walking with divine purposes in everything he does.

I do not mean to scare anyone away from practicing Bardon. I would point out, however, that I have met a few individuals who have felt very powerful dark influences enter their lives soon after they began working with Bardon's system. With such a challenging system of magick, it helps to be a strong individual who is living a healthy and balanced life. It also helps to have great courage and mental clarity.

The problem is that some individuals feel ok about themselves. They are in a mental and emotional space of sufficient promise and optimism that they are ready and willing to take on a challenging system of magick. But as they work with Bardon, as they enter into profound meditations which are in every chapter of his first book, they open themselves up to dark forces within their unconscious. When you are in deep meditation, you are no longer protected by the order of the natural world or the traditions of your society and religion. And these dark forces are stronger than the insight and will power some individuals have at their disposal. This can result in feeling overpowered at times by these negative powers. The wounds from such encounters may last a life time unless you manage to work your way past these dangers.

On the other hand, had these individuals not worked with Bardon, this kind of darkness in many cases would not have entered their lives. From my perspective, it is important for a community of magicians to make available resources which enrich the magical path. I think individuals should feel free when they face difficulties in their practices to stop and take as long as they need to expand their knowledge at their current level before moving on.

For every problem, there is a solution. For every difficulty, there is a way of working through it. For myself, I usually just need to find the right meditation and then my own personal problem or the problem I am working with other individuals dissolves. Some times it takes me many years to find the right meditation which solves the problem, but I have a lot of confidence about being able to find what I am looking for.

Demons monitor unusual acts of will. This is their job. They want creative will to be tied to the physical world. Like many individuals I have known, demons get extremely jealous when they see someone near them acting with freedom and living with a beauty which they have not found in themselves.

Echotasa, the 16th head of the lunar zone, specializes in magical authority, magical protection, and shows the magician how to gain control over negative beings in the lunar sphere. He pointed out to me that the best way to ward off negative beings is to unite with your guardian angel or your inner spirit. In the end, this is the only sure way to be free of negative influence. From this perspective, negative energies or beings show up as a reminder to you to unite with the highest light within you.

(See my separate essay on Negative Spirits).

A Ritual of Initiation for Bardon Magicians

Eralicarision, 23 degrees Leo of the earthzone, specializes in those universal forms of initiation which are present to some extent in all religious systems. He is very good at articulating the nature of initiation in terms of the attitudes and turning about of perspective which spiritual paths entail. I asked him for his thoughts on the kind of initiation a Bardon magician might consider at the beginning of his training. His response is for the individual to express words and explore images of the following nature to clarify his spiritual commitments.

Obviously, for each individual the imagery is different. We are all of us unique. What I see or receive from Eralicarision is of an individual walking into a temple which he imagines on the inner planes. This is perhaps the temple of Solomon. In any case, it is huge with mammoth stone pillars, stone floors, and stone walls. It embodies incredible wealth or else it can be completely bare and empty. This is for you to discover according to your own sense of what represents the sacred.

As you walk toward the center of the temple, you notice the great silence which the temple exists to enshrine. It is the silence which is sacred and holy. It is the silence which contains the wisdom of the ages and all those powers which the master magician is able to express.

The silence is the depths of the heart and the Soul of the Earth. This silence is not empty. You sense within it the minds and the hearts of all enlightened beings, of all the great masters of magick and cosmic wisdom who have ever existed on our planet.

And now, opening yourself to this silence, you make an offering to it and you receive in turn a gift from it. What treasure of life and spirit do you have or can you offer as a commitment to this silence? What have you been or done which allows you to feel at home in this place? And how will you take this silence and use it to transform your life?

Perhaps you will see an individual appear to you who asks you these questions and to whom you give your response. Perhaps you will hear these questions within your own soul and heart. Perhaps you will return again at another time or, as a ritual, every so often or whenever you need to renew your vision and the power of your

quest. Perhaps one by one you will greet the great teachers who have walked the earth and each of them in turn will offer you a gift according to the level of your commitment and the nature of your visions.

The commitment Erilicarision envisions for Bardonn magicians is summarized in these words which you may wish to speak aloud within the temple of wisdom:

"May the work I perform in training to be a magician serve the highest light of Divine Providence. May divine justice, fair play, and harmony shine through and within all that I do. May the words I speak, the breath I breathe, the light in my eyes, and the love in my heart transform the world around me. May my path be anointed with Divine beauty.

"May all who enter my life see divine peace reflected through me. May the truth of the universe, the mystery of creation, the light which sustains and shines within every created being use me as its servant. May my will be so perfected that in the end there is no distinction between the satisfaction of my desires and the work of Divine Providence on earth."

(See also my pathworking for a similar vision which I wrote while working with Alosom, a earthzone spirit in Sagittarius who specializes in silence).

Negative Conscience

Another interesting difficulty for those who engaged in inner plane work involves what I call having a negative conscience. Part of magick involves opening your heart and mind to your higher intuition. That is, you become sensitive to akasha. You sense what is wholesome, healing, guiding, inspirational, and wise. You sense what the best course of action is and your conscience informs you of what choices create the most harmony over the long run.

There are times, however, when an individual may find that his inner voice is not functioning well. It is not a good guide. Following it produces bad results. It produces discord, undermines your ideals, and leads you into dangerous and compromising situations. It causes you to take advantage of others and to respond not with wisdom but with agendas which you later on consider to be out of character and inappropriate.

A temporary lapse in conscience can result, for example, from coming under the influence of a powerful thoughtform. This thoughtform may belong to an organization such as a religion or group to which you belong or it even may be produced by another individual.

In any case, the thoughtform blocks your access to your higher intuition. When you look inward, it is the thoughtform which speaks and not the still voice within your heart. For this reason, a magician seeks to master the mental plane so that he screens out mental vibrations other than the pure source of what he seeks.

However, there is another more pernicious and forceful kind of thoughtform or imbalance which occurs for some individuals. If they have been engaged in powerful negative actions in past lives, especially magical ones, then their conscience or higher intuition may be to some extent damaged.

If they seek inner guidance, it is the powerful akashic negative magical presence which speaks to them. In effect, it is the magical authority and purposes developed in a former incarnation which is active. This result has been produced by their own karma. Some individuals will give into this conscience and follow its negative

suggestions. Others, however, will resist. These individuals have developed their own personalities in this life time and do not wish to embrace some dark force no matter how central it may seem to their inner life.

In this case, individuals often will completely avoid inner plane work. The inner planes are off limit. They will instead almost always work through established religions, organizations, or well-developed systems of philosophy and ethics. They do this so that the external environment can guide and assist them in place of relying upon an inner light.

Some individuals are so powerful as former black magicians or power brokers that they are permitted to incarnate only as long as they place themselves under other individual's authority. In effect, they are on probation. They are not permitted to act freely and choose their own course of actions in life. They must stay within carefully defined circles of influence. Otherwise, the terms of their incarnation are suspended and they may die suddenly.

When we discuss magick, therefore, from time to time we may encounter individuals who not only prefer but who are obsessed with working with organizations and magical lodges, etc. They can not function without that external support from their environment. They in fact require constant feedback from others at all times when they undertake inner plane work. When they act outside of the rules set up by their group or organization or religion, they may become very malicious.

On the other hand, it is indeed a vast enterprise to attempt to explore the inner planes on your own. The astral and other planes are full of vast uncharted domains which have very little to do with human culture or civilization. For this reason, even very skilled magicians often will attach themselves to various aspects of the physical plane. They will limit their magical actions and only use a tiny amount of the spiritual and psychic resources they could in fact draw upon if they so desired. Journeys to the inner worlds, if only to seek guidance and illumination, remain too threatening.

Akasha, the realm of pure light, does not stop with the aura of our planet earth. Akasha extends to the ends of the universe. It is a positive thing to appreciate the vastness of our universe both in its physical and its spiritual aspects. And it is helpful to understand our own limitations, the boundaries which protect us from the unknown and dangerous. It is another thing to repress your fear of that vastness by blindly attaching yourself to beliefs and customs which are arbitrary and have little real meaning in your life.

This kind of fear or negativity again shows up on the mental plane. An individual may defend himself from the vast void he senses within by binding himself to rigid beliefs, doctrines, philosophies, and thoughts which serve as his signposts and taboos. These signposts say, "Do not venture beyond the reaches of correct doctrine, belief, and interpretation. Beyond the point of correct doctrines lies monsters which no man is able to fight." In other words, you will discover a blind, irrational fear behind their beliefs. Their self-imposed limitations protect them from the unknown.

The remedy for this situation of mental attachment and rigidity is, as with the initiation I suggested, to respect the power of inner silence. Develop a mind which can observe, listen, contemplate, and sense without having to use thoughts as its primary mode of action. A truly silent mind is open enough to feel at ease reflecting the universe within itself. It is a place where light is free to appear or disappear. This is the domain through which flows a love which has no beginning or end. For this reason, inspired from this source, the mind is beyond all fear.

Astral Level – Negative Spirits

Negative Spirits or the Dark Side of the Force (From a description of the positive spirit Tagora and his negative counterpart)

Remember that in the Bardón cosmology, for each positive spirit in the earthzone there is also a negative counterpart. Like Bardón, I would suggest at the outset that you do not evoke negative spirits. Bardón says a magician should only contact those spirits which are compatible with his high ideals. Since I actively work with the Judges of Saturn who preside over both positive and negative spirits, a study of negativity is not outside the range of my work and responsibility. And, as a matter of experience, I have met individuals whose negativity could qualify them to be incarnations of negative beings. I have to deal with this kind of thing on a regular basis.

One difference between negative and positive spirits is that the negative are closer to the physical world and have darker colors in their auras. For these reasons, they are easier to contact. You do not have to be as pure nor do you need some noble purpose to catch their attention. You neither have to elevate your consciousness into a profound trance nor journey far on the inner planes in order to encounter them. Their activities are more familiar--their actions are sensational and full of scandal. Instead of uplifting and transforming, they supervise obsession, degradation, and destruction.

This is not to say that they serve no purpose. They too grant an opportunity to learn through experience. They give you a taste of life and a chance to find out who you are and what you are made of.

In fact, they like to challenge and test you. If you do not have an absolute commitment to the divine, if your will is in any way weak or undefined, they will visit you on occasion or send an emissary deputizing for them--someone you work with or meet in school or in your social life. These spirits are happy to offer their services as your tour guide, your confidant, counselor, and the author of your life script if you need a ghost writer.

If you lack meaning and purpose, they are happy to fill in all the blanks in your application for incarnation. If you do not know what you are after in life, you can be sure they will find something for you to do. Is life drab and boring? They will find you a task completely captivating and demanding. After all, this is their job--to get you completely involved with life if you do not want to play a part or else deny you the basics so you come to realize how precious the life is that you gave up.

And if you despair for any reason? Oh, wow, look out. That is like shouting or sending an SOS sent on their private wavelength saying, "I am here. Come rescue me for I am lost." You see, akasha is so sensitive to will and imagination that your choices in life automatically activate its resources either for creation or destruction. Human choice and will are that dynamic and powerful.

Negative spirits may appear to be exotic and otherworldly, but they merely reflect things with which we are already familiar. I have a friend whose uncle is in the mafia. Occasionally, he runs into mob figures. They always offer him "free" gifts out of respect for his uncle. But he knows that if he ever accepts a gift he will be bound to the mob forever. Once you take a free handout, they will call on you for special favors. You have a permanent relationship.

I have another friend whose grandfather was a kahuna, a Hawaiian priest. Whenever he meets kahunas, they tell him about the various Hawaiian spirits with whom he has a special connection. But he wants no part of this. He has never accepted the psychic

warfare his grandfather, as a kahuna, participated in. He has switched religions thinking that in this way he will escape from that kind of negative spiritual action. Each religion actually has its own way of dealing with negative spirits, performing exorcisms, and so forth.

The topic of negative entities covers a vast area of study. Some conceive of negative beings, devils, demons, and such as being insidious, hideous, and violently destructive. This seems to be the case but you have to distinguish between lower astral plane entities and highly developed beings.

As with the mob, if you go to a loan shark and default on your loan, the loan shark will come round and cause you physical injury. If you run, he will hunt you down. The situation is like survival in a jungle. If you suddenly encounter a wounded animal, an animal whose territory is invaded or an animal with a raging appetite, you may find yourself attacked with an amazing ferocity. Behind the teeth, the jaws, the claws, and the venom is a pain, a rage, or the blind desire to survive. Entities on the lower astral plane can turn on you with a pure, devouring hatred. And these negative beings, like the mob or an animal interested in survival, have a powerful sense of territory and of who is in charge.

But in the case of the loan shark, there is something more subtle. The negativity takes the form of entrapment. Nothing is a matter with what is given--with the money itself. It is the terms attached to the loan which make the transaction dark. Often negative spirits will sense the power within you. They see that you have a destiny, a mission, or something wonderful you are meant to accomplish. What they do is tempt you with a shortcut.

You may have something you really want to do with your life. But you do not have the money, the experience, the connections, the friends, the influence, the knowledge, or the magick. It seems what is meant to be will never happen. Your conviction is inadequate.

In steps a negative being. It says, "I will give you power, connections, and all the knowledge you will ever need." Because you lack experience, the offer appears friendly and generous. But you have to be sensitive to what is missing. Negative spirits often will grant very positive things or gifts on two but not all three of the physical, astral, and mental planes.

For example, they may dramatically increase your powers of concentration on the mental plane. And they will give ideal physical circumstances where you can work toward your dreams. But the astral life they provide is contaminated. Even as your opportunities in life increase, your emotional life becomes a toxic wasteland devoid of love and affection. They humiliate you and cause degradation to fill your astral body so you lose the self-esteem you need to make independent choices.

Consider another example. As in some groups, there is a physical community where you belong. And there is love and support nurturing you and drawing you into a life of sharing and caring. But what is at stake in this case is your mind. You have to think in a certain way. Any deviation from acceptable doctrines, beliefs, or interpretations is intolerable. You are not permitted to think your own thoughts.

If you have complete control of individuals' bodies or their emotions or their minds--just one of these three--you can pretty much put an end to their spiritual growth. If you can block a peoples' contact with the spiritual, then you can destroy the world or cause untold suffering.

The higher negative beings of the earthzone are intelligent and conniving. We can see the equivalent in human life. The Drug Enforcement Agency sent an undercover female agent to infiltrate

the drug cartels. She was set up in a business which launders money. She succeeded marvelously with the Columbians and so forth. But when she went to meet the Italian mob, she ran into something else.

The Italian mob did not know her. When she got off the plane in Rome, the mob photographed every single person arriving at the airport that day. They wanted to see if there were any other known agents who came in as her backup. The Italian mob operates its own intelligence service similar to the FBI and the CIA.

This agent succeeded in a securing a large number of arrests and also the confiscation of \$50 million of mob money. But the mob also put out a four million dollar contract on her life. Running into higher negative spirits is somewhat similar. You are up against professionals. They have a lot of resources to draw upon to manipulate and to harm you.

The mob may live down the street. You may go to school with their children. You may have business associates or friends who are under their influence. In some countries like Japan, there is an unwritten agreement between the government and the yakuza. The Japanese yakuza keep juvenile delinquents off the streets. They have their own system of internal discipline. Like the IRA in Belfast or the mob in Grosse Pointe, Michigan, thieves are not permitted to operate in their neighborhood. The mob controls evil like a monopoly. In effect, it provides order. Like a thief's guild, it insures that negative actions take place within prescribed limits. Individual initiative is not tolerated.

Hitler, during the Third Reich, gave occultists a choice. Either join the Nazi party or be sent to a concentration camp. He wanted a monopoly on magical power. Even in the United States, since the 1970's, the CIA has run its own research and operations involving remote viewing. This is so effective as an intelligence tool that the U.S. government wanted a monopoly on its use. The government actively interfered with individuals and private organizations researching this skill.

You can read on the internet and in books a great deal about this. It appears the U.S. government used disinformation, character assassination, and even physical assassination to control the spread of information. Negative beings are like that. If you are developing power, they want you to work for them or else they attempt to do you in.

The way to escape evil is to say, "I am committed to a higher purpose. I identify with it with my whole being. If you proceed against me, you proceed against the powers behind me." In other words, once you encounter evil--a highly potent negativity--it is no longer life as usual. You have to make an enormous commitment if you want to regain balance and harmony. This commitment must transcend your own life. It must be to the highest light you can imagine and your commitment must be sufficient that your life then becomes a vehicle for this light's expression. In other words, you need to find a source of power greater than the one which has control of you. If you are on a spiritual path, then you need a source of spirit of greater power and might.

There are times when there is nothing else that can save you than your own absolute commitment to the light. Everyone of us will one day encounter this situation in one or more of our incarnations. The Buddhist's refer to this as the motivation to seek enlightenment. For the Judges of Saturn, enlightenment is much, much more than something an individual attains to free himself from suffering. It is a state of mind in which you are free to celebrate the beauty of the universe. It is not just personal. It is a cosmic event.

Elemental beings can not approach an individual whose mind is centered within akasha. In a similar manner, negative beings can

not approach an individual who, in his faith and at his core, identifies with Divine Providence. The thing is you never want to underestimate the influence of power either in a positive or negative form. You never want to make the mistake of assuming that evil will go away, that once it has contacted you can ignore its touch and go back to the life you had before. You can count on negative spirits to wait life times for you to make another mistake and then they will offer you an invitation similar to one you accepted before.

On the other hand, it is interesting how much power Christians ascribe to the devil. Jews will tell you that the devil is a minor annoyance. It is God you have to look out for--fear Him and nothing else. It is only with God's permission that evil enters the world. All power is under God's supervision. If you read the psalms of David, it is clear that David never forgets for an instant that God is in charge and not the enemy or negative spirits.

In our solar system, according to Bardou, the spirits of the sphere of Saturn are the Judges who govern both positive and negative spirits when it comes to karma and cosmic law. On a planetary level and in the cases of black magicians, it is the Judges of Saturn who determine for how long negative spirits may be unleashed to cause destructive effects.

It is the task of Saturn to insure that the paths of spirit remain open and uncontaminated. They see the physical world and time as helping us to discover the divinity within us. Both negative and positive spirits serve this same end. The negative spirits bind, confine, and destroy. Again, it requires immense will to be free of their influence.

The positive spirits teach how to take into your hands the powers of creation. It requires immense will to work with them. The eyes of a magician can see and understand the work and appointed purpose of both kinds of spirits. Consequently, a magician neither fears how this or that experience may rob him of his purity nor does he close himself off from the world to protect his devotion. Ideally, he is able to offer assistance and insight to whoever comes to him regardless of their situation.

What black magicians have in common is not their malice, domination, or evil works. If you search their hearts, you will find they have lost a sense of the wonder and beauty of the universe. In other words, their hearts are closed. They no longer seek or desire to see how akasha is active in guiding and inspiring all things through the power of love.

For myself, therefore, one of the most important tasks in developing magical equilibrium is keeping myself inspired. For me, power serves the purposes of love. It is an aspect of being creative.

When I discover something negative in myself, I seek to capture the energy and will within it. I find an ecstasy, a divine purpose, or natural way of growing which allows the energy and the power within the negative to be expressed in a totally new way as part of a larger whole.

The negative is an expression of isolation and destruction. It contaminates and steals. But the power within akasha is such that anything can be brought into a greater harmony, anything can be turned around or remade so it leads to fulfillment and deep satisfaction. Love can unlock any gate or heal any soul. Part the work, for me, is in retaining my commitment to and appreciation for this love during all parts of my journey.

Physical Level

Pour breathing and pour breathing inhaling and exhaling various qualities

Position of body

Physical control in daily life

There are four exercises for the physical level of chapter 2 of Initiation into Hermetics. Since the first two relating to pour breathing raise a great many questions, I will review them last.

EXERCISE - Control of Body.

The goal of this exercise is to learn to sit "quietly, comfortably and without any trouble" for a half hour.

The point here is that there are a great many exercises in the Bardon system of training. Part of this training requires the student to disengage his or her five senses from the physical world. To do this, the body has to be relaxed enough so it provides no disturbances to the mind. It is always important to have a physical sense of peace, well-being, and harmony at the beginning and at the end of your practice sessions. This reassurance enables you to return to your personal and everyday activities after working with transpersonal and cosmic levels of consciousness and energy. Mastering body position helps develop this.

You begin the exercise by practicing for five minutes. Sit in a chair with your back straight, your feet flat on the floor, and your hands resting on your thighs. In the beginning, you can learn against the back of the chair. Close your eyes and then observe your body. Notice all you can about your body while you continue to remain motionless. Add a minute to each of your subsequent practice sessions. Eventually, you will be able to sit quietly for a half hour without feeling in any way disturbed, anxious, uncomfortable, or constrained.

COMMENTS. It might appear that this exercise is mechanical in nature. You learn to sit without moving as if your body is frozen. Members of the special forces such as Navy Seals learn to freeze their body posture for hours whether they are in a stream, on top of an ant nest, or beneath a bush, it does not matter. This is an exercise of mind over body. Those in the armed forces or those undergoing special training in the martial arts do this because of the importance of their mission--the body is an instrument and a weapon under the command of will.

Bardon also points out that will is an element in this exercise. He says that you can work with controlling physical posture as a means for developing will power. For example, he says you may wish to practice some of the many asanas of yoga positions in the orient. He recommends, however, that you first learn to sit upright in a chair for an hour before going on to practice asanas.

The above exercise is fairly straightforward. Different individuals will find it relatively easy or more difficult depending on their previous training. Some individuals such as those who are hyperactive may find it actually uncomfortable to try to sit still. There is a lot room in the Bardon pantheon of spirits for individual preferences.

There are a number of spirits who, for example, teach magical dancing or ritualized movement as a means for practicing magick. I can imagine individuals who get on perfectly well working through many kinds of exercises by combining them with movement. Movement has rhythmic and also artistic dimensions and these are also important in magick.

Some individuals may also wish to find their own approach as they work with their body. They may want to practice sitting still after doing yoga, stretching their muscles, or even creating or

finding the right setting in which to practice. This could be a matter of practicing in a temple, out of doors, or with other individuals, with music, etc. The point is to take the exercise and make it work for you individually.

When I began practicing meditation, no one pointed out to me the importance of being aware of the muscle structure of my body, my breathing, and the various exercises for relaxing. I did, however, have a little bit of a martial art background and a natural flair for shamanism.

When I am in a woods and see a deer, I can freeze my body and not move for a half hour because I like to blend in and feel a part of nature. I like to feel that I am a tree, a rock, a wolf, or a deer. My body likes drama and the excitement of a quest.

I think it is fair to assert for many individuals that if you work through some stretching exercises, it becomes much easier to relax and sit still. There is a natural high and euphoria the body experiences as you stretch and then relax various muscle systems one after the other. The blood circulation and level of vitality increase with slow, rhythmic breathing. The body enters a state of deep relaxation and peace and no mental imagery or element of will power is required to sit still. Sitting still is then effortless and completely natural.

Of course in magick, as with the martial arts and special forces, you want to be able on occasion to focus a hundred per cent of your attention without your body in any way interfering. You want to be able to do this at any time under any circumstances. If you have experienced a natural process of deep relaxation, I think it is perhaps much easier to enter this state when you need it. Your body is more ready to cooperate with your will without interference. The greater your awareness of the kind and location of tension in your body, the quicker you will be able to identify, to relax, and free yourself of that tension.

EXERCISE - Body control in everyday life.

Bardon says, "It is entirely up to the scholar to control and force body and nerves by will-power." Bardon gives examples of this exercise such as forcing yourself to do something when you are tired; if you feel hungry, don't eat for a half hour; if you feel thirsty, wait a while before drinking something; if you are usually slow at doing things, try doing them quickly; and if you are always active, try slowing down.

COMMENTS. The point of this exercise is to observe your behavior and routines and learn how to change them at will. There a number of components involved in being a magician. A magician is able to observe the world with a great deal of detachment. This means you learn to see yourself as if you are observing the behavior of another person. You want to bring crystal clarity to your observations.

Other traits magicians have are curiosity and a need to experiment. There is that frame of mind which is always ready to ask, "What can I learn if I do things differently?" "If I observe the process carefully, what goes on in my thoughts, feelings, and body when I change one of my routines or behaviors?" "If I feel resistance or anxiety when I change something in myself, can I track down that resistance to its source in my nervous system, psyche, or belief system?"

I think a magician is also an artist. It is perfectly natural for him to ask, "How can I make my life flow more smoothly so it is more satisfying and harmonious?" He sees his life as a work of art. Like

an artist, he feels free to change his methods, style, and the content through which he expresses his experience. But like any artist, he masters the material he is working with. For this reason, a magician studies himself and tries to test his limits. He remains flexible, adaptable, and ready to change his behavior.

EXERCISE - Conscious pore breathing.

Bardon says, "Sit comfortably in an arm-chair or lie down on a sofa, and relax all your muscles. Try to think that, with each inspiration, not only your lungs are breathing, i.e., inhaling air, but the whole body is doing so. Be firmly convinced that, together with your lungs, simultaneously each single pore of your body receives vital power and conveys it to the body. You ought to feel like a dry sponge which, when dipped into water, sucks it in greedily. You must have the same feeling when breathing in."

COMMENTS. The use of imagination in this practice facilitates the movement of vital power to move from the etheric energy in your surroundings into your body. You also practice exhaling the life force as well. Bardon mentions that each individual will feel this flow of vital energy in their own way. Basically, then, we imagine our skin to have a magical ability. It can draw vital energy into the body in a way somewhat analogous to the way the lungs draws oxygen into the blood stream.

One of the keys to magick is to imagine that you already possess the ability you are trying to master. It is through imagination that you produce the feelings and experiences you are seeking to acquire. A scientist constructs a hypothesis using a conceptual system, an image, or a metaphor to explain in advance what he does not yet understand. What a magician does is similar. Except the magician goes inside of the metaphor to experience it first hand. This increases his awareness and accelerates his ability to learn.

Let's use the image of a sponge absorbing water. Try this. Imagine you are holding a dry sponge in your hand. Slowly lower it into basin of water. Notice the rapid way it absorbs the water and how it becomes heavier as a result of the water spreading through it.

You can also notice the vacuum in your lungs which is created as your diaphragm contracts as you breathe in. You can then imagine your entire body is empty inside producing a vacuum which the energy in the air rushes in to fill. Tree roots absorb water and minerals from the soil. Leaves absorb sunlight. Imagine you are the tree's roots and leaves. It is the ability to absorb which you are after. As you concentrate on these various processes, you then imaginatively extend a similar ability to your body.

Another key to magick is employing firm conviction. There are a whole set of concepts which are closely related and yet each is distinct--faith, conviction, belief, trust, knowing, certainty, truth, commitment, confidence, credibility, determination, etc. I once asked my old philosophy professor and chairman of the department at a Christian college if there were any studies in phenomenology of the nature of faith. In other words, what is faith if you describe the personal experience of it without referring to doctrines, content of belief, religious images, stories, or theological and ecclesiastical issues. His reply was that Christian theology has been and still is preoccupied with the relation of faith to reason. Faith itself has been left undefined and is not an area of philosophical investigation or exploration.

In magick, the amount of faith and conviction an individual has is proportionate to the amount of the electrical fluid the individual has

control over. The strength with which you believe in something and incorporate this belief into your life are separate from the content of what you believe in. Consequently, a fanatic who believes in killing for his ideal may have the same strength of conviction or amount of electrical fluid within him as a supreme court justice who believes in the rule of law. Both men have great influence because the power of their belief is radiant and penetrates the auras of those they come in contact with though obviously the content and application of our two mens' beliefs are different.

The electrical fluid relates to our belief in being able to make a difference, to make something happen, or manifest something. It is quite possible to imagine breathing in life force to the extent that the experience feels completely real and is entirely convincing. But this may be no different than going to a movie where for two hours you are completely absorbed in the action. When you leave the theater, you are your old self again. For all the catharsis and euphoria you experience during the movie, there is no application or concrete result. Nothing is changed in the world in which you live.

The electrical fluid or firm conviction adds to our exercise an overwhelming belief and complete certainty that you are developing the power to change yourself and the world. We all have this level of firm conviction within us. For example, recall several times in your life when you acted with total conviction. You may have believed in what you were doing because of your commitment to some ideal or principle. For this reason, you were neither confused nor did you have doubts because of the obstacles you faced or the strength of those opposing you.

You may have taken great risks when no else would because of your great confidence that you had the right stuff--the experience and the knowledge--to get the job done. You may have had an inner feeling of certainty, conviction, or intuition that you could do something creative or difficult even when no one else was offering support or understanding. There may have been major life decisions during which you said to yourself words to the effect, "This is what I need to do to make my life work." And then with real courage and determination, you followed through with what you said you would do. Or more simply, were there times when you felt on top of the world, completely confident, and totally in charge of yourself even if this was only for an hour, a few minutes or a few moments?

The point is, whether the experience was major or minor, there are times when we have all acted with boldness, courage, conviction, or determination. Relive a few of these moments. As you do so, notice how you feel. Carry the best part of these feelings over to the exercise with your breathing. Go back and forth several times in your imagination between the level of conviction you possessed in this other experience and this moment. Apply that same conviction to your ability to breathe in life force through the pores of your skin.

Conviction, confidence, knowledge, and certainty--these are also an energy you produce within your body. If you produce this electrical energy through reliving a past experience, hold that energy within yourself. Sustain its strength. Apply it to this exercise. This is one way in which magick works: you extract from life experience its essence. You refine it, strengthen it, and then apply it in new and creative ways.

Initially, it is sufficient to gain a sense of vital energy entering and leaving the pores of your skin. You may feel warmth, increased pressure, tingly sensations, an increase in vitality, a flow of energy almost like air or a liquid moving through your skin, etc. Notice very carefully these sensations and feelings. You will want gradually

to strengthen and amplify them.

In the long run, what Bardon is after in this exercise is not only a clear and convincing mental plane imagination of breathing in vital energy. He wants more than a rich and overwhelming feeling of becoming saturated with life force. He wants the student to produce an etheric result. He wants the student to be able to change the world--to produce concrete effects in himself and others. To accomplish this, you will need to put all of yourself into the exercise. You will need the full power of your imagination and the full strength of your spirit almost to the extent that you can command the life force to obey your will.

EXERCISE

In this exercise, you add to the lungs and pour breathing the desire inhaling mentioned in chapter one. That is, you inhale through the whole body "health, success, peace, mastering of passions, or whatever you need most urgently." When you have attained a degree of success with this exercise, go on to exhaling those things you do not like such as character faults, illness, or whatever causes you to fail in your life.

COMMENTS. This practice develops further the exercise in the first chapter. Recall that in the first chapter we impregnated the vital energy entering our body with an image or idea. Combining intense concentration with vital energy strengthens the ability of the idea to manifest.

If someone is trying to sell you a car or some other item, the salesperson probably will not be very effective if he or she is tired and lacks enthusiasm. But if the salesperson is warm, inviting, and has a radiant sense of friendship, the customer is more likely to be interested in making a purchase. The same thing is true about putting thoughts into action. If you take an idea and enliven it with excitement, good feelings, enthusiasm, and imagination it will have a greater opportunity to make a difference in your life.

Part of the process of exhaling psychological qualities or illness involves making yourself empty. By exhaling, you are letting go and freeing yourself of attachment. In exhaling, there is release and a peace so strong nothing can hold on to you.

You do not distance yourself from life by letting go and emptying yourself. Exhalation is a way of opening oneself to receive new life. Within the emptiness is also a oneness which unites us all. In other words, part of the psychology in exhaling things you do not like involves the feeling that as you exhale you are opening yourself up. This involves trust and a sense of belonging to a greater whole.

Some individuals may wonder how you exhale sorrow, depression, anger, lust, etc. Thoughts and emotions are also energy. Here, at the beginning of Bardon's training system, we are learning to treat them as such. We are all continuously drawing in, releasing, and circulating energy with the world around us. Therefore, it is not a loss to let go of something which we carry inside when we can replace it with something better.

Physical Level – On Pranayama

Leo in Earthzone: Leo is radiant, confident, and full of rejoicing. Leos are naturally affectionate and supportive of others. Libra, with a different emphasis, is interested in love, beauty, and personal expression. Libra, for example, is very skilled in finding the point of

balance between two individuals.

But Leo can find the central point which holds together an entire community. Leo has the strength and desire to stand on that point. The inspiration and life of the community is reflected in his eyes and expressed through his voice.

You can find in Leo, then, a magnanimous heart and true generosity. There is also a ferocious will to defend the community from attack from without and contamination from within. Like a mother lion with her cubs, Leo is willing to protect and to educate her own.

The constellation of Leo is ruled by the sun. Since magicians are concerned with relating the microcosm--the individual--with the macrocosm--the universe, it is natural there are some individuals whose hearts reflect the light of the sun. And what is the magical secret of the sun's light which Leo's know? A mature Leo can feel in his or her heart a continuous explosion of joy which overflows as love to others. Indeed, if the Leos' spirituality has reached a universal level, then their radiant light illuminates everyone like the sun's light which shines upon the whole earth.

8 Degrees Leo: The 8th degree of Leo is very sensitive to life force, vitality, breath, and the air element. This degree of Leo on the akashic plane seems to scream out to the whole earth--"Hey folks, you are surrounded by a sea of vitality. Draw it in so you shine like the sun!"

Romasara's Domain of Akasha: This level of akasha joins a profound spiritual peace with mastery over breath, the etheric body, and the air element.

Romasara's Sigil: I draw the sigil placing the idea of mastery over breath into it. Immediately, my awareness of air heightens. The air I inhale feels incredibly rich and satisfying. My awareness sinks into my breathing so that I feel I have become the air and the life force within and surrounding my body.

In a few moments, more life force enters and circulates within my body. The trick does not involve learning specific breathing exercises. In Romasara's approach, direct awareness of air releases energy into the body and makes this vitality accessible to the will.

There is, then, a strong astral component present--total immersion in the experience of breathing opens the senses to perceiving life force. This is like meditating within a sacred temple. There is a warm, glowing sensation all through my body as if priests are chanting and concentrating their mantras to vibrate within me. It seems as if Romasara has placed his hands on my head and anointed me with an understanding of breath .

. After practicing for a while, I notice the sea of vitality which surrounds me. It proclaims that life is good, peaceful, and beautiful. Meditating with Romasara, it is easy to imagine why some individuals, as in India, run away to spend the rest of their lives practicing yoga. There is an intoxicating contentment in this energy like the kind you reflected in the faces of great yogis. This bliss is so rich it strives to cancel and to destroy one's responsibility to society. The urgency of personal needs which demand intimate bonds with lover, family, and community is weakened because of the extreme relaxation. This astral and etheric vision of universal energy is as enchanting as entering a realm of fairies or of undines who invite you to dwell among them forever.

And still this energy grows stronger. I feel I have left the earth and entered the sphere of the sun. When the light is bright enough, the barriers separating nature, human, divine, and the planetary zones dissolve. Romasara, like other spirits such as Bialode,

apparently has a close tie the solar sphere as well as to our earthzone. Enough of this mystical rapture with endorphins running wild in the bloodstream. Back to our evocation.

Romasara's Inner Source of Inspiration: The energy of God, without beginning or end, self-originating, and beyond all understanding, can be found within our bodies. It is within our breath. It is met in the perfection of our health and vitality. In other words, the body is sacred. It is the temple of God.

It has been the custom of religions to build temples and structures to symbolize the glory and majesty of God. Consciousness and our five senses enjoy having the support and reassurance which comes from entering a great cathedral, a shrine, a stone circle, a grove, or a place of worship. But what all these majestic buildings and sacred settings point to is Divine Presence which is found within our bodies and hearts.

If I can put it this way, Romasara acts as a tour guide introducing students to an infinite sea of vitality which is within our bodies and which extends throughout the universe. Therefore, as you are drawing Romasara's sigil, include this awareness within the light you visualize.

Outer Aura: Romasara's aura emits a very pure light. It refines life force. It burns with a radiant purity.

But as a matter of fact Romasara is very aware of every aspect of how breath and vitality move within the body. It could well be that if he were a human being, he would teach a great variety of methods. Each student would be introduced to the practice most useful to him.

Inner Aura: The way an undine is aware of the sea or a sylph of winds and weather patterns, Romasara is aware of the life force within the sea of air around us. Romasara has identified his consciousness with that sea. In practicing breathing with Romasara, you learn to draw upon these currents of energy which gradually become larger and stronger.

Akashic Plane: The akashic plane is the equivalent of entering a divine awareness extending without limit through space and time. The awareness Romasara represents on this plane is the absolute mastery of breath, life force, and radiant light. You can approximate this awareness in the following way. You imagine you are a divine being who comprehends all aspects of life force and vitality. Your must be certain that you have accomplished this so that you are free of all doubt. In other words, you simply make a picture of yourself embodying these qualities. This conviction, if strong and clear enough, will eventually manifest as a physical ability.

Mental Plane: On the mental plane, Romasara's presence stimulates the mind to be vibrant and to rest within a sea of shining bright vitality. This meditation does not emphasize your personality. It is a way of extending beyond yourself and identifying with the atmosphere of the earth.

I mention elsewhere how Swami Rama once had a student who kept pestering him to transmit shaktipat--that is, to confer a transfusion of pure life force to the student. The Swami finally consented. He took a glass of water and put some vitality into it as he held the glass between his palms. A while after the student drank the water the student's body went into convulsions and he literally began bouncing off the walls of the room he was in.

The problem was that the student's consciousness identified with his own body and personality. But the energy inside of him was an

absolutely free movement of universal energy pure and radiant--a celebration of divinity. The energy had no way of expressing itself within this individual. Unlike the Swami, the student had not spent decades chanting sacred names and mantras, opening the nadis of energy channels within his chakras, and training his mind to be boundless light full of bliss and delight. It helps, then, if the student takes some time and effort to train his mind and body so he can understand the teacher's consciousness.

There is a difference between the akashic plane and the mental plane. On the akashic plane, consciousness identifies with divinity without any form restriction or space and time limitation. In working with Romasara on the mental plane, awareness focuses on general aspects and principles. In this case, you become aware of the energy vibration in the atmosphere of the earth around you.

Sometimes Swamis have this little mental game they like to play with students. They get into talking about how "I am not my body. I am not my thoughts. I am not my breath. I am not my name. I am not my identity, " and on and on and on. Well, what remains at the end of this game? In Hinduism, following the model of a deity such as Krishna, you identify with the one indivisible and transcendent spirit within you.

But on the mental plane, Romasara does assume a specific identity. His consciousness has content, movement, and expression. He identifies with the trees, their roots and leaves. He identifies with the plants, the clouds, the winds, the rivers, and the seas. His awareness is within all the processes which nourish life on earth. And underneath the chemistry, biochemistry, metabolism, and breath is, again, an energy field of radiant light and pure vitality. This is what shines from his aura and where his consciousness rests.

Astral Plane: On the astral plane, I get the distinct image and sensation that breath produces the flame of spirit within the temple of our bodies radiating inexhaustible vitality. The sea of life force sensed on the mental plane now takes on a focal point--in and around your body is the dazzling and brilliant light of the sun. The essence of life force manifests as radiant light in your aura.

Franz Bardon talks about creating this aura around yourself through breath. Each breath accumulates more vitality within you until you feel you are about to burst with the pressure of the light. Practicing over time, you learn to extend this light thirty yards around your body. This supercharged aura makes it easy to heal others by transferring to them your excess vitality. This is a great approach. It just takes many years of dedication and practice to get this.

The nice thing about working with Romasara is that the energy produced is not only very intense and dynamic. It is also gentle. It is blazing bright and it also feels very natural and organic. I notice it is harmonious with my body and soothing to my emotions.

Physical Plane: The life force here is more dense. The light and vitality have a more direct effect on the physical body. This is where most yoga begins. You stretch your muscles using asanas and steady breathing. Circulation is increased. The muscles become more flexible and resilient. Your immune system and health improve. This kind of vitality, then, can produce physical results more quickly.

One individual told me that after she did yoga for an hour she was always in a much better position to think about her unsolved problems. The surcharge she built up of physical vitality influenced her astral body. She felt whole and illuminated from within. The anxiety and worry she attached to problems temporarily disappeared.

In this evocation, I have moved from the akashic plane down to the physical. Generally, students of yoga work the other way around. They perform exercises with their physical bodies. And they induce astral states of devotion and attunement to their line of masters through chanting and meditations. Their awareness is gradually extended to the inner planes where they learn to see themselves as spiritual beings

As with other earthzone spirits, Romasara is a teacher who inspires and reminds students of what is possible if you are willing to work for it. The immediate goal is to become aware of the vitality in air and to draw it into yourself. In the end, you produce what appears to others as miracles through the power of your aura.

Pathworking: In a pathworking, we may use free association and image exploration to explore a theme. This clarifies how we feel and takes us into a deeper understanding of ourselves. By contrast, a guided meditation may take us into contact with collective and global archetypes but it may not illuminate our personal experience. Using a sigil is more technical. It is a method employed by a magician and it can be the equivalent of a mini evocation in itself. It is also possible to combine all these methods at once.

A Pathworking with Romasara. To begin, I recall the different yogis and Swamis I have met or seen practicing over the years. As within a dream, my point of view shifts and I see myself now within a sphere of bright light and life force. Romasara seems to use this image to speak to me.

He says that by working with him it will become much easier for others to understand the spiritual ideas I wish to communicate. My aura will naturally reflect the reality of whatever I am talking about. Others' imaginations will be enhanced and they will be able to feel the inspiration which I feel.

He says too that I will experience far less strain in performing evocations. And finally, I will see much more clearly others' etheric, astral, and mental bodies. This will allow me to lend better assistance to others with their problems and difficulties.

In regard to Bardon's practices with breathing, Romasara points out it takes years to master them. For Romasara, it helps if you start at the beginning by imagining you have already perfected what you wish to embody in yourself--in this case, the mastery of life force. If your body senses you already have the conviction, the mental image, and the feeling for what is to be accomplished, then you are more likely to succeed.

In regard to using Romasara's sigil for mastering pranayama, Romasara says this determined on a case by case basis. Using a sigil is a form of magical ritual. You have to exert a great deal of imagination, will, and energy to make it work. It can be helpful from time to time to use a sigil as you meditate but this is not something to be overused. You want your vitality to develop gradually and without strain. You do not want to force your development in a way that throws you backward because the tension is too great to handle.

A Guided Meditation. This is a basic format for a guided meditation. You can embellish it and expand on it in any way you want.

Relax and sit comfortably. Concentrate on your breathing. Now imagine a spiritual being. This could be Romasara or another spirit related to vitality, health, and healing. As an example, visualize the archangel Raphael descending and appearing in front of you.

You see the shimmering light and radiant healing power shining from his aura. You look into his eyes and see the glory of God and God's beauty being freely extended to all who are willing to receive

it.

As you inhale, you sense in your own breath a willingness to experience this light, inspiration, and healing. The archangel's aura grows brighter and now part of his aura extends in front of him as a divine gift and blessing--he gives of his own being so that you might experience and know his love.

This energized image--an exact replica of the archangel--floats over to you and blends with your aura. You see, hear, feel, taste, and smell it and breathe it into yourself. There is a transition and you find yourself now within Raphael's heart. You feel a love so vast and wonderful the stars are born to give expression to its beauty. You also feel joined to a healing power so great it can restore anything to harmony.

As you breathe with his energy and let it sink in, it saturates every cell in your body. You know now that your mind, soul, and body have become a manifestation of this light and healing power. You are cloaked in beauty with the power to bless anyone who enters your life

Now return from this elevated state to your own body and personality. The intensity of the energy fades but within your heart there is now a direct link to Raphael. The essence of his inspiration is forever within your heart.

Common Difficulties/Imbalances: The first step in working with Romasara is to develop the etheric body. Most individuals are only aware of their physical body and not of the life force which animates it. One way to become aware of vitality is to practice yoga. In this case, as you stretch a muscle or practice an asana, you also breathe into the muscles being exercised. As you do this, you slowly begin to notice the range of sensations relating to tension, relaxation, and increased blood flow.

In becoming aware of these sensations, an individual also gradually becomes aware of the more subtle vitality which sustains the life of the body. Eventually, it is possible to sense directly the flows of life force. Tai Chi Chuan, Chi Kung, and various other practices also increase awareness of the etheric body through movement, balance, breathing, stretching, and training the imagination to circulate energy.

Once you have this awareness, then it is easy to practice pranayama. You can sense the life force which enters your body as you breathe. You can circulate this energy through your body and direct it consciously. In the process, you get a feel for how to maintain harmony and restore health.

It is also possible to sense the vitality in the air surrounding your body and to draw upon this energy to a greater degree. Of course, if your concentration and imagination are sufficiently trained, you can practice Bardon's accumulation of vitality exercises. Whatever procedure you use, whether it is quick or slow, the bottom line remains. You have to attain a direct awareness of the etheric body in a way which furthers health and maintains harmony.

Consider an example of Romasara's approach to pranayama. You can concentrate on your breath and imagine that you are drawing vitality into your right arm as you inhale and releasing it as you exhale. Try this for a few moments. Picture the inside of your arm empty and that energy enters it and leaves it as you breathe in and out.

Make a fist now with your right hand gradually tightening the muscles through the whole right arm. Notice at each level of tightness the different sensations. The muscles flex and may lock in position. You may notice an increase in blood pressure in your arm and the skin temperature become warmer. Keep your muscles flexed for ten or twenty seconds.

Now slowly release the muscles until your arm is relaxed. Here you will notice various sensations such as the feeling of lactic acid being absorbed by the blood and perhaps warmth all through the muscles of your arm.

Now try the breathing exercise again. Imagine your right arm is empty and you are inhaling and exhaling energy into it. It is more likely that you will sense to a greater degree the vitality entering and leaving the arm with the movement of your breath. The point is that the more you are aware of your body, the more easily it will be to sense the presence of vitality within you.

Physical Level – Explorations

Extended Commentary

Reviewing the exercise for chapter 2, physical level: Conscious pour breathing.

Bardon says, "Sit comfortably in an arm chair or lie down on a sofa, and relax all your muscles. Try to think that, with each inspiration, not only your lungs are breathing, i.e., inhaling air, but the whole body is doing so. Be firmly convinced that, together with your lungs, simultaneously each single pore of your body receives vital power and conveys it to the body. You ought to feel like a dry sponge which, when dipped into water, sucks it in greedily. You must have the same feeling when breathing in."

Though Bardon's exercise is straightforward and clear, there are countless ways we can explore and expand on it. We are, after all, working with the universal life force and vitality which animate all organic life. This life force is extremely resilient and adaptable. It is wondrous and in many ways mysterious. No doubt, different approaches to working with it will suit different individuals.

In this section, I am seeking to follow Bardon's way of thinking. I offer the following images, meditations, and procedures as a means for exploring the exercise further. I will mention some suggestions from different spirits of the earthzone later on.

The overall goal of this section is to gain a rich and powerful sense of balance, equilibrium, strength, and resilience in your health and vitality.

Part I. Pour Breathing

Let us turn again to pour breathing. Some individuals may find it difficult to get a sense of energy moving through the skin of the body. From the point of view of physiology, the skin can be considered an organ of the body in its own right. Among other things, the exercise for brushing and rubbing the skin from chapter one serves to raise our awareness of our skin.

The following method might be helpful to some individuals who are having trouble with pour breathing. In chapter 5 of Initiation into Hermetics, Bardon mentions, "The instructions of the fifth step shall show us how to transplant the consciousness into the center of any form, beginning with the tiniest atom to the highest universe." Also, in Bardon's book on quabbalah, he talks about condensing various colors of light which fill the entire universe into a small dot inside of the body. In Bardon's system, large amounts of energy as well as consciousness can enter very small spaces.

We apply this concept to pour breathing by starting with one pour at a time. Concentrate your mind on a very small dot the size of a pin prick on the tip of your index finger. Hold this concentration in your mind for several minutes. Next, take a deep breath and as you do so notice the sensation of your body becoming energized as you inhale. Repeat this deep breathing several times until you can recall clearly the way your body feels when it gets a large supply of oxygen.

Relax. Breathe normal and concentrate again on one precise point on the tip of your finger. Imagine also that your body is completely hollow and empty inside. Now as you inhale, imagine that vital energy is flowing through this tiny dot on the tip of your finger and completely filling the inside of your body.

We are putting together the tactile sensation of one specific dot on our finger with the feeling of vital energy flowing through the dot and also the sensation of the body being filled with a deep breath. As you exhale, reverse the process expelling the accumulated energy inside your body through this dot. There is no need to hurry with this exercise. Stay with it until it feels comfortable and easy to do.

Next, perform the same exercise one after the other on each of the fingers of your hand. Do the same with the other hand. Add the points together by first breathing through the points at the tip of the fingers on one hand and then the other hand. Do also the same exercise with the toes of both feet and then do the hands and feet all at once.

Some individuals may find that it helps to add movement to the breathing process. For example, stand and extend your arms in front of your body, palms facing down, elbows slightly bent and fingers slightly separated. As you inhale through your finger tips, slowly drop your elbows down and lower your body by bending your knees. As you exhale, extend your hands out and stand up straight again. Later on, produce the same sensations without the movement.

Return now to one hand. Increase the number of points you are concentrating on until they cover your entire hand. Extend the concentration on pour breathing to your forearm, then your upper arm, both arms at once, and gradually over the surface of your entire body. The idea is to get the mind to carry over from what you accomplish with one point to the entire surface of your body.

Obviously, the more you are aware of your body, the easier these exercises become. One individual said her hands were extremely sensitive after playing the base viola for years. The vibration of the instrument and the mental concentration on her hand eventually created a capacity for clairfeeling.

When I raced sailboats, I had a ferocious concentration on my hands because I used them to hold the tiller. And through the wood of the tiller I could sense the momentum of the sailboat, wind shifts, and waves striking the hull. My mind went through my hand to the tiller and to all parts of the sailboat as well as the elements of nature interacting with the sailboat. By training as a magician, I notice that my mind goes through my hand to connect to whatever I am concentrating on.

In a similar manner, in this exercise we are gradually learning to connect our minds to our skin so it embodies the ability to draw in and expel energy. Over a period of time, return again and again to concentrating on specific points on the surface of your body. Take that sensation of breathing through one point and extend it to a larger part of your body.

Taoists sometimes breathe through key acupuncture points on the hands and the feet. In Mantak Chia's book, Bone Marrow Nei Kung, he also has the student breathe in through the tips of the fingers. From there, the student learns to breathe vital energy into

the bone structure of the entire body with the goal of rejuvenating bone marrow and blood.

I would also note that students of acupuncture spend thousands of hours over years learning the precise way to insert needles into the hundreds of acupuncture points on the body for medical purposes. Each point has its own name, location on a meridian, influence on the four five elements, and relation to relieving different symptoms and illnesses. The skin is well worth our attention for it is full of magick and power.

Part II. Working with the Etheric Body

The previous section emphasizes lung and pour breathing. There are a great many applications of this basic ability. In Part II, I will review four applications or ways we can work with the energy which is produced. Point 4 is rather extensive since it greatly expands on our exploration of the four elements in regard to attaining magical equilibrium.

1. A Natural Rejuvenating Elixir

"The alchemist will recognize that the human body represents a genuine Athanor in which the most perfect alchemistic process, the great work or the preparation of the 'philosopher's stone,' is visibly performed." Franz Bardon

We are practicing breathing in life force through your lungs and all the pours of our body. As we do so, it is possible to sense our body becoming charged with a luminous, healing, and rejuvenating energy which brings perfect health and harmony.

This energy is the essence of life and an elixir--a quintessence in its own right. It is cool, serene, and calm and yet also energizing, dynamic, and radiant. It is soft, flowing, soothing, and healing yet also enduring and strong to the extent that it fully resists any negative or deteriorating influence. It is balanced, harmonious, and present evenly throughout the entire body and yet it is completely malleable--it can change its qualities to reflect any specific vibration or energy which is required to sustain health and equilibrium within the body.

Alchemy attempts to produce through natural means an elixir or philosopher's stone which embodies the quintessence of nature's energies. Nature is itself striving to evolve toward perfection. The alchemist strives to bring about that perfection of nature's energies within his laboratory.

Most students practicing lung and pour breathing over a period of time will experience a general increase in their health and vitality. But there is more available in this exercise. The human body is a microcosm reflecting within it all the energies of nature as well as the larger universe. As we inhale life force through all the pours of our body, we are also converting that life force into an elixir or quintessence. In the beginning, there are several things to emphasize to enhance this process.

First, develop a really clear image and sensation of your body being completely hollow and empty inside. This empty space, like a hermetically seal flask used in alchemical experiments, enables a mixing and fusing of the energies we place within it. As we inhale through our pours, we are inhaling the specific vital qualities of the different surfaces and parts of our bodies. This energy spreads everywhere inside of us like a perfect mixture.

Though we imagine our body empty inside, the energy we inhale penetrates and vibrates within every internal organ but it does not get trapped within them. It continues on and spreads throughout the entire body. Consequently, there is a mixing of all the different energies within the body which, again, is like mixing and drawing together in small measure all the different energies within nature and the greater universe.

Think of and visualize the body in this way--as a magical container designed to blend the energies of nature and the body in a perfect manner. By concentrating on the empty space within the body, we are evoking the presence of akasha which penetrates everywhere through space in an even manner and without any boundaries or barriers interfering with its movement.

By looking for, sensing, and imagining an elixir being produced through pure breathing--a luminous, rejuvenating, and healing energy, we are also reproducing the action of akasha in regard to time. Akasha suspends the time between this moment and that time when we will develop a perfect body, immortal, indestructible, and eternal. In this section, then, the task during pure breathing is to sense a pure, luminous, soft, serene, radiant, harmonious, cool, soothing, healing, enduring, and dynamic energy being produced within us.

What I am emphasizing here is not at all unusual or original. Again, in Mantak Chia's writings about Taoist practice, the individual at the very beginning learns to gather and to draw into one ball of energy the different external and internal energies of the body. These are then circulated through the different points of the spine and also the internal organs so that this ball of vitality turns into a kind of elixir.

There is however a slightly different emphasis between Taoist goals and those of a magician. The Taoist pursues all means which lead to longevity and which strengthen the endurance of the life force. The elixir I am emphasizing is equally useful for reproducing the enlightened mind which Buddhists pursue, the omnipresent, all-embracing love which Christians see Christ as embodying, and also the absolute power which is more characteristic of a Quabbalistic, spheric magician. Even at this level, we can begin to incorporate each of these paths and ideals into our own breathing practice should we desire to do so. .

2. Breathing Energy Directly in and out of the Etheric Body

Introduction to the Etheric Body

In using the phrase, "etheric body," I am describing the vibratory field of energy or vital life force which penetrates through and also derives its life from the physical body. This field of vital energy is not identical with the biochemical or physiological processes of the physical body. It is more subtle. In the following brief essay, I will discuss the etheric body as it is approached from several traditions

Western medical doctors can detect and accurately locate the classical acupuncture points using only scientific instruments. There is a measurable electro-magnetic shift in the vibration of an acupuncture point as compared to the surrounding surface of the skin. This acupuncture point and the energy being measured has a correlation to the activity of the etheric body. But, for the most part, the etheric body is not yet directly subject to scientific instruments of measurement and detection.

Bardon points out that if you concentrate on an internal organ or part of your body, there is an increase in blood circulation to that part. There is, for example, an increase in temperature due to the

dilation of blood vessels. There are changes in electrical impulses which are also easily measured, for example, by an ohmmeter.

But again, there measurable changes are not the etheric body itself which is more subtle. If you breathe into your hand and feel a strong pressure, some of what you feel is from increased blood circulation and change in temperature. But, if you are sensitive, beneath these more obvious sensations you can sense the vital energy moving within the etheric body.

Blood stays in the arteries and veins of your body. The vital energy you produce in your breathing will move anywhere you want it to. Consequently, with practice, you can get the vital energy compressed into your right hand to move, for example, down and into your left foot. You can also get it to move into another individual's body who is next to you or on the other side of the planet.

Generally speaking, when an individual is healthy, all the internal organs of the body produce more vital energy than is necessary for the functioning of that organ. This surplus charge of energy can be consciously refined and fused with other body energies. It can be circulated through the body to increase the strength and harmony of the etheric body.

Some individuals have a natural flair for working with vital energy and healing others with it. As I mention elsewhere, one Taoist student discovered that any internal Taoist meditation or circulation of chi she did in her body she could just as easily reproduce in someone else's body as well. Finding it easy to imagine herself within another's body, she could work with that individual's energy as easily as her own.

When most individual's die, the vital energy associated with the physical body rapidly dissolves since it is dependent on the biochemistry and physiological processes of the physical body. The deceased then enters the astral plane where he or she resides within an astral body which slowly deteriorates and which may be abandoned quickly or at a later point, e.g., when the individual chooses to incarnate again. That is the idea anyway.

Having worked for a lifetime with their mental bodies, some high Buddhist adepts have a practice in which they preserve the qualities of their mental bodies when they reincarnate. They may even describe when and where they will be reborn again going into great detail giving names and specific descriptions of their location. One such Tibetan lama consciously decided to adopt an astral body more suited for working with Westerners. Running a monastery with thousands of monks under him in Tibet required a powerful and dominating presence. But foreseeing that he would one day work with Westerners, he changed his personality for his next incarnation so it would be more appealing to Western values and standards. He chose a personality which was warm, inviting, and empathic.

On the other hand, descriptions in the Bardon system of spirits and of cosmic letters occasionally refer to the "immortality of the astral body." That is, the actual personality of the individual with its unique combination of the four elements retains its strength and does not deteriorate unless the individual should choose to make a change. The immortality of the astral body is often a consciously stated goal in some Taoist practices. A master once referred to making a house in which you live when you die, namely, an immortal astral body.

But there is more going in magick than this. There is also the conscious effort to build a powerful etheric body. The 24 elemental beings Bardon describes in his second book not only have extremely powerful astral bodies. They have powerful though non-physical etheric bodies which give them a heightened magical means for interacting with nature and the physical world when they choose to

do so.

The mummies of the Egyptian Pharaohs were often placed within pyramids. This, along with the mummification process and rituals, was an attempt to enable an astral immortality by preserving an etheric matrix on the physical plane. The physical mummy serves as a kind of battery or device for accumulating energy which then circulates to the departed soul. Similarly, the Chinese fung sui masters are concerned about the direction and placement of your ancestors bones. Ancestor worship may act to keep alive and to preserve the astral matrix of the departed soul. Consequently, there is also a return circulation of energy which moves through the bones of the departed soul to the descendants. In fung sui, the alignment of those bones influences the flow of energy.

Also in some schools of Taoism as in a few other religions there is a conscious attempt to preserve not only the astral body but also the etheric body of departed masters such as the eight immortals and other masters of a specific lineage. Whether the departed soul has any tie to this astral-etheric shell is irrelevant to the practice. The practitioners hope to gain a shaktipat or transference of energy from the master to those who are present during a ritual of evocation.

The Bardon spirits of the earthzone, by contrast, do not maintain physical, etheric, astral, or mental bodies. They preside without form within an akashic state of awareness. They are free to assume any form they wish and do so to represent themselves in a visible manner during an evocation by a magician. All 360 of them are quite capable of manifesting on the mental, astral, and physical planes should they desire to do so. In other words, they have mastered the three lower planes and can produce a mental, astral, and physical vehicle of manifestation at will.

In our basic practice here, there is nothing going on so mysterious or occult. If you can strengthen and energize your etheric body while you are alive, it kicks in automatically whenever you need extra energy. It preserves your harmony and equilibrium in the same way that having flexible and strong muscles gives you an edge in undertaking physical tasks.

Some athletes have fabulous physical bodies but once they retire from their sport and begin another career, there is no need for them to maintain such a high level of conditioning. Arnold Schwarzeneger, the former world champion weight lifter, may still keep in shape but not while he is shooting a movie such as Terminator as part of his new career as an actor. Similarly, a well-developed magician may choose to maintain his etheric matrix when he dies or let go of it depending on his purpose.

Combining Pour Breathing with the Etheric Body

The purpose of this exercise is to learn to imagine and then sense the etheric body. We do this so that it becomes easier to develop the etheric body and to increase our level of vitality.

Later on, when Bardon discusses the mental body, he has the student visualize a picture of himself standing in front of him. The student then places his consciousness within this image. In learning to project the astral body, the student transfers his breathing directly into the mental body which again is seen as being independent of the physical body.

In this exercise, we imagine the etheric body to be slightly larger and overlapping our physical body. Similar to working with the astral body, in this exercise we imagine the etheric body is drawing in and expelling energy directly from the air. Though we continue the lung and pour breathing, we imagine that the etheric body is also breathing by itself.

3. Strengthening the Etheric Body

The etheric body is not woven together by muscle, bone, tendon, and sinew and yet we can strengthen it through many different methods. In this section, I will mention two approaches.

(1). First, concentrate again on the image and feeling of your etheric body. Now imagine that every part of the etheric body is connected equally to every other part and every point to every other point. The idea is to produce a strong feeling of cohesion and interconnection within the etheric body.

There are many ways of approaching this in a concrete manner. One such method derives from Taoist practice. Both in Jin Shin Jyitsui and in Mantak Chia's work, the Tu Mo and Jen Mo meridians are combined to form the main central meridian. This enables one circular flow of vital energy around the outside of the body. Mantak Chia goes into detail on this meditation practice in his book, *Awakening Healing Energy through the Tao*. Mary Burmeister, the Jin Shin Jyitsui master, has a similar method which is done through application of the individual's hands rather than through meditation.

Similarly, in many Taoist practices, meditating on the meridians is used as a means for becoming conscious of and connecting the energy flows of vitality through the body. Dr. Stephen Thomas Chang in his book, *The Complete Book of Acupuncture, Celestial Arts*, 1976, gives a brief description, p. 48, of The Around the World Massage, "Using the bulb of the thumb or index and middle fingers, gently massage the entire length of each of the main meridians in the direction of the energy flow along the meridian." [The sequence is lung, large intestine, stomach, spleen-pancreas, heart, small intestine, bladder, kidney, heart constrictor, triple heater, gall bladder, and liver.]

After becoming competent in the previous exercise, he suggests meditating on the meridians. "...focus all your attention on the lung meridian. Trace the path of the lung meridian with your index and middle finger paying close attention to the concurrent subjective feelings that arise as a result of this procedure. Mentally follow the flow of energy as it descends along the lung meridian and then repeat the same procedure along the large intestine meridian which has an ascending flow of energy. Massaging the entire length of all twelve of the main meridians will eventually enable one to sense the most minute energy fluctuation along the meridian circuit. Ultimately, one will be able to willfully direct the energy flow along any one of the meridians. Becoming consciously aware of the circulation of energy within the body will confer longevity of life, for this ability will enable one to maintain a state of energy balance under any and all circumstances."

If you want a very detailed book showing the acupuncture points and meridians, you might consider the *Anatomical Atlas of Chinese Acupuncture Points*, Shandong Science and Technology Press, distributed by Pergamon Press. There are of course many books on this topic and you can find those which suit your needs.

I recall being in one class where the teacher had the students quickly trace the lines of the twelve main meridians over the surface of the entire body in about two minutes time. Once you have the meridian paths memorized, it is pretty easy to trace them with your fingers. Dr. Chang is suggesting, however, that the student slow down and meditate deeply on the energy flow through each of the meridians. In Mantak Chia's system, there is an emphasis on what is called the "extra meridians." These meridians, such as the Tu Mo and Jen Mo, are more suited for gathering and circulating surplus energy through the body.

There are a variety of ways to meditate and work with the energy of the meridians. If you were to try Chang's method of meditation on the meridians, relax and sink your mind slowly into the meridian. Try to feel the energy flowing through the meridian and then connect the meridian in your mind with the corresponding internal organ. The particular energy of the meridian and its corresponding organ have a similar vibration since they are closely related.

Many students will have no interest in the complexities of Chinese meridians and meditations. I mention the above example to illustrate a system which teaches how to direct and strengthen the movement of vital energy within the etheric body. In its defense, I would point out that the Chinese system of acupuncture and meridians is part of the curriculum in every medical school in mainland China. The more simple but abstract method I suggest of meditating on all parts of the body being interconnected is more of an akashic meditation.

(2) In this meditation, we concentrate on each part of the body offering balance and support to every other part. You can proceed, for example, by concentrating on a part of your body such as your hand. You sense that the energy of your hand supports every other part of your body as well as your whole body. And every other part of your body and your whole body support the energy of your hand. You continue on working with all parts of your body.

This is kind of like a focusing technique which I describe in detail under the section of my web page on Methods in Transpersonal Psychology. In that system, the individual will consciously focus his attention on one specific area of the body which is in some way restricted or blocked. In doing this, the individual also imagines the rest of the body offering its support by being open and receptive to the blocked area. In other words, the energy of the whole body is available to any area of need.

The Chakras as an Example of Internal Support

Another example of the internal support which occurs within the body relates to the system of the seven chakras. There are a great many books about the seven chakras but let me just mention a few points on how they support each other. The heart chakra is known for its harmony and compassion. Those with strong hearts like to resolve conflicts. They have high empathy. They are sensitive to others' feelings.

The third chakra in the solar plexus region, by contrast, establishes a direct connection between oneself and others. It is forceful, assertive, and commanding. The heart chakra needs the lower third chakra in order to avoid feeling vulnerable and unable to communicate itself. The third chakra presents the force of personality and charm an individual needs to win other's over to its position. And the third chakra needs the heart's harmony otherwise it becomes manipulative and injures others' feelings. By the way, the individuals who gain the most experience in life are those with this combination of strong third and four chakras.

The throat chakra is known for its creativity. It embodies great determination, adaptability, and ingenuity. The throat chakra is balanced by the second chakra in the belly below the navel. The second chakra deals with sexuality, sensuality, and also with those feelings and intuitions which guide a person in sensing what makes for happiness and affection. It has a great sense of what is natural and of what preserves your energy as an individual.

If a highly creative individual in the throat chakra can maintain an equally developed second chakra, he can keep his creativity from becoming rigid, artificial, compulsive, and haphazard. This is

because he will know when to withdraw from activity and renew himself in natural ways. And if the second chakra person can develop his throat chakra, his life will not only be natural and flowing. There will be productivity and interaction with exciting and creative individuals. Those with strong second chakras are sometimes so relaxed and content, they fail to exercise initiative and to take charge of their lives.

The sixth chakra or third eye is known for its psychic power. It offers an individual a combination of detachment, profound intuition, and spiritual purpose but it also burns up a great deal of vital energy when it is being used. Consequently, many spiritually gifted and psychic individuals limit their use of the third eye to a very narrow range of activities lest they become exhausted or suffer nervous tension.

The third eye, however, is balanced by developing in equal measure the first chakra at the base of the spine or above the perineum. This lower chakra contains the life force of nature and a profound sense of being grounded both within the material world and within the physical body. When a psychic or spiritual practitioner has his third eye balanced by his first chakra, he is down to earth, practical, and hard working. He rarely suffers from that fuzzy, other worldly and self-doubt you can often find in the eyes of spiritual adventurers.

Similarly, the first chakra individual who has a strong third eye does not get stuck in a physical situation or bogged down by his routines. He can sense in advance when a change is coming and he is ready to work with it when it arrives. The seventh chakra, the crown chakra, depends on the lower six chakras to express its visions. And yet it also interacts with the six. It presides over them acting as a higher aspect of conscience prodding and warning an individual when it is time to grow and to belong to a greater whole.

Following the chakras as a meditation, you feel that the two parts of your body relating to the chakras are connected and supporting each other. You imagine that the love in your heart is present in and supports the activities of your personality. And the forceful, assertive side of your third chakra is present and helps express the more tender and empathic feelings of your heart.

Similarly, your sexuality, sensuality, and need to express affection in your second chakra supports your throat chakra so your creativity remains natural, wholesome, and healthy. And, in reverse, your creativity and adaptability keep finding for you new and challenging ways to express your inner feelings.

With the third eye and the lowest chakra, you imagine that all the surplus vital energy in your body is available to your higher intuition, to support and empower it, whenever you wish to meditate and seek spiritual guidance. At the same time, you guard your life force and protect your health. You do not burn yourself out or become exhausted by excessive spiritual or psychic activity. Instead, you contemplate your life and activities to make sure everything is ordered and is fulfilled in the right way.

In summary, the first meditation on strengthening the etheric body emphasized each part and point being joined to every other so the etheric body is sensed as being one interconnected whole. In this second meditation, we emphasize the nurturing aspect of the etheric body. When there is a weakness or disturbance of vital energy, the whole etheric body offers its strength and harmony.

Note: the next section will cover:

4. Gathering the Five Elements through Breathing

This section has three parts. The first is a meditation reminding us of the interaction and presence of the five elements within our bodies. The second is an exploration and integration of the vital energy which animates each of the 12 signs of the zodiac as they manifest in human behavior. After becoming thoroughly familiar with the first two meditations, we proceed to the third meditation which reminds us that the life force we breathe in with each breath has universal aspects. Within the vitality of the air are the four aspects of Divine Providence--immortality, cosmic wisdom and enlightenment, absolute power, and all-embracing, cosmic love.

Physical Level – The Philosophers Stone

The idea of physical and astral immortality have been around a long time, for ages stretching back before written history. Many bishops and popes in the Christian church were obsessed with the idea of the philosopher's stone. It was said to be able to prolong life and transform lead into gold. When it comes to greed, such an idea easily lends itself to fraud in the hands of a good con man.

Many magicians also in the Middle Ages and after spent their life times searching for the philosopher's stone. Their experiments with various elixirs contributed to the formation of modern chemistry. There are many books recently written about alchemy and the philosopher's stone both as something to be sought and obtained as a physical substance and also as a spiritual attainment within oneself.

Those committed to producing something physical and those committed to producing something spiritual have sometimes been very critical of each other's goals. The one is criticized as being a gross materialist and the other is criticized as completely spiritualizing something that actually belongs to the sphere of nature and the real world.

Science I am sure will eventually produce the philosopher's stone or its scientific equivalent in its own good time for that is the nature of science--to discover everything that can be known about the physical universe. My goals are more humble. I am interesting in learning to be aware of, to explore, and to transform to whatever extent I can the vital energies within my physical and astral bodies.

The idea of astral immortality, although saved for a heavenly afterlife in Christianity, is definitely a part of various sects in Buddhism and Taoism. High Tibetan lamas, such as the "golden child" or Karmapa in the Kagyu order of Tibetan Buddhism, are said to have the ability to consciously pick their next incarnation after they die. The Karmapa is so precise he gives the names of his next parents and describes their location in his instructions to his disciples as to where to come and find him after he is reborn.

This action of magical incarnation carries with it a continuity of consciousness, that is, the same spiritual qualities, abilities, and often the same memories are present in the incarnating individual. You are simply sending your consciousness into the body of a child which requires that you relearn to speak and gain control again over your nervous system. But it is the same old you who is living on.

Taoists tend to emphasize, in addition to the Chinese ideal of long life, the concept of astral immortality. In other words, here in this life you begin working on designing and building the astral body you will inhabit when you die and live on the astral plane. You want to be strong,

radiant, and feel fully alive when you die and not be a ghost or slowly have your personality fade away over the centuries subject to the disintegrating influences of the astral plane. Though unfamiliar to Western consciousness, this ideal results from being concerned with the worship of ancestors and with prolonging and refining life, life force, and health.

Since Franz Bardon describes many spirits who specialize in alchemy and also various cosmic letters which he says lead to astral and physical immortality, it is natural for me to pursue this topic in my own way--that is, in a personal and psychic way through my own experimentation and experience.

The Philosopher's Stone in the Aura

In chapter 3, physical level, of his book, *Initiation into Hermetics*, Franz Bardon has the student practice concentrating and also accumulating vital energy in one's body through the use of breath. (Also see my commentary under Basic Practices on my web site, Chapter 3, Physical Level, Pour Breathing). If you breathe air in and out of every part of your body, for example, you can begin to sense the vitalization of each part of your body. If you practice accumulating this vital energy in each part of your body, you begin to strengthen and learn to heal the various parts of your own and other's bodies.

This kind of accumulation of vital energy, however, heavily favors the fire element. Bardon points out that the body becomes hot and radiates waves of heat like a hot radiator when the life force is concentrated in the body when you follow his instructions. This form of accumulation of vital energy is great for healing since the fire element is often used in healing.

In chapter 3 on the psychic level, Bardon has the student practice accumulating each of the four elements. The fire element in this case, however, is not in particular an aspect of vital energy. The fire element in nature, when gathered through breathing, produces an energy that is hot and fiery. It has a burning quality. The accumulated life force, by contrast, results in a kind of white light accumulation that is more organic, more a part of the natural energy of the body. It is also hot and expansive but definitely a healing energy as opposed to a fiery burning energy.

Some individuals are addicted to white light. They love it to the exclusion of the other aspects of life force. They adore gurus with bright shiny auras. Some of these individuals get very upset or outright paranoid when they encounter someone who is exploring light in the non-visible spectrum of vibration.

But in the actual physical universe white light is very small part of the total amount of energy being emitted throughout the universe. Besides star and solar light, there are many other forms of light in the invisible spectrum which are far more present with us and throughout the universe. These are ultraviolet, infrared, X-rays, gamma rays, and other forms of cosmic radiation. These too are light and our consciousness moves in these spectrums of light vibration as well.

The air we breathe in has the four elements in it and not just the bright fiery element. In every breath, we are drawing in a combination of the four elements. In part, we can learn to

become conscious of these four elements and direct them at will by working with each separately.

You can, for example, do breath accumulation of life force emphasizing the other elements. Earth, air, and water are not so bright like white light and certainly not hot and fiery. Some individuals, in fact, may find that the intense accumulation of life force within one's body through breathing is not particularly harmonious or health producing. A one-sided vitality accumulation may produce disharmonies depending on the individual's psychic makeup.

The water life force accumulation, as opposed to the fiery or white light kind of accumulation, is magnetic, cool, and soothing. You can imagine for example sitting in a pool of water in front of a falls and practice breathing in and out air as your body is surrounded by a fine mist of vapor from the falls. In this case, you can learn to sense more of the watery energy that is present in the same breath that you breathe in. You are just altering your mental imagery slightly to produce a different result in terms of your elemental accumulation.

But again, the accumulation of the water element in nature is different from the accumulation of the water aspect of vital life force in the body. If you use breath to accumulate the water element, you get in your body a cold, wet sensation of water. If you breathe in air utilizing the imagery for example of sitting in front of a water fall, you are getting more of the watery energy that is a part of your own life force.

This energy is not wet and cold. It is soothing and cleansing, even nurturing and sustaining. It is these health-producing, elemental energies within breath and the organic vitality of the body which I am interested in pursuing in this essay.

The element of air vital accumulation results in a balancing and harmonizing energy. The earth element vital accumulation is peaceful, calming, and stabilizing. The akasha element concentration produces a sense of inner stillness and profound faith.

If you gather and then blend these together, combining the opposite pairs carefully and then adding the akasha, you get a feeling of strong health and rejuvenation or the combination of all the qualities of each of the five elements. But this is still a dim reflection of what it is possible to incorporate in the human body.

The magician will naturally seek to explore and master the four elements in nature. The elements in nature are not necessarily friendly or harmonious with the vital energies in the human body. If you project into the undine's realm or the oceans, you may learn a lot about the vibration of the ocean or the incredibly states of bliss and ecstasy belonging to undines.

But you may return from these mental or astral explorations exhausted or in some cases haunted and disturbed by what you have encountered. There is no such imbalance or strain as an effect if you are working with the four elements which are a part of and present in your own vital energy.

Below are some of my preliminary thoughts and comments of what I am currently exploring, mostly in the last four days while meditating on the philosopher's stone. My interest is in the philosopher's stone which you produce in your aura. The goal here is to sense, explore, become familiar with, universalize, strengthen, and harmonize personal health.

My procedure is basically to focus within my body and then ask the spiritual world various questions and then record my thoughts and responses to the impressions I receive. I am not exactly new to this topic. I have spend many months during different years working on producing chemical based elixirs. But though I could produce very potent energies these were not particularly useful to me. The problem is I am under a powerful karmic limitation (which I did not understand at the time) to avoid using any physical implements or aids to my magical work in life.

That means no wands, no magick mirrors, no elixirs, no robes, no incense, etc. etc. I apparently overindulged and did too much of that sort of ritualized and externalized magical activity in other life times. In this life time my work is intended to be more simple and direct, more artistic and personal, than what was the norm for this kind of activity as practiced in other civilizations.

Questions

Question: What is the difference between a physical philosopher's stone and producing this energy in your aura?

Answer: The material philosopher's stone is a powdery substance which is incredibly expansive in producing healing and balancing life force. It can be used to heal others.

It is not just material, however. It combines in its vibration an ability to restore the elements and health of the astral body as well.

If you ingested some of the philosopher's stone, you would be producing a harmonious and universal level of health beginning with the physical elements in your body and working toward the inner planes of the astral, mental, etc. If you have the philosopher's stone vibration in your aura, you are producing the same universal level of health but through having the mental, astral, and etheric vibration influence and sustain the health of the physical body.

One is external and works quicker and more easily on the physical body. The other is internal and works quicker and more easily on the etheric and astral bodies.

How do the physical and auric philosopher's stone relate to physical and astral immortality?

Answer: Theoretically, both can produce physical immortality, that is, continuous physical health without deterioration. The physical philospoher's stone, however, does not produce astral immortality. That is, if the individual were to die, the astral body would be subject to the usual gradual process of deterioration. In other words, if you lose the physical support of ingesting the philosopher's stone as a medicinal elixir, you lose contact with its rejuvenating power.

The auric philosopher's stone, by contrast, does produce astral immortality, that is, a continuous sustaining of health and a resilience of the elements and form of the astral body. Again, this is because the physical stone has the advantage of influence more easily the physical body but has limited influence on the astral body's health and maintenance. The physical stone neither contains nor produces an autonomous and independent astral influence.

If you are sustaining your health through a physical elixir, you have to make more using the materials of the physical world when you use up your supply. If you are producing an internal philosopher's stone by using your own powers of concentration, then you can continue doing this when you are on the astral plane. One form of rejuvenation is external to yourself and the other is internal.

What is the appropriate philosopher's stone for me to work within my aura?

Answer: The elixir suitable for you to work with incorporates cosmic qualities or specific aspects of Divine Providence within it since your goal involves spiritualizing both the physical and the astral bodies.

What and how are the elements present in this stone?

The air element is similar to the akashic level of the cosmic letter *A*. This is the quality within air which is absolute and total enlightenment without limit. This is an enlightenment and wisdom that are cosmic and not just human in scope. It is a wisdom that belongs to Divine Providence and is equally effective anywhere in the universe. It is not a part of any human tradition.

Anyone who works with the cosmic letter *A* on the akashic level can begin to sense this energy and consciousness. You practice the concentration, you work with the energy, and you gain the experience. It is direct, personal, and it is the realm of nature in its cosmic dimension.

In this state of awareness, there is nothing you can not understand or comprehend. There is nothing that can bind, restrict, or limit your consciousness. You combine perfect and absolute freedom with a full appreciation of the laws and greater harmony that govern the universe. The goal is to become the embodiment, agent, and representative of this harmony on earth.

The earth element is an awareness of immortality, of physical matter being indestructible, that is, enduring without aging or suffering deterioration of any kind. Your consciousness becomes one with physical matter and you are fully aware of the power behind and within it and that sustains it. The power within matter that maintains and sustains its form and nature becomes part of your consciousness.

The water element is purifying (that is, cleansing), healing, and nurturing. Through the flowing, receptive, and magnetic qualities of water, oneness becomes complete. The water element in both its natural and divine aspects renews, restores, and fills with life because its love is so deep.

The fire element is perfect, complete, and absolute will and power. It can bring about change suddenly like lightning striking. It is massive and overpowering like the fusion of the sun exploding. It is silent, often hidden, and yet controlling like the magma that shapes and moves the continents. It is the force of will, that when assigned a mission or a purpose, accomplishes that mission and fulfills that purpose because there is no obstacle it can not overcome--it has that kind of determination and dynamic built into it.

Akasha, as the fifth element, has many aspects and qualities. Since we are focusing on the quintessence of life force in the body, akasha in this case involves a perfect penetration of all

aspects of the body with conscious awareness. This means that your awareness comes to understand not only the anatomy and all physiological and neurological processes within the body. You also comprehend the way in which the body is the temple of Divine Providence. It is the vehicle that enables the highest spirit and God consciousness to be physically present on earth.

There have been great kings who have built elaborate temples and priests of great power, purity, and religious intent who have entered those temples and spoken the sacred names of God. But a more fitting temple has already designed and anointed by God for this purpose--it is within each of our bodies should we but become conscious of it.

These five elements which I have described are perfectly joined and one. United, they produce a version of the philosopher's stone that can manifest within the human aura.

How or what is the process by which this energy is obtained, trained, practiced, and developed?

Answer: You meditate on each of the divine elements and then combine the pairs of opposites and then the akasha also into one.

Why do the pairs in particular need to be combined rather than work through each element one after another?

Answer: You combine the opposites of earth and air, and fire and water, and then these two sets together in order to bring more consciousness into the process so that the joining is perfected. You want the elements to interpenetrate rather than just being present at the same time.

What additional energy needs to be present?

Answer: You also need to add the natural elixir which exists within nature to this fusion so that it is not just a magical production but is accomplished in association and union with nature also.

What is the highest elixir like this in nature?

Answer: The image for it is the unicorn which is the closest animal embodying this energy. When you have the energy of the philosopher's stone you notice that it is solid like a mountain, open and clear like the sky, hot like a fiery conflagration, watery like the ocean, and akashic in that it penetrates through all ages of the world.

Besides these elemental components which are within it, the natural philosopher's stone in the aura can be described as a highly condensed vital energy that is wildly exuberant, that is, it increases the amount of energy you have so you feel incredibly enthusiastic. At the same time, it is passionately ecstatic, that is, you feel an inner union, rapport, and oneness between your body with the entire realm of nature.

In addition, every form of life, every desire and instinct, finds satisfaction in the peace and equilibrium that is within you. There is great depth and silent power that is simultaneously riotous in its celebration of the beauty and the life that reveals itself in a new way in each moment. It is a state of body and mind that is timeless, encompassing all ages of the world in

its immortality, but also is thrilled, taking delight in the joy that blossoms in and through each sensory impression.

Franz Bardon warns that using an elixir with this degree of potency can give youthful energy and outlook but there is a cost. You lose the wisdom you have gained from experience as well as your magical powers. It is not that you forget the knowledge you have acquired. Rather, you return to a time of youthful vitality in which your physical and astral bodies are enthralled and overpowered with riotous instincts. You no longer care about wisdom because you are carried away as you surf the waves of desire and gratification.

There is a remedy for this tradeoff in which you exchange your wisdom for youthful energy. Right from the beginning of your practice you impregnate your life force and your astral body with divine qualities. You make it a life long practice to join the qualities of your inner spirit and this quintessence of nature's life force. In this way, you learn to combine in your awareness the purity and universality of your spirit with the potency of primal life force so that you learn to see clearly the origin and fulfillment of every desire and need.

The body is a temple. You can find within it the Presence of God as well as mother nature, the goddess kundalini, and every force and spirit that represent the powers of creation. Working with the philosopher's stone requires a special commitment and a spirit of celebration most profound.

How is the energy elixir in nature obtained in the human body?

Answer: For the air element, you have to imagine the atmosphere of the earth, become familiar with it, and then turn some of that vibration of air into a vital energy which can reside in your body in a harmonious manner. The same with a mountain, the sea, fire, and akasha.

How do you turn the vibration of the atmosphere, etc. into a vital energy organic to the human body?

Answer: You remain conscious of the vital energy in your body while you place your consciousness into the atmosphere and identify with it. Slowly, the vital energy in your body is raised and expanded in its vibration so that it becomes transformed and universalized in harmony with nature.

If you just project your consciousness into the atmosphere you get the air element on a universal level but this energy vibration is not harmonious and supportive of the vital energy in your body. You have to move more slowly and allow the imagery and your consciousness of the atmosphere to take effect in transforming the vital energy within your body.

In other words, you first sense the vitality in your body. And then very gradually you introduce into this vitality an awareness of being within the sky. Slowly, you become acquainted with the weightlessness, openness, and airy expanse of the sky. The imagery you use of the sky has to be so gentle and relaxed that it does not produce any tension, only an increasing sense of harmony--like an exhalation of breath through which you feel released, satisfied, and at peace.

You pursue a similar course with the other elements. With earth, you bring into your consciousness the solidity of a mountain. With water, you contain in your awareness the

magnetism and fluidity of the seas. With fire, you hold in your awareness a great, fiery cataclysm.

And with akasha, the fifth element, you have the time frame and the awareness that comprehends the process through which the mineral, plant, and animal kingdoms are developed as well the four elements of earth, sea, air, and fire and the vital energies in both male and female human beings. The akashic element is an awareness both of what is in nature and of the fusion of these energies.

This akashic element is itself a vital or natural energy and as such it is a part of nature. It oversees the refining and transforming of natural energies but it requires the condensed essence of male and female and the four elements before it attains its full power to rejuvenate.

What is the state of mind in which to practice these meditations?

Answer: You practice in an extremely relaxed state of mind. You are so relaxed that your mind is in a dream like state, free of any concerns or worries and there is no intensification of your mental vibration as you concentrate or focus your awareness. In other words, you remain so much in harmony with the vital energy of your body that you at no point disturb the natural flow of currents in your body. It is like entering the stream of life force in your body and then adding to its richness and depth without blocking the natural flow.

What is the equivalent of the concentrated life force of this order in the body of a male and female?

Answer: The concentrated life force is found primarily in the male seed and the female eggs. The male seed or semen is electrical, penetrating, expansive, and potent. The female eggs are magnetic, attracting, and contain great depths--they contain a reflection of the universe within them.

Can these energies of the genders be combined to produced an elixir?

Answer: No. The gender energies produce an electromagnetic bond and not the elixir though you can psychically and through akasha join the genitals of the opposite genders and get a high state of equilibrium and balance between their primal energies. This of course results in a high level of empathy and attraction between the partners.

Can the male and female sexual energies be joined and fused after they have been refined?

Answer: Yes. The hot, expansive, and electrical energy of male sexuality can be refined so that it is free of desire, that is, of the compelling need to produce a result in the material world. Similarly, the cool, magnetic, and containing female sexual energy can be refined so that it is free of the compelling desire to produce a material result. These two refined energies can be joined so that there is one fused and new form of vitality.

This joined essence of the male and female is itself like an elixir in that it is highly potent. It produces faith, conviction, endurance, equilibrium, health, and strength. But it would need to fuse within it the energies of nature before it becomes a universal healing elixir.

How are these energies of the male and female refined?

Answer: You first extract from the masculine sexual energy the will and power found within it. This is a matter of finding the appropriate image or divine symbol that can gather this fiery energy into itself without imposing upon, repressing, or destroying the fiery energy. You have to find a symbol that resonates with your gut emotions, your personality, and also with your spirit at the same time.

The process is the same for the female sexual energy. You have to gather the feminine essence that is cool, magnetic, and containing around and within a symbol that embodies nurturing love and compassion. If you try to impose a symbol or image upon the sexual life force that is not fully organic and resonate with that life force, then you lose most of the life force in which case you lose your power and natural enthusiasm.

If you use a symbol which is not harmonious with your personality, the power of the life force you refine will be at war with you. If you use a symbol that is not harmonious with and a reflection of your inner spirit, then it may give you power and health, but this new energy will not aid you in the fulfillment of your destiny.

In addition, to the male sexual energy you add the enlightenment within the air element so that the masculine drive gains detachment and clarity, that is, freedom from compulsion. To the female sexual energy you add the earth element so that the feminine drive loses its need to contain. In each case, the sexual energy becomes free of the need to produce a material result. In both cases, they become free to be used in pure forms of creativity without being driven by unconscious desires.

In the earlier section describing the four elements corresponding to Divine Providence, I give examples of the kind of qualities that might be used to refine the energies in nature. The sexual energies are so malleable and adaptable that they can easily attach themselves to any kind of imagery that an individual finds personally compelling. The task is to find imagery that is resonate and harmonious with all sides of your self so that you are both empowered and transformed. This means you have to do a lot of thinking and contemplating about who you are personally, about what drives you from within, and what your spiritual goals are in this life.

Note: I am writing a book called *Mystical Fables* which explores a number of masculine and feminine images of magicians and poets, lovers and warriors, who represent for me images that gather the energies of my subconscious, my personality, and my spirit.

Why do gnomes such as Erami and Mentifil suggest human beings can use the polarities of their opposite genders to develop a philosopher's stone in their auras?

Answer: Erami's procedure utilizing partners for producing the vibration of the philosopher's stone in one's aura still relies on the combining of opposite energies in nature and the refining of these energies by focusing the awareness of akasha on them. The electric and magnetic fluids and masculine and feminine sexual polarities are used as a means to amplify, accelerate, and deepen the results. The polar masculine and feminine energies themselves are not the essential catalyst for the transformation of diverse nature energies into the elixir. But again, the opposite attraction of male and female can quicken and enrich the alchemical process as they can in any form of magick.

The difference is that the electrical fluid concentrated in the male and the magnetic fluid concentrated in the female are primordial kinds of power. With a well-designed electro-

magnetic volt (that is, surrounding an accumulation of the electrical fluid with magnetic fluid), you can initiate a powerful process of alchemical transformation.

The philosopher's stone, however, requires that you fully enter each of the elements of nature with your consciousness, transform them, and then fuse them. It is a natural process of refining and expanding awareness and fusing energy and it is free of personal ego. The dynamic attraction of masculine and feminine polarities tends to move too quickly toward union and is often beset with emotional highs and lows which undermine a genuine alchemical process.

(See also my 16 page essay, *Erami*, in my book, *Sylphs, Undines, Gnomes, and Salamanders*, for an example of how to work step by step either solo or with a partner in producing the vibration of the philosopher's stone in your aura.)

What do Taoists get in their auras when they try to develop this elixir?

Answer: From time to time there have been individuals who have produced very high grade philosopher's stones in their auras. This is sometimes called the immortality pearl. The immortality pearl in one well-known Taoist, for example, is very bright, radiant, and impressive. But it lacks the divine qualities and it lacks the natural elements of earth, water, and especially air. These missing ingredients severely limit the healing power of this individual.

It is a mistake to not incorporate more fully the power of the elements in nature and bring them into the body where they are transformed. The body is unable by itself to produce the philosopher's stone without referring to nature or to divine quality meditations. That is, you can not just take and refine and recombine the natural vital energies in the body to produce the elixir without utilizing a great deal of imagery which transforms this vitality to a very high degree.

What do the various spirits teach or produce when working with them relating to the philosopher's stone or elixirs?

Answer: For example, Kirek, 9 degrees Virgo in the earthzone, teaches about the philosopher's stone. This spirit is extremely intense in its vibration. The difference between Kirek and what I am describing is that from Kirek's point of view it is not necessary to be concerned so much with universalizing the astral body or the four elements in order to produce astral or physical immortality.

With astral immortality, you only need to engage in prolonged and very intense concentrations on each of the elements. The goal is to produce a high quality vibration in each of the elements to the point where they no longer deteriorate. The elements then resist all outside influence.

Also, being a high level spirit of the earthzone who resides in a formless state of awareness in akasha, Kirek naturally has the ability to manifest physically and produce purely through concentration whatever effect he wishes within his sphere of competency. Kirek could direct you in the use of alchemical methods utilizing chemical and herbs and so forth. But a high level contact with Kirek enables you to draw upon his power of concentration to also transform your physical body directly so that it acts as if you have been influenced by a

physical philosopher's stone. He also teaches much more in regard to resisting the negative influence of the elements in our world.

Spirits from the different planetary spheres also teach alchemy and the perfection of life force in accordance with the themes and interests of their spheres. Cambiel, who presides over the sign of Aquarius in the sphere of Jupiter, teaches about alchemy and the philosopher's stone. His approach, by contrast to Kirek's, is much more universal and cosmic in dimension.

The elixir or vibration Cambiel's produces is much more expansive and more readily influences others and the world around yourself in accordance with the expansiveness and great spiritual wealth of the sphere of Jupiter. Cambiel, however, is far more difficult to work with as compared to Kirek's who is closer to home and much more direct and "down to earth."

How does this practice relate to the cosmic letter OE which focuses specifically on alchemical transformation?

Answer: The cosmic letter OE emphasizes the kind of concentrations that lead to transformation on all levels and planes of existence. The auric philosopher's stone I am emphasizing in this essay is primarily focused on your own body and the upgrading and universalizing of your health and astral body to reflect within it some of the qualities of Divine Providence.

The OE is not specifically for embodying in yourself the four fundamental qualities of Divine Providence as they pertain to expanding and harmonizing your vitality and health. You are using part of the OE vibration as far as working with the akashic element in seeking to become completely conscious of your physical body. You are not working with the OE in so far as the OE is concerned with every other kind of transformation in the universe such as changing matter from one form into another.

On the astral plane, however, the OE is similar to what we are working on here. It is a penetrating awareness which is able to overcome any distinction created from opposites. Masculine and feminine, fire and water, air and earth, light and dark, etc.--all opposites are understood as what they are and also on another level in which they are transformed by being joined to a greater whole.

OE on the astral plane captures the entire process of producing the philosopher's stone, that is, the highest elixir of refined natural healing energy. It condenses this process into one feeling--the ability to draw forth the highest light and purest essence within anything that exists.

In this sense, the OE is concerned with the universal and cosmic aspects of transformation. It is nice to work with this letter as a form of quality control since it develops your intuition. Cosmic letters are, however, not in themselves energies which are organic and supportive of health. They are states of awareness and energies oriented toward a cosmic perspective on how to create. They are not always suitable for those who are new to magical practice.

What side effects, imbalances, or dangers might arise as this kind of life force or philosopher's stone develops within our auras?

Answer: Any sudden increase of the amount or quality of vitality within your body may cause difficulties for some individuals. Old habits may become stimulated. New emotions may rise to the surface. There may be a feeling of becoming overpowered or out of control. Some individuals have already observed this and learned about this problem from experience. Let us look at this from another point of view.

When you love and commit to another, you have the opportunity to learn about desire and need, responsibility and freedom. Whatever happens in the relationship--win or lose, rise to heights or fall to depths, sustain loyalty or suffer betrayal--you gain a lot of personal experience. When someone becomes a medical doctor or studies herbology, acupuncture, or a healing art, you are again involved directly in learning through personal experience and what you learn has many immediate applications and benefits.

The philosopher's stone, by contrast, has very little bearing on your personality. You can become a shaman, a natural healer, or study nature for many lifetimes and you still may not receive a hint that nature has a quintessence or a condensed essence that embodies the perfection of its multitude of energies. You can spend many lifetimes as a priest in every major religion or a magician who evokes many beings and still not discover the vibration of Divine Providence within yourself.

The requisite for this practice is that you appreciate the beauty of the universe. If you rise to that level of inspiration, then this practice will always be personal and you will enjoy every minute you give to it. It will be fun and exciting and full of love.

But without this inner union with Divine Providence at the outset, your practice may be haunted by doubt. You may feel you are walking in the dark or sailing at sea on a cloudy night without a compass. And if you begin to succeed so that the life force gathers in strength and intensity, then again, you may be given every opportunity to abuse or to waste this energy or to hoard it the way a dragon hoards its gold because its heart is cold.

We could pose a similar question regarding the Great Work to the sun, a magnificent image and symbol, that is both so powerful and yet impersonal: "How have you learned to be so radiant and bright, so giving of heat and light, so that after billions of years life finally appears and matures on earth?"

And the sun might reply, "Even when I was dark matter, swirling dust amid a cosmic void, even then I could feel in my heart the presence of an infinite joy. Even then I could feel amid that void a love that is everywhere and that has no limitation on its creativity or expression. The sun you see above you is but a small token and outer manifestation of what I am yet to become. But all that I do and that I have done are out of inspiration from love."

In all cases involving the practice of magick as with the other great professions in life, it helps above all else to love what you are doing with all of your heart. In this way, you already embody all that you are becoming and every new thing that occurs or that arises to challenge you you automatically accept it and make it part of your art.

Summary. The thing I like about the idea of working with refining, harmonizing, universalizing the life force within the body through breathing is that it is so natural and direct. You do not have to go to some other plane to receive instructions. Evocation and spirit contact require a lot of energy and often produce great strain on one's mental, astral, and physical body.

When you are working with your own body, mental imagery, and consciousness of vital life force, you can proceed gradually working from the familiar to the unfamiliar. You always stay within the vibration of harmony and health and do not at any point strain or tax yourself.

In terms of the Bardon practices involving the accumulation of elements, you are focusing here on getting to know and produce in yourself the qualities of the five elements in terms of their vitality and their power of restoring, nourishing, and rejuvenating the human body.

At the same time, you do not put off until the later chapters in *Initiation into Hermetics* the practice with the four fundamental divine qualities. God and Divine Providence should be worked with and held close to one's consciousness during all phases and aspects of the practice of high magick. (See my forthcoming essay which adds to my discussion of *The Hermetic Tradition and God Presence*.) Therefore, right here as we begin to work with and expand our health, we seek to find and produce in ourselves the divine aspects of the four elements specifically as they relate to generating health, harmony, and balance in our bodies.

Some individuals obviously will have a natural gift or a great flair for accumulating vitality through breathing and using this power to heal themselves and others. Other individuals, such as myself, are more inclined to study the cosmic harmony first before pursuing the applications of magick. The progress is slower, less dramatic, but the skills acquired are a part of your personality--they serve to express your self and your ideals. The consequence is that in proceeding step by step in expanding our awareness of nature and divinity, we are able to find and know God and Divine Providence, as I suggest, during each phase and aspect of the practice.